CHENNAI - SATURDAY - MARCH 28, 2026

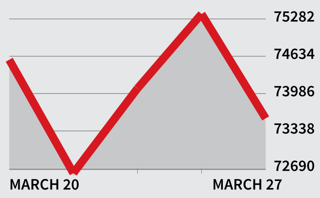
₹10 • Pages 12 • Volume 33 • Number 86

www.businessline.in

businessline thehindubusinessline

the hindu businessline.

SENSEX 73583.22 (-1690.23)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	22819.60	-486.85
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.22	-0.47
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.81	+0.84
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	142370.00	-3250
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	221647.00	-13167

POLLSCAPE. **Kerala should have** gained most from GST but gets low compensation, says VD Satheesan, Leader of the Opposition **p5**

AUTO FOCUS. **BMW 5 Series** shifts to comfort, prioritising luxury, space, practicality over driving focus **p4**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

IN CONTROL

‘No impending lockdown in India due to W. Asia war’

New Delhi: Parliament on Friday completed the budgetary exercise for the fiscal year 2026-27 as the Rajya Sabha returned the Finance Bill to the Lok Sabha. Meanwhile, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman strongly dismissed speculation about an impending lockdown in the wake of the West Asia war. **p7**

TURKEY BACKS OFF

India faces WTO investment pact heat

New Delhi: India’s fight to keep the China-backed Investment Facilitation for Development pact out of the WTO legal framework has got stiffer with Turkey, one of the three major countries initially objecting to it, formally withdrawing its opposition at the ongoing WTO MC14 in Yaounde, Cameroon. Now, the responsibility to safeguard the WTO’s “consensus-based architecture” falls mostly on India. **p12**

Centre cuts special additional excise on petrol, diesel by ₹10

DUTY REVISION. No change in retail prices; windfall gain tax reintroduced for refiners

Shishir Sinha
Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Offering relief to oil marketing companies amid rising crude oil prices due to the West Asia conflict, the Finance Ministry on Friday reduced the special additional excise duty (SAED) on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre with immediate effect, while reintroducing the windfall gain tax on export-bound diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) by refiners.

However, there is no change in the retail prices of petrol and diesel.

Also, there will be no reduction in the devolution pool as the basic central excise duty remains unchanged.

The government estimates a net loss of ₹5,500 crore in the first fortnight after adjusting for windfall tax gains.

Though the government has not given estimates for the whole year, economists expect the net loss to be between ₹1.5 lakh crore and ₹1.7 lakh crore.

The decision to revise the duty structure was taken at a meeting convened by the Prime Minister on Thursday.

Big relief (₹ per litre)

	Unbranded Petrol		Unbranded Diesel	
	Earlier	Now	Earlier	Now
Basic excise duty	1.4	1.4	1.8	1.8
Special additional excise duty	13	3	10	0
Agriculture infrastructure & development cess	2.5	2.5	4	4
Additional excise duty (road & infrastructure cess)	5	5	2	2
Total	21.9	11.9	17.8	7.8

Source: PPAC

PROTECTING CONSUMERS

“The government had two options — either pass on the increase to consumers (by way of an increase in the petrol and diesel prices) or take a hit (by cutting the excise duty). The government chose the latter,” Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said.

She added that the duties have been levied on diesel exports at ₹21.5 per litre and on ATF exports at ₹29.5 per litre.

Later, Chairman of the Central Board of Indirect Taxes & Customs Vivek Chaturvedi said the windfall tax on exports is expected to generate about ₹1,500 crore in the first fortnight, while the government will have to forgo over ₹7,000 crore in revenue because of the excise duty cut.

This could work out to a net loss of ₹5,500 crore.

EXPORT RATIONALE

Explaining the rationale for the levy of export tax in the form of an SAED, Chaturvedi said the surge in international prices had incentivised refiners to export, and this move will help ensure availability of fuel for domestic consumption.

He added that the export tax will be reviewed on a fortnightly basis, as was the practice earlier, to align the duty with the prevailing market rates.

Besides, the government has also mandated domestic refiners to supply 50 per cent of exported petrol and 30 per cent of exported diesel to the domestic market.

FISCAL BURDEN

Madhavi Arora, Chief Economist of Emkay Global, said that such a move will help in absorbing 30-40 per cent of annualised losses of the OMCs on auto fuel at current prices. “The annualised fiscal hit to the government would be ₹1.55 lakh crore owing to this burden sharing,” she said.

Meanwhile, DK Pant of India Ratings & Research said his estimates suggested that if the excise duty remains at the current level throughout FY27, it would cost the government ₹1.70 lakh crore.

More Reports on p2, p3

Iran war: ₹ closes at all-time low, bond yields harden, equities take a beating

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The raging war in West Asia continues to have a deleterious effect on the Indian financial markets, with the rupee closing at an all-time low, bond yields hardening, and equities taking a beating.

The rupee closed at a new low of 94.8125 per dollar, down about 84 paise against the previous close of 93.9775, amid rising global energy prices, FPI-related outflows from domestic equity markets, and a strengthening dollar.

Yields of Government Securities (G-Secs) hardened due to fears of the fiscal implications of the government’s move to reduce excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 each.

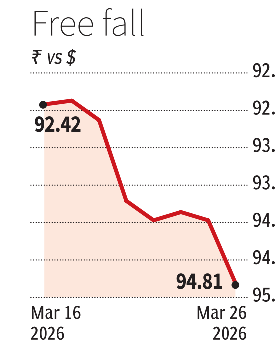
Yield of the 10-year benchmark bond (6.48 per cent GS2035) closed at 6.94 per cent, up 6 basis points over the previous close of 6.88 per cent.

The last time the 10-year G-Sec yield was at the 6.94 per cent level was in October 2024.

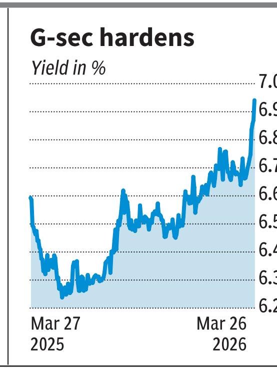
The equity markets are feeling the heat of the West Asia war due to the negative impact it will have on the economy and companies, even as FPIs continue to pull out. Amid worsening macro and slowing earnings growth, Goldman Sachs has lowered Indian equities to marketweight from overweight on less attractive risk/reward than North Asian markets.

Equity benchmarks BSE Sensex and NSE Nifty ended down 2.25 per cent (to close at 73,583) and 2.09 per cent (22,820), respectively.

Free fall



G-sec hardens



RUPEE VAULTS ABOVE 94

The rupee on Friday closed at 94.8125 per dollar, about 109 paise weaker against last Friday’s 93.72 close.

Since the beginning of the West Asia war, the rupee has depreciated about 4 per cent.

Yes Securities, in a report, noted that the Indian rupee fell to a record low, past 94 per dollar this week, pressured by energy supply concerns and foreign outflows. “The rupee has dropped about 4 per cent since the war began, putting it on track for its first fiscal year decline in over a decade. Rising energy costs are adding to inflation and growth concerns, keeping the near-term outlook weak,” per the report.

Impact of the government’s move to reduce excise duty on petrol and diesel to shield consumers and oil marketing companies from the global oil shock has raised concerns that the government may borrow more in FY27. G-Sec yields went up due to this.

With FPIs pulling out about $11.38 billion worth of investments from the Indian equity markets in March so far (up to March 27), the benchmark equity indices are sinking further.

Tata Motors shares fall 5.6% to 52-week low after JLR halts production at UK plant

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

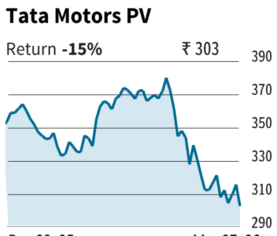
Tata Motors shares fell 5.6 per cent on Friday to a 52-week low of ₹301.10, after Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) halted production at its Solihull plant in the UK, triggering fresh concerns over supply disruptions and weak global demand.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles shares closed at ₹303.20 on the NSE. The stock reached an intra-day low of ₹301.05.

The plant, which produces high-margin models such as the Range Rover and Range Rover Sport, has paused output on select lines due to a supplier-related parts issue.

The disruption, alongside a pre-scheduled Easter shutdown, is expected to last until April 8.

Tata Motors PV



‘LIMITED IMPACT’

In a clarification to exchanges, Tata Motors said the disruption is “short-term and limited in scope” and does not expect any material impact on overall operations or financial performance.

JLR said it is working closely with the supplier to resolve the issue and minimise any impact on customers and operations.

The development is significant given JLR’s outsized role in Tata Motors’ financials, contributing nearly 70 per cent of consolidated revenue and remaining its primary earnings driver.

Analysts said the disruption adds to an already challenging backdrop, with demand, margins and external risks under pressure simultaneously. Demand in key markets such as China and the US remains subdued, analysts said, as macroeconomic headwinds weigh on sentiment for luxury vehicles.

MARGIN PRESSURE

Margins are tightening as JLR absorbs recent luxury tax hikes in China to defend market share, protecting volumes but weighing on profitability.

Rising marketing spends and higher US tariffs are adding to cost pressures, analysts said, pointing to growing geopolitical and fiscal risks.

Industry experts have noted that Friday’s decline suggests the Solihull disruption triggered a broader risk-off move in the stock, which had been under pressure amid concerns over slowing global luxury demand and the capital intensity of JLR’s electric-vehicle transition.

Despite near-term headwinds, Tata Motors continues to bet on JLR’s “Reimagine” strategy, with key launches planned for 2026, including the Range Rover Electric and a new Jaguar EV.

IPL ad rates go up by 25-30%, led by smart TV slots

Advertisers increase IPL spends, shifting focus towards targeted CTV platforms

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

As the 2026 edition of the Indian Premier League (IPL) kicks off in Bengaluru on Saturday, television advertising rates are up by 25-30 per cent compared to 2025. The higher ad rates are led largely by demand around smart TV or connected TV (CTV) slots, which offer a more interactive experience compared to linear TV.

Ad rates in terms of first ask have increased by 20 per cent for CTV to around ₹600 cost per mille (CPM), whereas linear TV ad rates went up 10 per cent from last year’s rates of ₹18-28 lakh, as per Nitro Commerce.

“While inventory volume is soaring, standard entry cost remains surprisingly stagnant. Even with targeting at ₹300 or premium CTV at ₹600, the ‘commodity’ ad space is no longer the primary battlefield,” said Umair Mohammed, Founder CEO of Nitro Commerce.

SMART SPEND. Advertisers prefer CTV over linear TV as it helps them reach a specific target audience ISTOCKPHOTO

TARGETED REACH

Advertisers prefer CTV over linear TV as it helps them reach a specific target audience. Linear TV, while more expensive in absolute terms, reaches an unsegregated audience, resulting in a lot of media spend wastage, according to experts. “Linear TV reaches everyone from metros to remote villages. CTV, by comparison, filters a more top-tier audience — consumers with broadband connections. So, a luxury brand may prefer to buy a more affluent audience via CTV,” said Lloyd Mathias, a business strategist.

AUDIENCE FOCUS

Modern brands focus on “moment marketing” like DRS, tickers, or the Super 4s and 6s. These slots capture peak psychological attention when viewers are most emotionally invested.

In this regard, CTV is more measurable with hard digital data as opposed to linear TV, which relies on TRP numbers. “CTV offers the premium audience, which Jio has been itching to leverage. Also, CTV is where the real battle for content is between Amazon, Netflix, Sony and Jio,” said Ajimon Francis, Managing Director at Brand Finance India.

Ultimately, IPL remains a “Go Big or Go Home” arena, said Mohammed.

The real financial weight lies in the massive ₹100-150 crore sponsorship deals.

On Thursday, JioStar announced 27 sponsors for 2026 with Google, Campa and Havells & Lloyd as the co-presenting sponsors.

Four weeks into crisis, exports to West Asia come to a near-halt

TRADE WOES. Exporters face payment issues; gas and input shortage hits production; freight rates skyrocket

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Four weeks into the widening West Asia conflict between the US-Israel alliance and Iran, Indian exporters are grappling with a compounding crisis as the disruption brings regional trade to a virtual standstill. Skyrocketing shipment costs to other destinations, payment issues and a domestic shortage of petroleum products and other imported inputs are adding to woes, they say.

"As much as 16 per cent of our exports go to West Asia but since March 1 exports to the region have virtually come to a standstill as no shipments are being dispatched and there is almost negligible air cargo," said Pankaj Chadha, Chairman, Engineering Export Promotion Council.

This is because the Strait of Hormuz, the primary gateway to the region, has been effectively blocked.

In FY25, India's total goods exports to West Asia were at $65.54 billion, accounting for about 15 per cent of the country's total exports. Shipments to other destinations being routed through the Cape of Good Hope have also taken a beating due to the increase in shipments costs by up to $2,000 per container, because of the re-routing, Chadha said.

ISSUES OF GRAVE CONCERN. Prolonged uncertainty and disruption in supply chains have started hitting several sectors, such as the leather and footwear industry

LIQUIDITY CRUNCH

Engineering units are also suffering due to a shortage of LPG and PNG required to run their furnaces and manufacturing has taken a hit, he added.

The crisis in the region is also leading to a liquidity crunch for exporters due to blocking of payments. "Our payments are stuck as money is not coming from West Asia. The importers claim that their economies are badly hurt so there is not much buying. They do not have any money to pay us. The situation is really bad," said Sanjay Jain, a major exporter of garments and textiles.

Prolonged uncertainty and disruption in supply chains have started hitting several sectors such as the leather and footwear industry reliant on petroleum derivatives. "For footwear, one needs many petroleum based products as inputs such as rubber, PUs, synthetic linings, etc. The prices for all these inputs have increased by 20-30 per cent, leading to at least 10 per cent increase in total production cost," said Israr Ahmed, a Chennai-based exporter of leather products.

"The continuing turbulence in West Asia and its resulting impact on raw material supplies, supply chains and industrial energy, is deeply concerning for the MSME-dominated textiles and apparel sector," said Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) Secretary General Chandrima Chatterjee.

While the relief measures already announced by the government offer some comfort, an early return to normalcy in West Asia is what is being hoped for as FY26 draws to a close, she said.

The depreciation in the value of rupee vis-a-vis the US dollar has not alleviated the situation much, pointed out Jain.

"The US dollar is rising. But a 3-4 per cent rise can't compensate for the increase in cost of manufacturing plus the high freight costs," he said.

High input costs, supply squeeze threaten farmers' kharif income

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Kharif fertilizer supply faces a reality check as the US-Israel-Iran war enters its fourth week. Despite official assurances, a shortage of natural gas and logistics bottlenecks are hitting urea production. With shipping routes diverted and no ceasefire on the horizon, the government's 'adequate stock' claim is being tested by the reality of a global energy and supply chain rupture.

Fertilizer Minister JP Nadda on Friday told Parliament that India has adequate reserves to provide fertilizers to farmers. "I want to assure the citizens that the government has taken steps to ensure fertilizer is available to farmers whenever required. We have sufficient reserves in place. There is no need to panic," he said.

As on March 23, India has 53.08 lakh tonnes (lt) of urea, 21.80 lt of di ammonium phosphate (DAP), 7.98 lt of muriate of potash (MOP) and 48.38 lt of complex (in combination of N, P, K, S nutrients) in stock. The industry is keenly watching how the stock position will be this year amid threat to domestic production.

In the last kharif season, the requirement of urea was estimated at 185.4 lt whereas the sales rose by 4 per cent to 193.2 lt. The demand for different fertilizers during kharif 2026 is yet to be estimated.

INDIA'S PRODUCTION

The government also said India has produced 24.23 lt of fertilizers — 13.55 lt of urea, 7.62 lt DAP/NPK and 3.06 lt SSP, during March 1-24, notwithstanding the gas supply crunch amid the West Asia crisis. To further augment supplies to the urea plants, an additional 7.31 MMSCMD of natural gas has been procured through bidding process for March 18-31, that is expected to increase gas availability to 80 per cent of their past six-month average consumption, from current 65 per cent supply.

According to Anand Chandra, Co-founder and Executive Director of Arya.ag, when fertilizer prices move globally, the first real impact is felt at the farmgate. For smallholders, even a 10-15 per cent hike in input costs can influence cropping decisions and directly affect income.

Officials said since key fertilizers' retail prices are capped in India, there may not be an impact, provided States able to check black marketing when supplies are strained. However, there are a number of non-subsidised fertilizers used by farmers and those can be affected from global price rise. They added that any increase in diesel or power costs will be an additional burden.

Chandra also said any increase in crude prices or supply shortfalls is likely to raise transportation costs, which then flows through the agri value chain. "This can soften demand in certain commodities or delay price transmission, further tightening realisations for farmers," he said, adding higher input costs and uncertain demand conditions can significantly strain farmer incomes in a single season.

Import concerns: India ups LPG output, focuses on PNG

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

PRODUCTION INCREASE. Domestic refinery production has now been ramped up by 40%, bringing daily LPG output to a record 50,000 tonnes

As the recent conflict in West Asia completes a month, the world's second largest importer of LPG has managed to navigate the black swan event so far by prioritising domestic production of the key cooking fuel, while focusing on encouraging as many as 60 lakh LPG consumers to migrate to piped natural gas (PNG).

The conflict — considered the biggest disruption in the history of global oil and gas markets — impacted India adversely, given that 60 per cent of its LPG requirement, 47 per cent of its liquefied natural gas (LNG) demand and roughly 30 per cent of crude oil needs transit the Strait of Hormuz, the 34 km-long world's most critical energy choke point.

The conflict led to a surge in global energy prices. While Brent crude oil prices have averaged at $98 per barrel in March 2026 so far (up to March 25, 2026), up from $68 in February 2026, the average price of the Indian basket of crude oil has risen significantly to $125.7 a barrel in the ongoing month from $69 in February 2026, ICRA said.

Besides, natural gas prices (JKM) have also risen quite sharply, surpassing $20 per mBtu on March 18, 2026, nearly double the levels seen a month ago, it added.

While India has "sufficient" stocks of crude oil, natural gas, petrol, diesel and jet fuel, it faces supply risk with respect to LPG imports. This is because India is importing 60 per cent of its domestic demand.

However, the government responded immediately to the issue and prioritised LPG production in refiners at the expense of petrochemicals by invoking the Essential Commodities Act.

Domestic refinery production has now been ramped up by 40 per cent, bringing daily LPG output to a record 50,000 tonnes, which is more than 60 per cent of India's requirement.

India's daily requirement is around 80,000 tonnes. This helped the net daily import requirement to decline to 30,000 tonnes.

LPG IMPORTS

Besides, the government has 80,000 tonnes of assured LPG import cargoes, which are en-route from the US, Russia, Australia and other countries, arriving across India's 22 LPG import terminals. This is equal to almost a month's supply.

Besides, Centre has also managed to check panic buying with OMCs successfully delivering over 50 lakh cylinders every day. Cylinder demand had gone up to 89 lakh cylinders due to panic booking, but has now come down to 50 lakh cylinders.

Commercial cylinder allocations have been raised to up to 70 per cent in consultation.

The government is also pushing for expansion of PNG and compressed natural gas (CNG) in the country, encouraging households and businesses to migrate to piped gas. City gas distribution (CGD) has expanded from 57 geographical areas (GAs) in 2014 to over 300 today. Domestic PNG connections have grown from 25 lakh to over 1.6 crore.

In terms of crude oil and petroleum products, the government is in a very comfortable position.

India has 74 days of total reserve capacity and actual stock cover is around 60 days right now (including crude stocks, products stocks and the dedicated strategic storage in caverns). Nearly two months of steady supply is available. Beside, another 2 months of crude oil imports have been secured.

FMCG firms coping with surging raw material costs

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

One month into the West Asia conflict, the FMCG industry is coping with surging packaging costs due to rising crude oil prices and rupee depreciation.

Rationalising of commercial LPG has also had some impact on production for some sectors. In categories such as edible oils, packaged water and paints, players have already begun taking price hikes.

Others said if the conflict continues, calls on price hikes will need to be taken by later next month.

A senior industry executive said, "Packaging material prices have gone through the roof. PET resin prices have now gone up to ₹143 per kg and is expected to cross ₹150 per kg by next week. This coupled with the rupee depreciation could mean the situation will worsen. Some price hikes have already been taken by the packaged drinking water industry such a ₹18 pack is now priced at ₹20. Prices may need to be hiked again if things worsen."

Meanwhile, Asian Paints, Berger Paints and Kansai Nerolac have already announced price hikes. Analysts believe paint players are likely to take a second round of price hikes if higher crude oil prices persist.

Edible oils players have also had to take price hikes due to heightened costs. Shrikant Kanhere, MD & CEO, AWL Agri Business said, "The edible oil prices are closely linked to crude oil. Due to the West Asia conflict, all the imported edible oil prices are already up by 10-15 per cent across the board and so that price increase is already reflecting."

FRESH HEADWINDS

A report by BNP Paribas noted that FMCG companies had seen improvement in demand trends in Q3 FY26 and were well poised for sustained growth in the coming 4-6 quarters. However, the West Asia conflict has led to fresh headwinds leading to concerns about rising costs, export order cancellation and LPG gas availability, it added.

Mayank Shah, Vice President of Parle Products, said, "Higher crude oil prices have led to higher packaging costs. Price of commercial LPG has also gone up and since there is rationing there have been some challenges. We are using alternatives wherever possible in our plants but there has been some impact on production on some lines. So, if all these issues persist, we will have to take a call on price hike towards the end of April or early May."

Shah said that the packaged food industry has also urged the government that in terms of allocations for commercial LPG, packaged food manufacturing plants should be considered essential.

Restaurants, hotels seeing lower revenues, higher costs

Our Bureaus
New Delhi/Chennai/Bengaluru/Mumbai/Kolkata

HARD TIMES. Despite the Centre's directive, restaurants continue to face LPG supply disruptions due to bottlenecks at the State levels

Restaurants, institutional food services companies and hotels have seen significant cost increases due to higher LPG costs as well as decline in revenues. With commercial LPG supplies remaining under pressures across the States, players have had to reduce operational hours, cut back on menu offerings or even resort to temporary closures. The hospitality industry is also facing headwinds due to decline in international tourism footfalls as well as headwinds in terms of MICE and wedding events.

Sanjay Kumar, CEO & MD, Rassense, which does catering for a large number of manufacturing facilities, said the commercial LPG costs are up nearly 3x for the company as availability remains constrained especially in southern and eastern regions.

"We are securing LPG supplies wherever possible at steep costs, while using boilers and other alternatives at factories and have also switched to firewood for central kitchens. We have cut back on menu items and switched to menu items that do not require gas-based cooking to save on costs," he added.

Despite the Central government's directive, restaurants continue to face LPG supply disruptions due to bottlenecks at the State levels, said Pranav Rungta, VP, NRAI. He added that in many cases the players are being forced to procure LPG in the grey market at significantly higher prices.

FOOTFALL DOWN

International tourist footfalls are also down for the hotel industry. Pradeep Shetty, VP, Federation of Hotel and Restaurant Associations of India (FHRAI) said, "City hotels are beginning to see revenue pressures with lesser occupancies. Fresh international travel is not happening. Even MICE and wedding events are being planned as per LPG availability. Resorts and smaller players have curtailed operations and switched to woodfire and other alternatives. In terms of commercial LPG shortage issue, things remain under pressure for restaurants, depending on allocations being made by states and piped gas connectivity."

Paritosh Ladhani, Co-Founder, Sincere Developers, noted, "There has been a significant impact on international tourist footfalls. During this month, there was a dip visible even in domestic tourism due to subdued consumer sentiment. However, we are seeing some signs of an uptick."

Venkada Subbu, President, Tamil Nadu Hotel Owners' Association, said that increase of commercial LPG allocation has not yet trickled down to restaurants. Items consuming more gas have been removed from menus, he added.

M Ravi, President, Chennai Hotels Association, and owner of Namma Veedu Vasantha Bhavan, also noted that agents continue to report shortage of LPG. With salaries, rent and bank loans to pay, it is "survival mode" and around 30 per cent of members have shut down.

According to Sudesh Poddar, President of the Hotel & Restaurant Association of Eastern India (HRAEI), large restaurants in Kolkata are now opting for electricity for at least 70 per cent of their daily energy usage, facing shortage and a high level of uncertainty over LPG supply.

Auto sector functioning at near normal levels

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

KEEPING WATCH. Auto majors are monitoring the situation on a daily basis, maintaining contact with suppliers too REUTERS

Almost one month into the war in the West Asia, automobile manufacturers on Friday said operations at plants are functioning near normal with active mitigation measures in place, and the companies are monitoring the situation on a daily basis, keeping in touch with suppliers too.

"We are working closely with our supplier and logistics partners to manage volatility and ensure continuity, while optimising production schedules wherever required. We continue to closely monitor and evaluate the potential impact of recent developments, including fuel availability and supply-chain challenges, on our manufacturing operations and the wider automotive ecosystem," spokespersons at Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles told *businessline*.

According to sources, the Ministry of Heavy Industries has also urged the original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) to shift their factory operations from oil-based fuels to electricity, and to use recycled aluminium or alternative materials as shortages and costs rise.

In the commercial vehicle segment, Tata Motors said the ongoing conflict in West Asia is impacting the broader commercial vehicle ecosystem as several critical production and supply-chain processes across the industry depend on stable transportation corridors and assured energy availability.

"Any prolonged disruption could have implications for operational continuity for markets such as Africa and particularly West Asia — where we are witnessing impact," a spokesperson at Tata Motors said.

Meanwhile, auto components players said they are monitoring the situation and are hopeful that the auto industry sails through this crisis at the earliest.

The Automotive Component Manufacturers Association of India (ACMA) said the companies are closely tracking the evolving US-Iran situation.

GOVT MEASURES

"While recent measures prioritising domestic fuel supplies have tightened availability for industry, we appreciate the government's responsiveness and continued engagement. With coordinated efforts to ensure stable energy access and diversify sourcing, we are confident the industry will navigate these near-term challenges while maintaining production continuity and growth momentum," Vinnie Mehta, Director General, ACMA, told *business-line*.

Queries sent to Maruti Suzuki India, Hyundai Motor India, JSW MG Motor India, and Mahindra & Mahindra remained unanswered.

Geopolitical tensions drive volatility in gold prices, hit domestic jewellery demand

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

A surge in geopolitical tensions in West Asia has jolted India's gold market, triggering sharp price swings and dampening both domestic buying and export demand at a critical juncture for the jewellery trade.

Gold prices, which had rallied for most of the month, have turned sharply volatile amid global uncertainty, while a weakening rupee and mounting logistical disruptions threaten to further squeeze imports. The combined impact is weighing on sentiment across the value chain, from retailers to exporters, as consumers turn cautious in the face of sudden price corrections.

Gold prices plunged by ₹3,263 or 2 per cent to ₹142,942 per 10 gm on Friday against ₹146,205 in line with the global trend, according to the Indian Bullion Jewellers and Association of India data.

In fact, gold prices have declined by ₹24,529 per 10 gm or 15 per cent in March due to uncertainty kicked off by the US-Israel attack on Iran.

SILVER PRICES

Similarly, silver prices have fallen to ₹221,647 per kg against ₹234,814 on Thursday. It dipped by ₹68,201 from ₹289,848 per kg on March 2.

Avinash Gupta, Vice-Chairman, All India Gem And Jewellery Domestic Council, said the ongoing West Asia conflict and the resulting volatility in global gold prices had created short-term uncertainty in jewellery demand.

However, Indian consumers continue to view gold and jewellery as a safe and trusted asset, especially during times of geopolitical tension, he added.

While retail sentiment has been cautious, the long term fundamentals of the industry remain strong, and traders expect the demand to stabilise as markets adjust to the new price levels, said Gupta.

Interestingly, gold has lost its safe-haven status amid the raging West Asia war and dipped along with other assets including equity markets.

The destruction of oil producing assets in West Asia has forced investors move their bets from gold to crude oil. The war has made it difficult to export bullion from Dubai where the flight operations have come to a standstill. This apart, the rupee depreciation has made the imports more costlier.

Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, said the rupee has depreciated to all-time low near 94.80 with Brent crude moving back to $110 a barrel and exerting renewed pressure on the rupee.

The currency is also facing headwinds from persistent FPI selling, with outflows crossing $13 billion this month and potentially matching the pace seen in March 2020, he said. The rupee depreciation will hold gold prices elevated compared to the global markets and this will further depress domestic demand.

Centre assures adequate fuel supply, rules out retail price hikes

EASING SHORTAGE. Govt approves additional 20% allocation of commercial LPG, prioritises industries

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi


PANIC BUYING. Consumers throng a petrol station in Thane PTI

Even as the oil marketing companies' (OMCs) under-recoveries rose by around ₹26 per litre on petrol and a steep ₹81.9 per litre on diesel, the government on Friday said there are "sufficient supplies" of the two key auto fuels with no plans by PSU OMCs to hike retail prices.

"The government had two choices: either increase prices drastically for citizens of Bharat as all other nations have done, or bear the brunt on its finances so that the Indian citizen is insulated from international volatility. Prime Minister Narendra Modi decided to take a hit on government finances to safeguard the Indian citizen. The government has taken a substantial impact on its taxation revenues to reduce the high losses being faced by oil marketing companies at this time of sky-high international prices," said Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

The global situation remains in flux, and the government is closely monitoring developments across energy, supply chains and essential commodities on a real-time basis.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas, said crude oil and petroleum products prices had risen in the global market. However, the government initiated several important decisions at different levels to manage the situation effectively.

SUPPLY INVENTORY

India has sufficient crude oil inventory, with supplies lined up for the next two months. The situation is also "comfortable" for LPG and PNG. Besides, refineries are operating at full or even above their capacity. Domestic LPG production has increased by almost 40 per cent hitting around 50,000 tonnes per day, she added.

Sharma said the current diesel and petrol prices have been lower or at similar levels since April 2022.

To compensate PMCs, government reduced excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre with immediate effect. The excise reduction is not being passed on as a price cut at the pump. It directly reduces the under-recoveries being absorbed by PSU OMCs.

At the current international crude prices, under-recoveries stand at ₹26 per litre on petrol and ₹81.90 per litre on diesel. The combined daily under-recovery being absorbed by OMCs is ₹2,400 crore. On supply inventory, Sharma assured that all refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, and sufficient stocks of petrol and diesel are being maintained. Besides, LPG production from refineries has been increased by 40 per cent to support domestic consumption.

Supply of LPG continues to be affected due to the prevailing geopolitical situation. No dry-outs have been reported at LPG distributorships. Delivery of domestic LPG cylinders continues as normal, she added.

COMMERCIAL LPG

On Friday, the government approved an additional 20 per cent allocation of commercial LPG, taking total allocation to 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, with priority to steel, automobiles, textiles, dyes, chemicals and plastics. Among this, priority shall be given to process industries or those requiring LPG for specialised heating purposes that cannot be substituted by natural gas.

Besides, more than 40,000 5-kg free trade LPG cylinders were sold on Thursday. Around 28 States/UTs have issued allocation orders for non-domestic LPG, while PSU oil marketing companies are supplying in remaining areas. About 29,656 tonnes of commercial LPG have been lifted since March 14, 2026.

Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General of CII, said, "CII and industry strongly welcome the government's calibrated and timely interventions to cushion the economy from energy price shocks. Measures on fuel pricing and LPG allocation will stabilise costs, sustain industrial operations, and protect households. Industry stands ready to partner closely to reinforce supply resilience and maintain economic stability in a volatile environment."

VISUALLY.

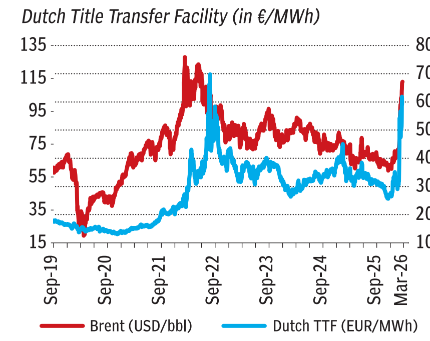
Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee** | Graphic **KS Gunasekar**

Why the reduction in SED

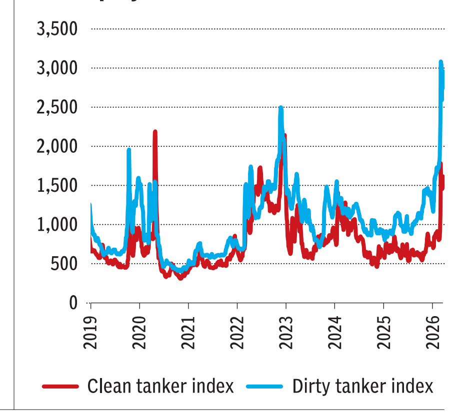
Since the start of the West Asia conflict, the price of Brent crude has gone from about $73/bbl to $109/bbl, a 49% hike. The Centre has reduced the special additional excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10/litre, to compensate the oil marketing companies (OMCs) from under recoveries due to price increase. Any reduction in excise duty is a fiscal-hit. However, any price absorption by OMCs should effectively also be viewed as a fiscal cost, as it erodes the dividends these companies would otherwise transfer to the government as revenue. Given this trade-off, the best fit in a protracted supply shock situation is near-equal distributional burden sharing by economic agents, with OMCs bearing the first leg of pain, followed by the government and eventually the end consumer

From the start of the West Asia conflict, Brent is up about 56%, while gas prices have risen by almost 85%

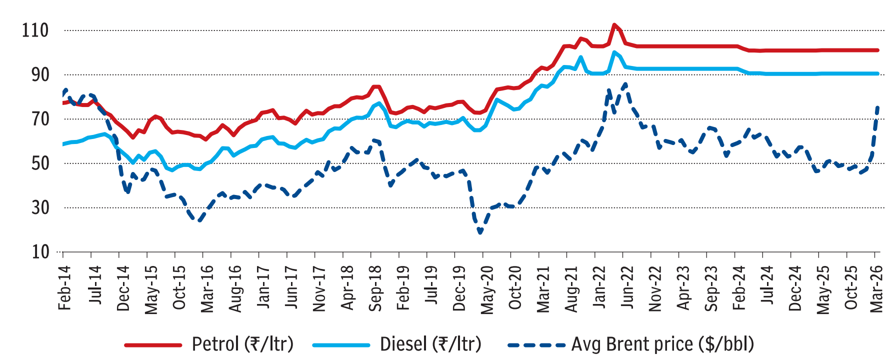
Price movement of Brent (in $/bbl) and Dutch Title Transfer Facility (in €/MWh)



Tanker freight rates have also shot up by about 80%

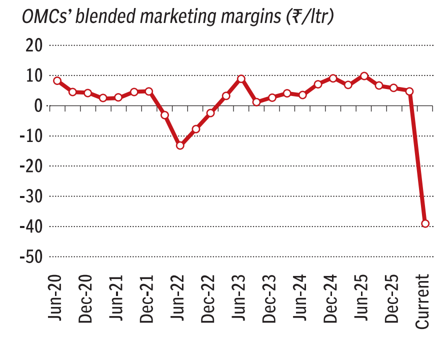


However, domestic pump prices have remained stable post-2022



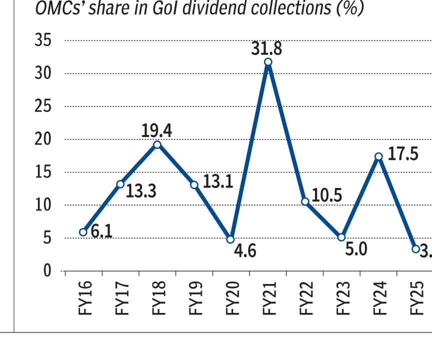
OMCs are staring at a huge margin-hit at current crude oil prices

OMCs' blended marketing margins (₹/ltr)



Protecting OMC margins is significant for government to maintain dividends

OMCs' share in GoI dividend collections (%)



Source: Emkay research

PM urges States/UTs to take strict measures against hoarding, profiteering


TAKING STOCK. Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairing a virtual meeting with CMs PTI

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday told the States to take strict action against hoarding. He also urged the States to accelerate efforts in promoting alternative energy.

He was speaking during a video conference with the Chief Ministers and Lieutenant Governors of the States and Union Territories to review preparedness considering the emerging situation arising out of recent developments in West Asia and its potential impact on India.

According to an official statement, the Prime Minister urged the States to ensure the smooth functioning of supply chains and to take strict measures against hoarding and profiteering. He highlighted the importance of activating control rooms at the State and district levels and maintaining administrative alertness to prevent disruptions.

ADVANCE PLANNING

"He also stressed the need for advance planning in the agriculture sector, particularly in monitoring fertilizer storage and distribution, so that farmers do not face difficulties during the upcoming kharif season," a statement said.

The Prime Minister highlighted that the situation remains dynamic, necessitating continuous monitoring and adaptive strategies. He said that an Inter-Ministerial Group had been operational since March 3, reviewing the situation on a daily basis and taking timely decisions.

He stressed that the government's priorities are to maintain economic and trade stability, ensure energy security, safeguard the interests of citizens, and strengthen industry and supply chains.

Emphasising the critical role of the States, he said effective implementation of decisions takes place at their level. He called for constant communication and coordination between the Centre and the States, along with timely sharing of information and joint decision-making, so that the responses are swift and well-aligned.

He urged the States to accelerate efforts in promoting alternative energy sources such as biofuels, solar energy, electric mobility, as well as expanding piped natural gas connections. He also highlighted the importance of enhancing domestic exploration of oil and natural gas, with active cooperation from the States.

'Refiners to continue selling 50% of petrol, 30% of diesel exports in domestic market'

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government on Friday clarified that the 2022 mandate for refiners to sell 50 per cent of their petrol exports and 30 per cent of diesel exports in the domestic market remains in force.

The Finance Ministry on Friday reimposed the windfall gain tax on aviation turbine fuel (ATF) exports with an effective levy of ₹29.50 a litre. Similarly for export-bound diesel, it would be ₹21.50 a litre. This has been done to check windfall gains made by refiners.

WINDFALL TAX

The windfall tax was first introduced in July 2022 following Russia's invasion of Ukraine and was withdrawn in December 2024.

During that time, the mandate for refiners to ensure that a certain percentage of their exports should be sold in the domestic market was enforced. However, the same was not rolled back and is still in force.

On rationale of the recent windfall tax, the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas said at a time when international diesel prices have surged sharply, the levy is designed to disincentive exports and ensure that refinery output is directed first towards meeting domestic demand.

Keeping Indian pumps fully supplied takes precedence over export opportunities, however commercially attractive those may be at current global prices. This decision is consistent with the approach adopted since the Russia-Ukraine conflict of 2022, when OMCs absorbed sustained losses and the government cut Central taxes to shield households and businesses from global price volatility, it added.

"The government will continue to monitor the evolving global energy situation and take all measures necessary to maintain supply stability," the Ministry said.

TAX REVIEW

- Finance Mininistry has reimposed the windfall gain tax on ATF exports with an effective levy of ₹29.50 a litre
- For export-bound diesel, it would be ₹21.50 a litre

Indian airlines face headwinds, ICRA revises outlook to negative

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai


WAR IMPACT. West Asia is an important market for Indian carriers and cancellations will impact revenue, says an expert

Indian airlines continue to face a double whammy of revenue loss arising from flight cancellations and increased expenses due to airspace closures and extended flight durations.

India carriers are not operating to Bahrain, Doha and Kuwait while offering limited services to Oman, Saudi Arabia and UAE. Geopolitical tensions have resulted in further weakening of the rupee, and domestic jet fuel prices are also expected to witness a sharp price revision from April 1.

IndiGo has said it may have to recalibrate its capacity based as the operating environment remains fluid. The airline said there is a material escalation in operating costs and fuel and forex-related costs expected to increase substantially. "While we have introduced a fuel surcharge to compensate for some of this cost, this and other fare increases required will have an effect on demand," IndiGo said.

"West Asia is an important market for Indian carriers and cancellations will impact revenue. This would have been a busy season for travel given Eid holidays in West Asia and school and college vacations in India," an aviation expert said.

Rating agency ICRA on Friday revised its outlook on the Indian aviation industry to negative from stable, citing cost pressures and downside risks to demand.

ICRA expects domestic air passenger traffic growth for FY26 at 0-3 per cent and international passenger traffic growth for Indian carriers at 7-9 per cent indicating a relatively weak near-term demand environment.

ICRA's earlier growth forecast for FY27, formulated prior to the West Asian conflict, estimated domestic air passenger traffic growth at 6-8 per cent and international growth at 8-10 per cent. However, these projections now carry a downward bias, the rating agency said.

Gujarat's Morbi ceramic units set to hike prices once production resumes

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad


IN DIRE STRAITS. Over 700 units are facing a 30-day shutdown due to gas shortages triggered by the ongoing West Asia conflict, impacting exports in a big way REUTERS

As the Iran conflict stretches close to a month, taking a visible toll on trade flows and energy supplies, over 700 ceramic units in Gujarat's Morbi cluster have shut down and are now preparing to increase prices when production resumes after a planned 30-day closure triggered by gas shortages and export disruptions.

Industry bodies have mandated a temporary shutdown as manufacturers grapple with constrained fuel supply and rising input uncertainties, prompting a coordinated strategy to restore margins once stability returns.

"Currently, only about 10 per cent of the units that continue to receive Gujarat Gas supply are operational. The rest 700-odd including the units producing sanitarywares have shut down," said veteran ceramic manufacturer from Morbi KG Kundariya.

Units dependent on alternative fuels such as propane were among the first to halt production, followed by others as existing gas allocations and stockpiles ran dry. Several units, including mid-size manufacturers, ceased operations as recently as March 24 after exhausting monthly supplies.

Kundariya shut his ceramic unit operating on PNG supplies from Gujarat Gas on March 24 after the stocks for the month were exhausted. This was the second unit to down its shutters after the first one using propane as fuel closed down in the first week of March immediately after the Iran conflict intensified and propane supplies ran dry.

JOB LOSS

The shutdown has significantly impacted employment in the region.

Of the roughly four lakh workers engaged in Morbi's ceramic ecosystem, over 60 per cent have returned to their villages. Those remaining are largely involved in maintenance activities or are awaiting clarity on reopening timelines. waiting clarity on reopening timelines. Manufacturers said the planned shutdown is also a tactical move.

"The idea is to stabilise operations and revise prices upwards when units reopen," Kundariya said, adding that prolonged cost pressures and supply disruptions had made current pricing unsustainable. Exports, a key revenue driver for the cluster, have been severely affected since the onset of the conflict. Shipments to Gulf countries were disrupted almost immediately, with logistical bottlenecks compounding the situation.

"Around 2,000 containers carrying export consignments worth approximately ₹102 crore were returned to Morbi after shipping lines declined to service key Gulf routes," Kundariya said.

Shipping costs have also surged, with some operators levying a war-risk surcharge of up to $3,000 per container for cargo in transit or awaiting loading at Mundra port.

In several cases, exporters were asked to pay additional charges to reposition containers that had been offloaded at intermediary ports.

An estimated 800 containers en route to Gulf destinations were diverted and unloaded at ports such as Nhava Sheva, Colombo and Salalah in Oman.

Industry players said there is limited visibility on the status of some consignments, particularly those routed through Salalah, adding to financial uncertainty.

TRADE DISRUPTION

Despite the disruption in Gulf trade, some manufacturers have continued exporting to alternative markets using existing inventory.

"Units are fulfilling orders to non-Gulf destinations from available stock, but fresh production is largely halted," said Manoj Arvadiya, President of the Morbi Ceramic Association's vitrified tiles division.

Industry stakeholders expect that a combination of resumed gas supply, easing geopolitical tensions, and inventory liquidation will shape the pace of recovery.

However, pricing is likely to firm up once operations restart, as manufacturers seek to offset losses incurred during the shutdown period and adapt to elevated logistics and fuel costs.

"Currently, we are focused on fulfilling the export orders. Apart from Gulf countries, we continue to export to Latin America and the rest of Asia," said Nilesh Jetparia, a ceramic manufacturer from Morbi whose both ceramic units that used to operate on propane have been shut.

Morbi manufacturers are expecting gas prices to also rise when supply resumes.

Goyal discusses trade issues with Chinese Minister

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday held a meeting with his Chinese counterpart Wang Wentao and discussed trade-related issues.

The bilateral meeting was held on the sidelines of the 14th ministerial conference in Yaounde, Cameroon. "Met Wang Wentao, Minister of Commerce of China, on the sidelines of the #WTOMC14. Exchanged views on the MC-14 agenda and discussed bilateral trade matters," Goyal said in a social media post. The meeting is important as India's trade deficit with China crossed $100 billion during the 11-month period of FY26.

CHENNAI
businessline.
SATURDAY - MARCH 28 - 2026

Plush Point

WHAT'S IN A NUMBER? The BMW 530Li M Sport is Munich's most credible attempt at taking on its arch nemesis, and it spells strong value

YASH GAWDE

Ruman Devmane

The BMW 5 Series has had it tougher in the past. Some years ago, the 5 Series had to shoulder the responsibility of delivering faultlessly as a driver's car, wearing its BMW emblem with a degree of seriousness. It was at a time when this class of sedans were the flag-bearers of their brand identity. You bought a 5 Series if you wanted to be seen as an enthusiast and an E-Class if you didn't.

The gradual evolution of the 3 Series and especially its performance derivatives (the M340i, for one), and the compact but spirited 2 Series have, however, taken this load off the 5. Today, it's free to hit the E-Class where it hurts the most. As a result, what BMW now sells you is the long-wheelbase version of the 5 Series. It's a car that offers a far superior backseat experience than it has ever been able to under that nameplate, and one that isn't as singular in its outlook as the versions that have preceded it.

Sure, purists will mourn the evolution of the 5 Series in this direction, but that's wasteful because what BMW has shaved off the 5, it has comfortably transplanted into the smaller and punchier M340i, a car that only nominally undercuts this ₹74.80-lakh (ex-showroom) 530Li. In other words, BMW hasn't forgotten how to make fast or fun cars, it's just changed priorities within the family. This was important in the case of the 5 Series, because the Mercedes-Benz E-Class' popularity isn't something it could afford to ignore.

As part of its latest update, the 5 Series has received a few fanciful additions, namely the Sky Lounge illuminated panoramic sunroof that creates a sort of patterned effect in an assortment of colours, adding a 'wow' factor to the cabin even if only at night. More importantly, it now gets really eye-catching 19-inch M wheels that complement its stance better than the outgoing 18-inchers and, additionally, also boasts what BMW calls the Driver Assistance Plus package. As part of this package, the 5 now gets features such as Active Cruise Control, Lane Keeping Assist and Blind Spot Monitoring. There are a bunch of collision avoidance systems, too, which, while unintrusive, can be turned off quite intuitively. The Bowers & Wilkins 18-speaker sound package, though not new, deserves mention for being punchy! And while there are enough 'M Sport' reminders in the form of badges, it isn't really an 'M' car in the traditional sense. The 530Li M Sport is also the only spec you can buy the regular 5 Series in, the alternatives being the electric i5 (₹1.19 crore) and the all-out performance-oriented M5 (₹2.05 crore). With the range and revisions explained, let's proceed to what the 5 Series actually feels like to drive — and to be driven in.

NEW ENOUGH. Updated safety-assists and 19-inch wheels that fill up the wheel wells admirably are among the 5's revisions. The cockpit is modern and the rear seats are comfy! YASH GAWDE

Seated behind the wheel, you get every impression of the 5 being a long car. The purist in me may have sulked at the ironed out 'power bulges' of yesteryear 5s, but I suppose that's a tell-tale sign of the 5's new character. Dominating your view instead is an expansive curved display, executed with a contemporary layout that'll sit well with the tech-inclined amongst you. While you do get the feeling of being enveloped by a lot of car and leather around you, it still feels like a luxuriously airy cabin thanks to the large windows, generally great space and, of course, the sunroof which, for all its shielding properties, I chose to draw shut. Okay, now it's really time to drive.

Steering the 5 feels pronouncedly light — not something you expect from a BMW — although I was thankful for it seeing as I had to extract it out of a rather tight parking space. Gather momentum and a strong first impression you get is an overall plushness — not a term the 5 has historically been associated with. You get the feeling that this is a big car that's designed, primarily, for comfort.

POSH SPICE

The 2.0-litre twin-scroll turbocharged petrol engine is smooth and linear, well-suited to the car's posh mannerisms, and while its 254.7-bhp output may seem conservative on paper, it can produce a surge of strong acceleration that will make your passengers a bit queasy. The 40.7 kg-m of torque BMW has extracted from its petrol motor impresses, too, and the 8-speed Steptronic gearbox is sprightly enough to keep pace with the engine's performance. Drive gently, though, and you will find the 5 performing with the same manner of decorum as an E-Class. Big deal, that. Look away, purists.

Even with its 19-inch wheels, the ride quality is really rather good and this remains the case even as the speeds go up. In fact, on an expressway stint, I found it to be perhaps a bit too soft, but switching to the backseat (where I duly napped for the better part of an hour) I didn't seem to mind it. In fact, it's the backseat that's the place to be in this car anyway. There's enough room to sprawl out and the seats are comfortable, although it offers neither an electric recline function or a 'boss' mode (the E-Class does), which I suppose explains its price tag but is undoubtedly a critical miss on BMW's part.

On the front of overall practicality, the 5 continues to impress. Be it the ease of parking, ample in-cabin storage, a large-enough boot under the floor of which sits an 18-inch space-saver (the stock tyre size is 245/45 R19) or its 60-litre fuel tank that is good enough for roughly 500 km of uninterrupted driving in a mixed cycle, the 530Li is a well-configured car that will convincingly let you experience luxury in a flavour that still is BMW, even if subtly so.

An easy choice to make in this class, then? On objective grounds, absolutely. Here's a well-rounded car for those of you who still prefer a sedan over an SUV (or maybe you already have two of those!) and its price tag certainly adds to its appeal.

Of course, buying a car of this league in India isn't merely a function-based choice; prestige, badge value and even nostalgia, as personal as these factors may be, do play a strong role in your decision-making. In which case, all I can say is, there hasn't been a better time to buy yourself a swanky sedan. Spoilt for choice, aren't you?

@TheMotorGram

QUICKLY.

Lexus ES 500e EV launched at ₹89.99 lakh

Japanese luxury carmaker Lexus has entered India's EV space with the launch of the ES 500e sedan. Based on the eighth-generation ES, it features a 74.7-kWh battery with dual electric motors producing 338 bhp and 44.6 kg-m, along with an all-wheel drive. The luxury sedan offers a claimed range of up to 580 km and can be charged from 10 to 80 per cent in 28 minutes.

Bimota unveils the custom KB399 overseas

The bespoke Italian company has developed its version of the Kawasaki Ninja ZX-4RR with uprated components and styling inspired by the bigger Bimota KB998 Rimini. While the performance numbers haven't been revealed, the standard 4RR makes 78.9 bhp and 3.9 kg-m. Bimota has added an Akrapovic exhaust as standard, along with Showa SFF-BP USD forks and BFRC-Lite rear shock and Brembo Stylema brakes. Other changes include carbon fibre bodywork and billet aluminium components.

2026 Hyundai Exter available at ₹5.80 lakh

The refreshed micro-SUV now comes with updated styling and features, with a stronger focus on safety. Hyundai has made changes to the front bumper, added beefier claddings and a new C-pillar garnish. New features include an armrest for the driver's seat, metal pedals, USB-C ports for rear passengers and wireless Apple CarPlay and Android Auto via a portable adapter. It continues with the same 1.2-litre engine with a manual transmission, an automated manual transmission and petrol + CNG options.

@TheMotorGram

Show and Tell

TRUMP CARD. The Harley-Davidson Breakout is as American as motorcycles get. Excessive, bold, shiny and quite loud, too!

YASH GAWDE

ODDS AND ENDS. A fat 240-section rear tyre is almost the Breakout's centrepiece. Ultra-low ground clearance means it scrapes everywhere. Also, the headlight has an odd shape YASH GAWDE

Ruman Devmane

Who thought Harley-Davidsons could be practical? No, the Breakout isn't, but it makes every other Harley seem that way. Here's a motorcycle that's aimed squarely at those who want to make a style statement in big, sparkly letters, even if you only venture as far as down the block from where you live.

A sort of factory-built chopper, the Breakout 117 is a proper 10-gallon hat tip (or whatever is the Milwaukee equivalent) to the American custom motorcycle culture so popularised through television programming even in India.

To frame it differently, this isn't a motorcycle you can travel with — not comfortably anyway. It's a statement piece and it's priced that way, too. At ₹31 lakh (ex-showroom, Delhi), the Breakout asks for serious money, although it also saves you the trouble of building a Harley-based chopper if that's something you've always fancied. Full disclosure: This isn't the latest of the Breakout range either. There's already a 2026 model around in the US although it is only expected to arrive in India towards the end of this year.

With that established, I can tell you about what riding it feels like. It seems heavy, long, low and a bit cumbersome at first, but if you have any experience with large-displacement Harleys you'll adapt to it quite quickly. Unlike in most Harleys, where a big chrome-laden V-twin engine is often the centrepiece, the Breakout has two — the engine and an incredibly wide rear tyre. An exaggerated rear end is the signature of every authentic chopper and Harley hasn't held back with that 240-section 18-inch Michelin Scorcher. At the front, you get a relatively skinny 130-section 21-inch tyre.

MUSCLE POWER

In my short stint with it, I rode it through outrageously slow traffic at first, where two things came to the fore — this is a heavy motorcycle (upwards of 300 kg) and it can get quite hot. This isn't news to those acquainted with the Harley-Davidson way, of course, and I don't grudge it that either. Because when the road opens up, the Breakout is surreal in how playful it is. The 100 bhp and 17.1 kg-m its 1923 cc 45-degree V-twin produces somehow overwhelms a contact patch as large as that and, combined with the analogue and distinct exhaust note its twin-stacked pipes emit, the Breakout can get quite addictive. I suspect Breakout buyers won't leave those stock exhaust pipes unattended for too long, though. It's meant to be an attention magnet, after all.

Ergonomically, you can trust it to grow on you. It's not a naturally comfortable bike on most counts; the weight, steering effort, heavy clutch action and limitations of the suspension are all compromised in favour of form and, equally, its bold performance. It isn't hateful either, though. Spend enough time with it, work out a riding routine and you'll find it to be a flavourful machine you'll eventually move into your living space or customise even further. As you do. On another note, the brakes are strong and progressive, the tyres do more than just look good and the seat is quite comfortable. I like the tiny digital display incorporated into the handlebar clamp and loathe the absurdly-shaped headlight, which has been replaced with a proper circular unit in the 2026 model. Objectivity isn't what the Breakout is about, or even attempts to acknowledge it. Even so, does it justify its price tag? Hard to say. If you ask me, for once, I wish Donald Trump had his way so we could all have cheaper Harleys. Until then, we can dream about them anyway. One thing's for certain, though. There's nothing else like it out there.

@TheMotorGram

‘We will launch 27 aviation projects if we win’

ALL SET. For the first time, an Opposition has done its homework and prepared alternative programmes for the future: VD Satheesan

bl.interview

Chitra Narayanan
V Sajeev Kumar
New Delhi / Kochi

Kerala’s Opposition leader and senior Congressman VD Satheesan says the party is ready with an economic plan to lift the State out of its severe financial crisis.

“For the first time, an Opposition has done its homework and prepared alternative programmes for the future to combat the failures of the present government,” he said, stressing that we will see a *puthuyuga* (new age) Kerala.

Edited excerpts:

> Kerala is a consumer State. It should have been the number one beneficiary in India for GST. Unfortunately, we are getting very low compensation
>
> **VD SATHEESAN**
> Leader of the Opposition

Are you confident that UDF will win 100 seats?

We will come back with 100-plus seats. That is our prediction, and it is on the basis of history.

In almost all the States, the Opposition has been losing byelections, but we won here in Kerala with double, triple margins in all byelections. We also won the elections to the local bodies.

In the Parliamentary election, we won 18 out of the 20 seats. First, there is a huge anti-incumbency sentiment. Second, we have been exposing the government for a long time on its failures.

At the same time, two years ago, for the first time in India, an Opposition started to research and work on alternative programmes. Our promise is that wherever the government fails, we will give you alternative projects.

Our narrative has been that in healthcare, Kerala is on the ventilator. We conducted a health conclave in 2025, in which more than 300 doctors from India and abroad participated, and then we presented a very good health document.

In higher education, our narrative was that brain drain is happening in Kerala and within five years, Kerala will be an old age home. Then we produced a very good report on how to prevent the large exodus by improving our education systems.

Our assessment is that the nature of jobs has been changing across the world. So, corresponding to that, we have to restructure the curriculum.

For start-ups, too, we have prepared a very good document that talks of providing management mentors, techno mentors and a revolving fund. We have talked of dream projects such as coastal shipping. We have a 600-km-long coast line and two international seaports, one container terminal and 17 mini ports.

We have declared that we are going to start coastal shipping and cruise shipping. Then we have four international airports, two of which are under the government. We will start 27 aviation projects if we win.

What about attracting investments to the State?

We are inviting ideas, we want to showcase more than 1,000 projects in various sectors. Investors will be treated as state guests, as will the NRIs, the backbone of the Kerala economy through the remittances they send. 10 per cent of the NRI remittances will be channelised for infrastructure development through PPP projects; the government will only be a facilitator.

But Kerala is almost bankrupt, how will you restore the coffers?

I have made a presentation as the leader of the Opposition before the 16th Finance Commission. The commission appreciated it because of the homework we have done. Number one plan is to introduce a planned tax administration, then we will cover all the leakages from the Treasury; then we will stimulate the economy through projects.

Kerala is a consumer State. It should have been the number one beneficiary in India for GST. Unfortunately, we are getting very low compensation.

Do you think Sabarimala will be a central issue in this election?

It will be a major issue because 2019 onwards gold pilferage was happening, and the court has clearly mentioned that the *dwarapalaka* idols were sold to a millionaire.

The CPM and the government have protected all three senior leaders involved in the issue and have not taken any disciplinary action against them.

Everyone wants to know who will be chief minister if the UDF comes to power...

That is the narrative of the CPI(M) because you know in Karnataka and Telangana, there was no chief ministerial candidate. After the Karnataka election, Siddaramaiah*ji* became the CM. Similarly, Revanth Reddy became the CM in Telangana. We are united. We are working together.

So, will the selection be from Kerala or the high command?

It will be from the high command after taking the opinion of the elected MLAs. That is the procedure. For the last several years, the Congress has not projected any chief ministerial candidate anywhere in India.

This factor of the Gandhi family representing Wayanad in Parliament — how much will this help UDF in State politics?

It will help a lot. Because Malayalis like the Gandhi family very much. They treat both Rahulji and Priyankaji as their children.

The five guarantees that Rahul Gandhi announced — where are the funds for that?

The insurance scheme is very good because in our health document we made it clear that Kerala is the number one State that has high out-of-pocket expenses.

That is why we have examined the insurance scheme implemented by the Rajasthan government when Ashok Gehlot*ji* was Chief Minister.

It was a very good project. As for free bus rides for women, I don’t think that after one year, there will be any burden on the government side; we also have a plan to make KSRTC self-reliant.

QUICKLY.

BALANCING ACT. Umesh Rai, BJP candidate from Howrah Uttar Assembly constituency, addressing locals during a campaign, ahead of the West Bengal elections, on Friday PTI

AIADMK announces second list of candidates

Chennai: The All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) on Friday released the next instalment of candidates for the upcoming polls. The AIADMK has renominated 30 sitting MLAs in its second list. Overall, the party has renominated 46 MLAs among the candidates announced so far. With this, the party has announced 150 of the 169 seats that it is set to contest in the upcoming polls. While women candidates were missing in the first list, the second list includes 17 women, including Saroja Elangovan (Thuraiyur), Leema Rose Martin, wife of lottery baron Santiago Martin (Lalgudi), Maragatham Kumaravel (Madurantakam) and Ilamathi Subramanian (Thiruvidaimaruthoor), among others. Interestingly, the majority of the remaining seats for which the candidates are yet to be announced are those in Chennai city. As far as Chennai constituencies go, the AIADMK candidate has been announced only for Royapuram (D Jayakumar), and contenders for 12 more constituencies are yet to be announced. Some of the prominent players who find a place in today’s list and sitting MLAs include Senthilkumar (Vaniyambadi), Ashok Kumar (Krishnagiri), Pollachi Jayaraman (Pollachi), Udumalai Radhakrishnan (Udumalai) and Dalavai Sundaram from Kanniyakumari. Among the keenly watched contests is Gobichettypalayam, which is likely to be between AIADMK contender Prabhu and former AIADMK member KA Sengottaiyan, who is now with the TVK. Meanwhile, former Union Minister GK Vasan also named his party candidates for the five constituencies allotted to his Tamil Maanila Congress (TMC-M). The IJK, helmed by ex-MP Pariventhar, also named its nominees for two Assembly segments. OUR BUREAU

Actor Vijay’s rally in Chennai faces hurdles

Chennai: In a blow to its maiden campaign in Chennai ahead of the Assembly polls, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) alleged that the Chennai Police had denied permission for Vijay’s rally in Perambur on Saturday. “The planned campaign by TVK has been obstructed by the Chennai City Police Department and certain officials, which constitutes a fascist attack on democracy,” said the party in a social media post on Friday evening. “While permission for the event was sought two days prior to the event on March 26, the Chennai Corporation has suddenly dug a trench at that location and erected iron barricades... In this situation, the police conducted an inspection, and stated that 3,000 people could not gather there. Based on this, permission has now been denied on the grounds that the location is not suitable for campaigning,” said the official account of the party. “This very obstruction serves as evidence of the extent to which the DMK fears the TVK. Therefore, it is certain that the people of Tamil Nadu will send the ‘anti-democratic’ DMK regime back home in the upcoming Assembly elections,” it added. Chennai District Election Officer and GCC Commissioner J Kumaragurubaran said political parties or individuals must apply on the Election Commission’s Suvidha Portal 48 hours before the rally for permission, along with necessary approvals from the PWD and the police department. OUR BUREAU

War of words between Cong, CPI (M) in Kerala

Kochi: The political battle in poll-bound Kerala is intensifying, with a war of words erupting between the CPI(M) and the Congress. Countering remarks made by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan at Kothamangalam, AICC General Secretary KC Venugopal on Friday alleged that Vijayan was wary of the growing influence of Rahul Gandhi in the State and was avoiding criticism of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Criticising the Chief Minister for repeatedly targeting Gandhi, Venugopal said Vijayan was aware of Gandhi’s strong appeal among Kerala’s electorate. He also alleged that Vijayan’s reluctance to speak against the Prime Minister stemmed from an understanding with the Centre on issues such as PM SHRI and labour codes. Venugopal pointed out that other Chief Ministers, including MK Stalin, were actively raising State demands, securing funds and opposing divisive politics, while Vijayan remained “focused only on targeting Rahul”. V SAJEEV KUMAR

CANDIDATE PROFILE

Will Martin hit the jackpot in Puducherry?

Rohan Das
Chennai

After years of bankrolling political campaigns, Jose Charles Martin, the son of lottery baron Santiago Martin, has now entered the arena himself.

The businessman-turned-politician, whose company was the largest political donor through the now-scrapped electoral bonds route, is garnering eyeballs in the 2026 Puducherry Assembly polls.

Martin will contest from the Kamaraj Nagar constituency in Puducherry after his nomination was accepted by the EC. He had filed nominations for both the Kamaraj Nagar and Nellinthope constituencies.

After a few years with the BJP, which he quit citing issues with the local leadership, Martin launched a new political party, the Latchiya Jananayaga Katchi (LJK), in 2025, which he fashioned from his welfare outfit, JCM Makkal Mandram.

The party has now been taken into the NDA fold, being allotted two seats in the upcoming election. Martin will contest from the Kamaraj Nagar constituency in Puducherry after his nomination was accepted by the EC.

TOTAL ASSETS

While his party may be making a modest opening in Puducherry, the businessman’s deep pockets stand out among other candidates in the fray.

In his affidavit, he disclosed assets worth ₹597 crore, including movable and immovable assets.

This includes around 4.5 per cent stake in Future Gaming and Hotel Services,

Jose Charles Martin

the lottery company his father founded, cars worth about ₹2 crore, jewellery valued around ₹72 crore and ₹32 crore in watches.

He also owns land and property of about ₹450 crore, and his debts amount to ₹210 crore.

Interestingly, Jose is just one of the several Martin family members in the poll fray this time.

His mother, Leema Rose Martin, will contest from Tamil Nadu’s Lalgudi constituency in Tiruchirapalli district on an AIADMK ticket.

His brother-in-law, Aadhav Arjuna, is, however, more prominent in the political arena as the general secretary of actor Vijay’s Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) and a close acquaintance of the actor.

In terms of ideology, Martin earlier called out the ruling NDA alliance for operating like a syndicate and failing to provide basic necessities. He stated that his focus will be on people-first development, along with business-oriented efficiency, aiming to transform Puducherry into a global hub.

Kerala sees unusual wave of defections

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

While shifting loyalties is common in electoral politics, the defection of long-serving legislators to rival camps and their decision to contest against former allies has traditionally been rare in Kerala. However, the run-up to the 2026 Assembly elections is witnessing a noticeable departure from that trend.

Aisha Potty

G Sudhakaran

‘LEFT’ OUT

At least six former legislators have switched sides and are now in the fray under the banners of parties they once opposed vehemently. Of them, four leaders from the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and two from the Communist Party of India (CPI) have severed ties with their parties, with several aligning either with the Congress or the BJP.

A prominent defection is that of Aisha Potty, a three-time CPI(M) MLA from Kottarakkara, who ended her long association with the party in January. Her differences with the party were reportedly began after she was replaced by KN Balagopal, the current State Finance Minister, in the constituency. The Congress has fielded her from Kottarakkara.

Her entry into the Congress triggered dissent, leading to the exit of R Resmi, Mahila Congress General Secretary and the party’s previous candidate. Resmi has since joined the BJP, and will now contest against both Balagopal and Potty.

S Rajendran, a three-time CPI(M) MLA from Devikulam, has also joined the BJP after prolonged differences with the party, and is contesting from the same constituency.

Another senior leader, former Public Works Minister G Sudhakaran, left the CPI(M) after being sidelined following the party’s decision to enforce an age limit of 75 years. A four-term MLA, he is set to contest as an independent candidate from Ambalappuzha, where the Congress is unlikely to field a candidate, though the BJP has entered the fray.

Former CPI(M) legislator PK Sasi also quit the party and is contesting as independent candidate from Ottapalam.

From the CPI, former MLAs K Ajith and CC Mukunadan have joined the BJP, and are contesting from Vaikom and Nattika.

A SERIOUS THREAT

This alarming and unprecedented drain of veterans, mainly from the LDF, should serve as an eye opener since it is a serious threat to the much-boasted cadre character of the Left parties. Interestingly, most of the defectors appear to have found a safe haven in the BJP, which has shown no qualms about welcoming them.

But whether these deserters will end up as just refugees in the NDA camp or prove to be prize catches for the BJP-led national alliance is a tricky question.

The same is the case with those who have defected to the UDF camp, either for political asylum or for electoral support for their independent candidature.

The answer to this vexed question depends on the outcome of the polls and the changes that are likely to happen in the post-poll political equations.

A CHAIN FOR CHANGE

SPREADING THE MESSAGE. Students of The New College in Chennai form a human chain as part of an awareness initiative by the Election Commission, urging the public to ensure 100 per cent voter turnout in the upcoming Assembly elections RAGU R

Sleuths launch crackdown in Kerala to seize unaccounted cash

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

Sleuths from the Enforcement Directorate, the Financial Intelligence Unit, Customs, the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence and the Income Tax department have intensified vehicle checks to curb the movement of unaccounted cash.

The scale of the crackdown was evident when cars were flagged down in Thiruvananthapuram by a joint team of uniformed personnel and plainclothes men. Officers asked the occupants to open doors to conduct a thorough inspection, checking the dashboard, seats and even the undercarriage.

SENSITIVE PERIOD

Wallets were examined and residential addresses verified, with even the drivers not being spared scrutiny.

Each Assembly constituency has three flying squads and five static surveillance teams deployed at random locations.

Personnel have been drawn from outside the State as well, including from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, particularly for the ED and DRI units. The State police and the CRPF are assisting in the drive.

“You never know what a vehicle might be carrying. Cash or contraband can be planted without the owner’s knowledge. Vehicles can be tracked and details passed on to handlers elsewhere to retrieve the parcels,” said an officer on duty, requesting anonymity.

At the same time, officials stressed that care is being taken to avoid harassment. A family of four, including children, was seen being treated courteously and allowed to proceed after their identity and travel details were verified.

“We do not want to inconvenience families unless there is suspicion or specific intelligence. We act when there is reason,” said the officer. At least 15 agencies are currently involved in the State-wide surveillance effort, targeting unaccounted or illicit money.

Officials said no carrier will be spared, whether moving funds for election purposes or for business transactions.

So far, ₹2.1 crore in cash has been seized in the State, while gold, valuable gifts and contraband together are estimated to exceed ₹30 crore.

Officials clarified that no questions will be asked for carrying cash up to ₹50,000. Purchases exceeding ₹10,000 must be supported by valid bills or invoices. Cash above ₹50,000 requires proof such as bank withdrawal slips, while amounts exceeding ₹10 lakh must have clearance from the Income Tax department, in line with norms communicated by the Reserve Bank of India to the Election Commission.

Seized cash will be returned upon verification of valid documentation. A special drive along the national highway in Thrissur recently led to the seizure of ₹62.5 lakh in cash.

The carrier claimed the money was meant for a business transaction and not for election funding.

Residences and neighbourhoods of prominent leaders are also under surveillance amid concerns over the distribution of inducements. The I-T department, which has set up a 24x7 control room in Kerala, said enforcement will be non-discriminatory, including towards political parties.

thehindubusinessline.
SATURDAY - MARCH 28, 2026

Hard choices

Centre's oil excise duty cut, a balancing act

For a country that imports 85 per cent of its crude oil requirements, it goes without saying that a sharp rise in global prices will impact inflation, growth, fiscal deficit and current account deficit. The stakeholders here are the users (consumers, businesses and agriculturists), the government and the oil marketing firms. They lose out on incomes/revenues and costs/prices. There is an equilibrium of sorts in place between these stakeholders, if global crude oil prices are well below $70 a barrel.

This has been cruelly disrupted by the recent spurt in prices from $70 a barrel to over $120, since the Iran war began. As a result, oil companies are losing ₹24 a litre on petrol and ₹30 a litre on diesel, as their costs have shot up, without retail prices changing, eating into their refining and marketing margins. The Centre has protected the consumers and oil companies by virtually scrapping the special additional excise duty — from ₹13 per litre of petrol to ₹3 and from ₹10 to nil in the case of diesel – and taking the hit. Analysts expect a ₹1.55 lakh crore loss to the exchequer or about a 10 basis points rise in the fiscal deficit if the reductions remain in place the whole of FY27. To be sure, the consumer needs protection from inflation to keep domestic demand going at a time when growth will take a hit on the net exports side. There can be no escaping a pass-through of inflation through other commodities on account of price and exchange rate shock. Both the Centre and States have future rising expenses to contend with (on account of fertilizer subsidy and other relief measures in the event of the war dragging on), and cannot be expected to forgo too much excise revenue. An increase in pump prices of fuels looks unavoidable, if the war drags on for, say, another month. Costs will be borne by governments (higher deficits), consumers (higher prices), oil companies (reduced earnings) and businesses in some proportion.

The October 2025 Monetary Policy report of the Reserve Bank of India observes that if crude oil prices rise by 10 per cent "above the baseline" (presumably the stakeholder equilibrium price), and assuming full pass-through to domestic product prices, inflation could turn out to be higher by 30 basis points and growth may be lower by around 15 basis points. If the price rise is absorbed by the Centre, the fiscal deficit will rise. As the Chief Economic Adviser, V Anantha Nageswaran said before the House Panel on Finance, the worries begin if oil prices stay at above $90 a barrel for two or three quarters. At $130 a barrel, the current account deficit can rise to 3.2 per cent of GDP, the fiscal deficit to 5.6 per cent of GDP and inflation to 5.5 per cent; growth may fall 100 basis points to 6.4 per cent. This is a grim situation. The government needs to respond nimbly by securing energy supplies from Russia and Iran. There can be no escaping the price shock, but at least the supply shock can be mitigated. Meanwhile, long term energy security needs attention.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

The war poses bigger questions for Beijing

For years, official Chinese rhetoric on Iran invoked their shared historical status as grand civilisations that have struggled against western aggression. Bilateral ties date back more than half a century. In 2021, they signed a comprehensive strategic agreement pledging $400bn of Chinese investment. And China's economy is already flagging; it has just set its lowest growth target since 1991, underlining the importance of stability for Beijing. So its muted response since the US and Israel launched their war is striking. Beijing condemned the attack, but it was Washington that postponed the summit between their leaders because of the conflict. As Gulf states that previously mediated back away, China shows no interest in stepping up. LONDON, MARCH 26

讀賣新聞 THE YOMIURI SHIMBUN

Data Centers: Develop Facilities with Regional Revitalization

Amid the spread of generative artificial intelligence, data centers have become a critical part of infrastructure that supports a digital society. Efforts should be made to spread out such facilities across the nation to prevent them from being concentrated in specific areas. Data centers are facilities that house large numbers of servers and handle data storage and processing via the internet. These facilities lead to the vitalization of economic activities, including those in related industries. The United States — where tech giants such as Amazon, Google and Microsoft have a significant presence — is the global leader in the data center field. According to the Internal Affairs and Communications Ministry, there are more than 5,000 data centers in the United States, while Japan only has a little over 200. Furthermore, data centers in Japan tend to be concentrated in major urban areas, and that has become an issue. TOKYO, MARCH 27

Grim future for world economy

BLEAK OUTLOOK. With limited fiscal and monetary space to combat stagflation, recession looks a distinct possibility

DHANANJAY SINHA

The global economy is vacillating between sharply swinging narratives from the US administration under President Donald Trump and responses from Iran. Markets have reacted with volatility, oscillating between expectations of an imminent ceasefire and fears of prolonged confrontation. Investors are struggling to price in the long-term implications beyond immediate headlines.

In the immediate term, the announcement of a five-day war interregnum (now extended to 10 days) from the US side has provided some respite for markets. Yet it remains uncertain whether this pause can evolve into a lasting amicable resolution.

Historically, the US has rarely accepted outright submission in armed operations of this nature. The current context makes any decision to de-escalate even trickier, as America stands at a critical inflection point where its global hegemony, both economic and geopolitical, is visibly eroding. The stated objectives of the operation in Iran, including regime change, full control over nuclear capabilities, and access to oil reserves, remain largely unfulfilled. Given the asymmetric nature of the conflict, Iran retains leverage through its ability to disrupt oil supplies and maintain elevated prices, using these as bargaining tools to extract concessions.

Even in a scenario of quicker de-escalation, disruptions to crude and gas supplies, along with damage to infrastructure in the Strait of Hormuz region, will take considerable time to repair. Consequently, it is reasonable to assume that oil prices may remain elevated for longer than many market participants currently anticipate.

Irrespective of how the war fares, efforts to combat the growth and inflation fallouts are likely to be actively considered. Wars have historically been followed by lagged economic rebounds, often fuelled by substantial government spending on reconstruction, infrastructure, and defence.

However, in the current environment, such efforts face significant headwinds from peak levels of public debt and the pressing need for higher defence budgets, which constrain fiscal space for other forms of stimulus. Stagflation is imminent, with demand compression and recession as a likely outcome.

Borrowing costs have risen due to structural factors including declining global savings rates and early signs of de-dollarisation pressures, while bond markets demand higher risk premiums for sovereigns with record debt burdens.

TOUGH CHOICES. Commitments to defence, infrastructure, and entitlements leave limited room for additional large-scale stimulus GETTY IMAGES

According to the Institute of International Finance (IIF) Global Debt Monitor, global debt surged by nearly $29 trillion during 2025, pushing the worldwide total to a record $348 trillion. Of this increase, advanced economies accounted for the majority, with governments (both in advanced and emerging markets) contributing a substantial share. Continued fiscal expansion and regulatory adjustments are expected to drive further debt accumulation, raising legitimate concerns about long-term sustainability.

In the US, the public debt-to-GDP ratio has climbed to approximately 122 per cent as of late 2025. Pre-Supreme Court rulings on tariffs had already projected a $175 billion tax refund alongside a federal fiscal deficit reaching $1.9 trillion in 2026 (around 5.8 per cent of GDP). Commitments to defence, infrastructure, and entitlements leave limited room for additional stimulus without pushing yields higher and crowding out private investment.

Similar constraints appear elsewhere. The Eurozone's average debt-to-GDP stands near 90 per cent, while the UK's ratio is about 105 per cent amid a 4.7 per cent deficit. Japan leads with a ratio exceeding 250 per cent and persistent 4-5 per cent deficits, even as it contemplates further stimulus in 2026.

China's official figure hovers around 80 per cent, but including significant hidden local government obligations paints a more strained picture alongside 3-4 per cent deficits. Emerging markets average 65-70 per cent, though outliers such as India (around 85.5 per cent, or ₹325 lakh crore by FY27E) and Brazil (near 90 per cent) face tighter margins.

> In the context of the Iran war, for India, rising subsidy demands and increased allocations for defence and livelihood support will necessitate difficult expenditure trade-offs

With the Iran conflict potentially anchoring oil prices in the $90-100 range for an extended period, governments may prioritise targeted measures such as energy subsidies and elevated defence budgets, limiting stimulus and necessitating further borrowing. This could result in higher bond yields, renewed inflation, or even sovereign credit downgrades in vulnerable cases.

NARROW POLICY OPTIONS

In India, policy challenges confronting both fiscal and monetary authorities are formidable. Central and State government debt combined could approach ₹325 lakh crore (around 83 per cent of FY27 GDP estimates), with the Centre's debt alone reaching ₹214 lakh crore in FY27E, nearly four times the level of FY14. The budgeted fiscal deficit for FY27 stands at ₹17 lakh crore, while the combined Centre-plus-States figure may reach ₹29-30 lakh crore, leaving scant room for counter-cyclical stimulus. The additional ₹9-10 lakh crore annual oil import burden will ultimately be distributed across industries, oil marketing companies, households, and government budgets through some combination of higher prices, subsidies, and taxes.

Rising subsidy demands and increased allocations for defence and livelihood support will necessitate difficult expenditure trade-offs. Scope for further taxation of households appears limited, pushing reliance toward higher levies on corporates, sin goods, and premium products.

For the RBI, pre-existing challenges have been magnified. Despite substantial liquidity injections and rate cuts, 10-year G-sec yields have firmed to around 6.85 per cent, while the rupee has weakened to record lows near 94 against the dollar. The credit-deposit ratio has climbed above 82.5 per cent, constraining banks' ability to expand lending amid sluggish deposit growth. India's current account deficit could exceed $100 billion in FY27E under sustained $100 oil and current exchange rates, approaching the FY08 peak. Persistent declines in foreign investment flows could result in a balance of payments deficit for a third consecutive year, potentially reaching 3.3 per cent of GDP (a two-decade high).

Drawdowns from RBI forex reserves may accelerate depreciation. The combination of rising inflation, currency weakness, and slowing growth risks constraining both policy flexibility and direct investment inflows, can place the RBI's multiple objectives of price stability, financial stability, government financing support, and liquidity management, under considerable strain.

CLOUDY MARKET OUTLOOK

Indian equity markets are navigating elevated uncertainties surrounding corporate earnings, capital flows, and valuations. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have been net sellers of around $43 billion in equities since September 2024. Domestic institutional flows into equity mutual funds have shown resilience, aggregating $59 billion over the period. However, systematic investment plan (SIP) data indicates that the number of outstanding SIPs (103 million as of January 2026) has stagnated since October 2024, while average SIP assets under management have grown 20 per cent, suggesting greater participation from affluent segments and attrition among smaller investors facing negative returns. Monthly mutual fund flows declined to ₹23,000 crore in February 2025 from an average of ₹40,000 crore in late 2024, reflecting reduced smaller-ticket participation.

Resilient domestic flows have not fully offset FPI outflows, resulting in valuation compression: the Nifty's trailing price-to-earnings multiple has fallen 14 per cent from September 2024, to around 20x. Should FPI retrenchment continue, falling valuations and moderating retail enthusiasm could exert sustained downward pressure.

An optimistic scenario might involve: (a) a sudden halt to hostilities due to massive economic costs, (b) FPIs returning to perceived value despite earnings risks, or (c) a substantial expansion of domestic flows to counterbalance outflows. However, these outcomes appear low-probability at present.

The writer is CEO and Co-Head of Equities & Head of Research, Systematix Group. Views are personal

How excise duty cuts support OMCs

The tax cuts will help oil marketing firms reduce their under-recoveries; it will not impact retail prices

bl.explainer

Richa Mishra

To manage rising global crude prices and support Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), the Centre has cut excise duties on petrol and diesel effective March 27. Alongside, it has introduced an export levy on diesel and ATF to disincentivise exports and ensure refinery output is directed towards meeting domestic demand. These taxes target the super-normal profits refiners earn from high global product cracks — the margin between crude oil and refined products.

However, these decisions have "nil" impact on the consumer's pocket.

What are the tax elements in petrol and diesel retail pricing?

Petrol and diesel retail pricing in India has four-tax related elements, divided between the Union and the State governments.

The Centre levies a multi-layered excise duty comprising Basic Excise duty, Special Additional Excise duty, Agriculture Infrastructure & Development Cess, and Road & Infrastructure Cess.

Effective March 26, 2026, the government significantly reduced the "Special Additional Excise Duty" (SAED) to offset rising global crude oil prices.

States levy Value Added Tax (VAT) or Sales Tax on the sum of the base price, freight, dealer commission, and central excise duty. Because VAT is often a percentage (ad valorem), rates vary significantly between States.

While not a tax, a mandatory component added to the final price is dealer commission. It typically ranges from ₹2.50 to ₹4.50 per litre for petrol and slightly less for diesel.

Will the slashing of excise duty on petrol and diesel mean a cut in retail price?

The Centre's message was clear when announcing the duty cut: "Retail pump prices of petrol and diesel will not change. The excise reduction is not being passed on as a price cut at the pump."

What it does is it reduces the under-recoveries being absorbed by public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) — Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation — who have continued to supply fuel to Indian consumers at prices well below their cost of supply.

According to the government, at current international crude prices, under-recoveries stand at approximately ₹26 per litre of petrol and ₹81.90 per litre of diesel. The combined daily under-recovery being absorbed by OMCs is approximately ₹2,400 crore. The excise reduction offsets ₹10 per litre of these losses, ensuring OMCs can continue to supply fuel without disruption while keeping retail prices unchanged.

EXCISE CUT. Some relief for OMCs /ISTOCKPHOTO

What is under-recovery?

Under-recovery is the difference between the cost price (what it costs to produce/import fuel) and the selling price realised by the oil marketing companies (OMCs).

Simply put, it is the revenue shortfall that occurs when the government keeps retail fuel prices lower than international market rates to protect consumers.

Number crunchers in the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas will define it as: Under Recovery = Total Desired Price (Market Rate) – Selling Price at Depot.

The desired price is calculated using Trade Parity Pricing (TPP), which considers international prices, freight, insurance, and customs duty. Historically, under-recoveries are shared by three entities — the government: Through direct cash subsidies or tax cuts; Upstream Companies: Companies like ONGC and OIL often provide crude oil at discounted rates to OMCs; and the OMCs themselves absorb the remaining portion, which can lead to high debt levels and reduced capital expenditure.

Is it actually a loss?

Experts say there is a technical difference. Under-recovery is a shortfall against a perceived market-linked price. The marketing companies may still be operationally profitable if their actual refining costs are lower than the international benchmarks used in the formula.

While actual loss is when the selling price falls below the actual cost of production and procurement.

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Futile move

Apropos, 'Tax on mobile data usage isn't good idea', (March 27). The proposal to impose a tax on data usage reflects a regressive fiscal approach that undermines the foundational ethos of a digital economy.

In a country like India, where internet access is integral to education, entrepreneurship, and governance, such a levy would exacerbate existing digital inequalities. It risks disproportionately burdening economically vulnerable users while inflating operational costs for start-ups and small enterprises. Furthermore, it contradicts the objectives of digital inclusion and innovation-driven growth.

Rather than expanding revenue through restrictive taxation, policy should prioritize affordability and infrastructure, ensuring that digital access remains an enabler of socio-economic mobility rather than a taxed privilege.

N Sadhasiva Reddy

Bengaluru

Social media addiction

The recent verdict by a California court holding Meta and YouTube accountable in a social media addiction case could prove to be a bellwether for a broader push toward greater accountability for Big Tech. The 20-year-old plaintiff, who argued that these platforms contributed to anxiety and depression, was awarded substantial damages, with Meta ordered to pay $4.2 million and YouTube $1.8 billion. This judgment reinforces the concerns raised by experts such as Tristan Harris and Justin Rosenstein, who have long argued that social media platforms are deliberately designed to capture and sustain user attention by exploiting human psychology.

In an era where digital platforms are deeply embedded in education, work, and social life, outright prohibition is neither practical nor sufficient. It is essential that children are equipped with the cognitive and emotional skills needed to navigate the attention economy responsibly.

M Jeyaram

Sholavandan (TN)

Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai-600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., and Printed by Ra Babu Vijay at THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Plot B-6 & B-7, CMDA Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu Dist., Pin: 603209. Editor: Raghuvir Srinivasan (Editor responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 7528

QUICKLY.

Forex reserves drop $11.41 b to $698 b: RBI

Mumbai: India's forex reserves dropped by $11.4 billion to $698.3 billion during the week ended March 20 due to a sharp decrease in gold reserves, the RBI said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the overall reserves had dropped $7 billion to $709.7 billion. The kitty expanded to an all-time high of $728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year. PTI

Sundaram Clayton Board nod for interim dividend

Chennai: The Board of Directors of Sundaram Clayton on Friday declared an interim dividend of ₹4.50 per share (90 per cent) on 2,20,46,162 equity shares of ₹5 each fully paid up, absorbing a sum of ₹9.92 crore, for the financial year ending March 31, 2026. The record date for the purpose of the interim dividend will be April 3, 2026, it said in a filing to the exchanges. OUR BUREAU

‘No impending lockdown in India because of W. Asia war’

IN CONTROL. Govt will remain on its toes to keep fiscal deficit under check: Sitharaman

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Parliament on Friday completed the budgetary exercise for the fiscal year 2026-27 as the Rajya Sabha returned the Finance Bill to the Lok Sabha.

Meanwhile, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman strongly dismissed speculation about an impending lockdown in the wake of the West Asia war.

Responding to debate on the Finance Bill in the Upper House, Sitharaman highlighted the situation in the neighbouring countries *vis-a-vis* India and pointed to Pakistan, which has seen a 200 per cent hike on high octane fuel, 20 per cent hike on petrol and diesel.

“Petrol now is sold at 321 PKR a litre. Smart lockdowns were announced in Sindh province, so that their fuel can be conserved, restricting movement, gatherings and public events. Schools are shut for two weeks. Government offices have moved to four-day working week.

> Some leaders are spreading rumours that there will be lockdown. This rumour-mongering should not happen
>
> **NIRMALA SITHARAMAN**
> Finance Minister

Private offices [have been] told to shift 50 per cent staff to work from home,” she said, emphasising that the situation in India is vastly different.

“We’re not doing any of it. Still, some leaders are spreading rumours that there will be lockdown. This rumour-mongering should not happen. It’s being done to spread fear,” she said.

ON DUTY REVISION

Talking about impact of duty revision, the Minister said the government will remain on its toes to keep fiscal deficit under check while ensuring the burden of rising global crude oil prices does not fall on the common man. “We will be able to keep the government fiscal stance carefully managed. Also, there will be efforts to have greater mobilisations through non-tax revenues,” Sitharaman said.

The Minister informed the House that globally, international crude oil prices had surged to $112 a barrel from $70 per barrel within just one month due to the disruptions in Strait of Hormuz. Brent Crude has not dropped below $100 since March 13. Petrol and diesel prices have gone up by 30 to 50 per cent in South-East Asian nations, 30 per cent in North America, 20 per cent in Europe and 50 per cent in African countries.

“For the last four years, after the Russia-Ukraine conflict, there’s been severe stress in terms of the oil, fertilizers, and therefore, we are carefully managing,” she said.

Later, the Rajya Sabha returned the Finance Bill to the Lok Sabha by voice vote, thus completing the budgetary exercise for the next fiscal year, starting April 1. The Lok Sabha passed the bill on March 25, along with 32 amendments.

The Union Budget 2026-27 envisages a total expenditure of ₹53.47 lakh crore, an increase of 7.7 per cent over the current fiscal ending March 31. The total capex proposed for the next fiscal is ₹12.2 lakh crore.

It proposes a gross tax revenue collection of ₹44.04 lakh crore and a gross borrowing of ₹17.2 lakh crore. The fiscal deficit for FY27 is projected at 4.3 per cent of the GDP, lower than 4.4 per cent in the current fiscal.

Govt to borrow ₹8.2 lakh crore in H1 FY27

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Finance Ministry, in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), on Friday decided to borrow ₹8.20 lakh crore through dated securities during April-September period of fiscal year 2026-27.

This is 51 per cent of the total borrowing of ₹16.09 lakh crore and is lower than the usual 60 per cent plus seen during the first half. “As 10-year bond yield is over 6.9 per cent and global situation is too volatile, borrowing is less,” said DK Pant, Chief Economist with India Ratings & Research.

According to a Finance Ministry statement, since Budget presentation, switches of G-Sec (Government Securities) were conducted, reducing gross market borrowing to ₹16.09 lakh crore. “Of ₹16.09 lakh crore, ₹8.20 lakh crore is planned to be borrowed in H1 through issuance of dated securities, including ₹15,000 crore of sovereign green bonds (SGrBs),” the statement said. It will be completed through 26 weekly auctions and spread over 3-, 5-, 7-, 10-, 15-, 30-, 40- and 50-year securities. The share of borrowing (including SGrBs) under different maturities will be: 3-year (8.1 per cent), 5-year (15.4 per cent), 7-year (8.1 per cent), 10-year (29 per cent), 15-year (14.5 per cent), 30-year (7.3 per cent), 40-year (8 per cent) and 50-year (9.6 per cent).

TREASURY BILLS

“The government will carry out switching/buyback of securities to smoothen the redemption profile. It will continue to exercise greenshoe option to retain an additional subscription of up to ₹2,000 crore against each of the securities indicated in the auction notifications,” the statement added.

Weekly borrowing through Treasury Bills in Q1FY27 is expected to be ₹24,000 crore for 12 weeks.

TV, AC, washing machine prices to rise 7-12% from April 1: Hisense India CEO

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Hisense India CEO Pankaj Rana

Prices of televisions, air conditioners (AC) and washing machines are set to rise 7-12 per cent from April 1 as input cost inflation and supply disruptions begin to feed into retail pricing, Hisense India CEO Pankaj Rana said.

“We have already issued a price circular to the market. From April 1, AC prices will increase by a minimum of 10-12 per cent, driven by sharp increases in input costs, logistics and supply disruptions,” Rana said.

Company officials indicated that while ACs will see the steepest hikes, televisions could become costlier by 5-7 per cent due to memory cost inflation.

Washing machines and refrigerators are also likely to see price increases of around 7-8 per cent. However, the full impact on consumers may be gradual, as existing channel inventory could delay immediate pass-through.

PASSING ON COSTS

The increase comes amid a convergence of pressures, including higher raw material costs such as plastics and polymers, elevated container and logistics expenses, a weakening rupee, rising freight rates and supply-side disruptions linked to geopolitical tensions, costs that manufacturers can no longer fully absorb.

Sharing further details on the company’s performance, Rana said that Hisense closed calendar year 2025 with revenue of around $100 million.

“We are targeting around $150 million in revenue this year. Given the current environment, that is a realistic number rather than an aggressive one,” he said, adding that growth will be driven by category expansion and manufacturing scale-up.

“Demand will remain strong given low penetration and the summer season, but if product prices rise meaningfully, there could be some moderation. The impact won’t be sharp, but it will be visible,” he indicated.

The pricing shift coincides with a structural reset underway at Hisense India, which is transitioning from an import-led model to local manufacturing.

DISTRIBUTION

The company plans to add washing machine production by July–August, followed by local television manufacturing later in the year, completing a full white goods portfolio in India.

Hisense is also expanding distribution across large-format retail chains like Reliance Digital, Croma and Vijay Sales, as it looks to rebalance its online-heavy sales mix with a stronger offline footprint.

Despite near-term pricing pressure, demand is expected to remain resilient. “The industry is projecting 20–25 per cent growth in air-conditioner sales this year, supported by an early summer and low penetration levels. Television demand is likely to remain in single digits, while washing machines could see 10–12 per cent growth,” Rana said.

“On the supply side, we are seeing multiple challenges, from rising container and raw material costs to constraints like LPG availability impacting production. These are real, on-ground issues for manufacturers right now,” he added.

IL&FS case: NCLT order throws light on auditors’ role in IBC cases

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The National Company Law Tribunal’s (NCLT) refusal to grant immunity to leading audit firms in the IL&FS case marks a sharp turning point in how accountability is enforced in India’s financial system, putting auditors squarely in the regulatory crosshairs.

By denying protection to firms such as Deloitte, BSR & Associates and SRBC & Co, the ruling challenges a long-held assumption that resolution processes under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016, could shield intermediaries from legal and criminal scrutiny. Instead, it redraws the risk landscape for auditors, signalling that participation in resolution frameworks may no longer offer a safe harbour from enforcement action.

The decision comes amid an ongoing legal push launched in 2018 by the Centre, after the collapse of Infrastructure Leasing & Financial Services and its group entities triggered one of India’s most significant financial crises.

While the audit firms had sought to be excluded from proceedings under this provision, NCLT held that Section 339 also includes third parties, if evidence indicates their involvement.

HEIGHTENED SCRUTINY

Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates, said the verdict signals a clear judicial shift towards heightened scrutiny of professional advisors.

The verdict may have a chilling effect on professional participation in distressed asset resolutions as the absence of immunity creates residual liability risks, she added.

However, the refusal of immunity to audit firms is unlikely to operate as a blanket precedent automatically binding across all ongoing matters, she said.

Varun Lakra, Associate Partner, King Stubb & Kasiva, Advocates and Attorneys, said the order signals that professional firms, including auditors, may not automatically receive protection merely because they were engaged in a professional capacity.

Abhishek Swaroop, Partner, Saraf and Partners, said the NCLT had signalled that personal exposure can, in principle, extend to any person who knowingly enables a company’s fraudulent business.

However, the NCLT clarified that merely being a party to a transaction with the company is insufficient; there must be knowing participation in fraudulent conduct of the company’s business, he added.

States’ borrowing costs rise by 0.3% to over 8%

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

Borrowing costs for the States rose by a sharp 0.15-0.3 per cent at an auction on Friday to over 8 per cent in some securities, tracking a spike in government bond yields amid the escalating conflict in West Asia that has pushed up global oil prices.

Data compiled by *PTI* from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) showed that the cut-off yield on long-term securities increased across maturities. The yield on 15-year State Development Loans (SDLs) rose by 0.24 per cent compared with the previous auction on March 24, while the yields on 20-year SDLs increased 0.16 per cent and those on 25-year bonds climbed by 0.30 per cent.

In the SDL auction on Friday, 13 States borrowed ₹39,991.958 crore, lower than the notified amount of ₹42,941 crore.

Tenneco Clean Air eyes acquisitions, ramps up R&D to drive next phase of growth

T E Raja Simhan
Hosur

Inside the Tenneco Clean Air India Ltd plant at Hosur T E RAJA SIMHAN

Arvind Chandra, CEO & Whole Time Director, Tenneco Clean Air India Ltd T E RAJA SIMHAN

Tenneco Clean Air India Ltd, part of the $17-billion US-based Tenneco, is gearing up for its next phase of growth involving acquisitions, capacity expansion and a significant push in R&D as it targets sustained double-digit growth over the next three to four years.

Tenneco is expanding its footprint with a plant planned in Kharkhoda, Haryana, to strengthen its presence in North India, at an outlay of ₹71 crore, said Arvind Chandra, CEO and Whole-Time Director, speaking at the company’s Hosur facility.

Sources said the company also plans a fund infusion in its Hosur plant to add a product line for shock absorbers. However, the executive did not disclose the details.

Tenneco operates 12 manufacturing facilities across India, spanning both Clean Air & Powertrain Solutions and Advanced Ride Performance businesses.

“We are the largest supplier of shock absorbers and struts to Indian passenger vehicle OEMs, with a 52 per cent market share in the ₹5,000 crore market. We are the largest supplier of clean air solutions to Indian commercial transport OEMs, with a market share of 57 per cent in the ₹2,000 crore market,” said Chandra.

The company’s clients include Ashok Leyland, Bajaj Auto, Cummins, Daimler India Commercial Vehicle, Honda Motorcycle, Hyundai, Mahindra & Mahindra, Maruti Suzuki and Tata Motors.

The ₹5,000-crore Gurugram-based auto component major is actively evaluating its first inorganic acquisition, with a focus on technology, electronics and software capabilities that can complement its core strengths and future mobility needs. It manufactures intensive clean air, powertrain and suspension solutions tailored for Indian OEMs and export markets.

“We are a zero-debt company,” said Chandra. He declined to disclose the size of the potential acquisition. Beyond its traditional focus, the company is evaluating adjacent segments such as off-highway and industrial applications, including construction equipment, where margins are typically higher.

R&D EXPANSION

The company has earmarked up to $2 million to upgrade its R&D centre in Hosur. There are around 150 engineers in the R&D centre, and this will be expanded to nearly 200, he said.

The reporter was in Hosur at the company’s invitation

CIL to spend ₹3,300 cr on eight coking coal washeries, to go live by FY30

Our Bureau
Kolkata

Coal India will be setting up eight coking coal washeries on an outlay of ₹3,300 crore to improve the quality of its coking coal.

Expected to be operational by FY30, these washeries will have a combined washing capacity of 21.5 million tonnes per year (MT/Y), the company said in a stock exchange filing on Friday. “The upcoming coking coal washeries are in addition to the 10 that CIL already operates, having 18.35 MT/Y cumulative capacity,” it said.

It would also invest ₹300 crore in the renovation and modernisation of the existing washeries to ensure optimal and gainful utilisation.

DOMESTIC QUALITY

Of the eight new washeries, five will be set up in Central Coalfields (14.5 MT/Y) and three in Bharat Coking Coal (7 MT/Y).

“This calibrated expansion of washing capacity and modernisation is to improve domestic coking coal quality and an effort to moderate import dependence in the coming years,” Coal India said.

Having monetised one coking coal washery in Bharat Coking Coal a year ago, plans are underway to monetise three older, non-operative coking coal washeries aligning with National Monetisation Policy.

CIL is also renovating and modernising two ageing coking coal washeries to improve their throughput, recovery efficiency and process reliability.

In a public-private collaboration model, the coal major is leveraging washing capacity and technical expertise from TATA Steel to enhance the supply of quality coking coal to the domestic steel sector.

For BSE/NSE live quotes, scan the QR code or click the link https://bit.ly/2FpossK

CHENNAI
businessline.
SATURDAY - MARCH 28 - 2026

Nifty, Sensex post fifth straight weekly fall as war fears grip market

PAIN ALL AROUND. Broad-based sell-off pinches stocks across sectors; PSU banks, realty, auto tumble sharply

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets suffered a decisive sell-off on Friday, with benchmark indices snapping a two-session recovery and closing sharply lower as geopolitical tensions around the US-Iran conflict, a record rupee depreciation, and broad institutional selling combined to drive the steepest single-day fall of the week.

The BSE Sensex declined 1,690.23 points to close at 73,583.22, while the NSE Nifty 50 fell 486.85 points to end at 22,819.60.

The Nifty has now fallen 9.37 per cent from 25,178.65 since the West Asia conflict erupted on February 28, and has registered its fifth consecutive weekly decline, shedding 1.27 per cent over the week.

GRIM PICTURE

The sell-off was broad-based and decisive. PSU banks led sectoral losses, falling 3.88 per cent, followed by realty at 3.1 per cent, auto at 2.79 per cent, and financial services at 2.69 per cent. Private banks and consumer durables also dropped more than 2 per cent. The CPSE segment was the only pocket of marginal relative strength. Nifty Midcap and Nifty Smallcap indices mirrored the benchmark, falling 2.23 per cent and 1.74 per cent. The BSE market breadth collapsed, with the advance-decline ratio shrinking to 0.23.

NSE cash market volumes surged 25 per cent over the previous session, partly due to semi-annual index rebalancing. India VIX climbed over 8 per cent during the day to close at 26.80. On the Nifty, put-call ratio stood at 0.89, with heavy call writing at 23,000 and 23,200 capping upside, while put writers were positioned at 22,500.

"Markets extended their decline on Friday, ending sharply lower and continuing the ongoing corrective phase amid weak global cues... The index failed to gain traction and eventually settled near the day's low," said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research, Religare Broking.

US President Trump extended the pause on strikes targeting Iran's energy infrastructure until April 6 and reiterated diplomatic engagement, but markets drew limited comfort as Tehran continued retaliatory action.

The SBI Funds Management research note on the Middle East conflict, released in March, had flagged that the Strait of Hormuz disruption represents a purer supply shock than past geopolitical episodes, with no meaningful bypass route, and that "... if the SoH closure persists, prices will continue rising until recessionary demand compression takes hold."

The note further projected India's current account deficit widening by up to $70 billion in a scenario where crude holds near $100 per barrel for the full year.

BEAR ONSLAUGHT. The Nifty has now fallen 9.37% from 25,178.65 since the West Asia conflict erupted on February 28

SEBI extends suspension on trading in 7 agri commodity derivatives till March 2027

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Markets regulator SEBI on Friday extended the suspension of derivatives trading in seven agricultural commodities, including wheat, moong and paddy (non-basmati) by another year till March 31, 2027, in a bid to rein in prices.

The other commodities under suspension include chana, crude palm oil, mustard seeds and their derivatives, and soybean, along with its derivatives.

TRADING SUSPENSION

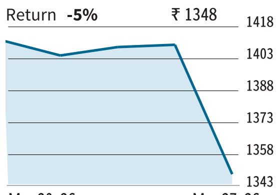
The directive was originally issued on December 19, 2021, suspending trading in these contracts until December 20, 2022. Since then, the restriction has been extended multiple times — first till December 20, 2023, then December 20, 2024, followed by January 31, 2025, March 31, 2025, and subsequently March 31, 2026. "In continuation of the said directions, the suspension in trading in the above contracts has been further extended till March 31, 2027," SEBI said in a statement.

The suspension allows market participants to square off existing positions but prohibits any fresh futures trading in these commodities.

The move is aimed at curbing excessive speculation and volatility in key agricultural commodities, which play a crucial role in determining food prices and inflation.

QUICKLY.

Reliance falls 4.6%; loses ₹87,014 cr in market-cap



New Delhi: Shares of Reliance Industries faced heavy selling on Friday and tumbled 4.6 per cent, facing an erosion of ₹87,014 crore from its market valuation, in-tandem with a bearish trend in the stock market. The bellwether stock tanked 4.55 per cent to settle at ₹1,348.25 on the BSE. During the day, it dropped 4.78 per cent to ₹1,345. At the NSE, the stock tumbled 4.59 per cent to end at ₹1,348.10. The sharp decline in the stock wiped out ₹87,013.8 crore from its market valuation, which stood at ₹18,24,515.62 crore. PTI

SBICAP Trustee settles debenture norms case

New Delhi: SBICAP Trustee Company has settled with SEBI a case alleging violations of debenture trustee norms after paying ₹23.45 lakh towards settlement charges. After the receipt of the settlement amount by SEBI, the instant adjudication proceedings initiated against SBICAP Trustee Company Ltd, vide Show Cause Notice dated October 8, 2024, are hereby disposed of, the regulator said. In its show cause notice, SEBI observed that in two NCD issuances of JM Financial Asset Reconstruction Company, where SBICAP Trustee acted as debenture trustee, encumbrance on securities offered as security was not created through depository system. PTI

SEBI clears 6 IPOs as 1 is withdrawn

Our Bureau
Mumbai

SEBI has cleared six initial public offerings, including those of Vishvaraj Environment, Prasol Chemicals, SAEL Industries, NoPaper-Forms Solutions, Symbiotec Pharmalab and Shah Investor's Home, while Jindal Supreme (India) withdrew its proposed IPO.

Vishvaraj Environment, a leading developer of water utility and wastewater management projects, plans to raise ₹2,250 crore through the proposed IPO.

The company's initial public offering comprises a fresh equity issuance of ₹1,250 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of ₹1,000 crore by the promoter selling shareholder, Premier Financial Services.

The company plans to use the proceeds to repay loans of ₹545 crore and fund capex for three projects of ₹415 crore, besides general corporate purposes.

JM Financial, Axis Capital and DAM Capital Advisors are the book-running lead managers to the issue.

OTHER IPOs

Symbiotec Pharmalab will raise ₹2,180 crore through its IPO, comprising a fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹150 crore and OFS of up to ₹2,030 crore by existing promoters and investors. The funds will be used for debt repayment and general corporate purposes.

Prasol Chemicals plans to raise ₹500 crore through the IPO.

The company will issue fresh equity shares of ₹80 crore and OFS of up to ₹420 crore by existing shareholders.

Info Edge-backed NoPaperForms Solutions will raise ₹500 crore to ₹600 crore through fresh equity issuance and OFS.

The SaaS platform provider filed its draft papers for the IPO last November.

The Shah Investor's Home IPO consists of a fresh issue of 54 lakh shares. The company provides a comprehensive suite of services, including mutual fund distribution, margin funding, and stock lending and borrowing.

ACME Solar jumps 6% as brokerages remain bullish, Investec sees 18 per cent upside

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Shares of ACME Solar Holdings zoomed in Friday's session, buoyed by bullish commentary from the brokerages highlighting its strong growth visibility and positioning in the next-generation renewable energy segments.

After hitting an intra-day high of ₹274, the stock settled at ₹269.41, up 6 per cent.

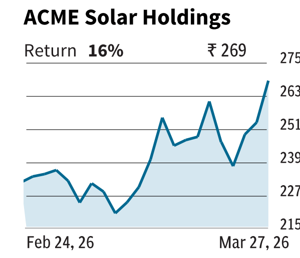
BROKERAGE BULLISH

Brokerage Investec initiated coverage with a 'Buy' rating and a target price of ₹319 citing ACME Solar's transition into a leading player in firm and dispatchable renewable energy (FDRE). Investec said the company's growing focus on hybrid solutions, combining solar, wind and storage, positions it well to deliver round-the-clock clean power, a segment expected to see strong demand.

The brokerage highlighted that nearly half of ACME's portfolio is already aligned to FDRE, with a robust pipeline of about 5 GW under development. It expects strong earnings growth over the next few years, driven by capacity additions and higher utilisation assets, with profitability supported by improving return ratios and execution visibility. Domestic brokerage Centrum Broking also initiated coverage with a 'buy' call at ₹315. It said the company was emerging as a high-growth renewable independent power producer, backed by a strong pipeline, improving financial discipline, and increasing exposure to high-value hybrid and round-the-clock power projects. It expects robust earnings momentum, projecting revenue, EBITDA and profit to grow at a strong pace over FY25-FY28, supported by steady capacity additions and long-term power purchase agreements that provide stable, annuity-like cash flows.

The brokerage further noted that ACME's strategic shift towards hybrid, FDRE and storage-backed projects enhanced its competitiveness, offering better tariffs and improved project economics, compared to traditional solar assets.

ACME Solar Holdings



BROKER'S CALL.

Choice Equity Broking

DR REDDY'S LAB (ADD)
Target: ₹1,315
CMP: ₹1,281.95

We interacted with Dr Reddy's Lab Head of IR, Aishwarya Sitharam, following the company's successful day-1 launch of Semaglutide. Dr Reddy's Lab is the first to introduce a DCGI-approved version in India under the brand name Obeda, establishing an early-mover advantage in the domestic GLP-1 market.

Semaglutide is a complex peptide product and not a simple smallmolecule generic and hence requires advanced manufacturing capabilities and sterile production expertise.

The company's premium pricing at ₹4,200 per month versus peers at ₹1,300 reflects its dosage form, with a prefilled disposable pen format as compared to vial-based alternatives, which could support greater physician preference and patient stickiness. The management has indicated that it is unlikely to engage in aggressive price cuts to drive volumes.

We view this launch as positioning the company strategically within the emerging GLP-1 opportunity, with a differentiated focus on quality, delivery format and brand trust rather than price-led competition. Overall, in the medium term, we expect a shift towards a more consolidated, quality-led market, with Dr Reddy's Lab well-placed to benefit given its early entry and manufacturing strengths. Profitability is likely to improve as the business scales up and operating leverage kicks in.

Elara Capital

BLACK BUCK (BUY)
Target: ₹814
CMP: ₹589.05

Black Buck (formerly Zinka Logistics Solutions Ltd) is entering a multifold monetisation phase. Its stabilised core business — payments and telematics (92 per cent of revenue as o n FY25) — is set to compound through market share gains, industry tailwinds, operating leverage and robust profitability.

Meanwhile , growth initiatives like SuperLoads are monetising digital freight transactions via platform, positioning Black Buck as an end-to-end solution for 3.5 million truck operators in a $135-140 billion unorganised freight opportunity. Core profits would fuel SuperLoads ' expansion, with an established playbook, targeting about 10x revenue by FY28 E via replication. Margin may moderate to about 28-29 per cent by FY28E amid reinvestments, but 90 per cent+ contribution margin in the core businesses should ensure robust cash flow.

The company is reshaping India's trucking ecosystem. We initiate with a Buy rating, with DCF-based TP of ₹814, assuming ₹665 for the core business and ₹149 for SuperLoads.

Key risks: Any adverse change in toll fees economics could compress take rates; Scaling up SuperLoads without slipping into capital intensity or operational complexity remains critical; and Banks, fintech, or digital freight platforms could put pressure on market share and monetisation.

Assertive boardroom: Why independent director voice matters

RINGSIDE VIEW.

KS BADRI NARAYANAN

The controversy surrounding HDFC Bank, following the sudden resignation of its Part-Time Chairman and Independent Director Atanu Chakraborty last week, refuses to die down.

In his resignation letter, he cited "certain happenings and practices within the bank" over the past two years that were not aligned with his personal values and ethics.

The remarks rattled investors, dragged down the stock and ignited intense debate across social media.

Regulators Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) have taken cognisance of the issue and are actively reviewing and investigating the matter.

Eyebrows were raised over the way the disclosures were made, with many feeling that what was left unsaid in the letter allowed room for speculation about the company's corporate governance practices.

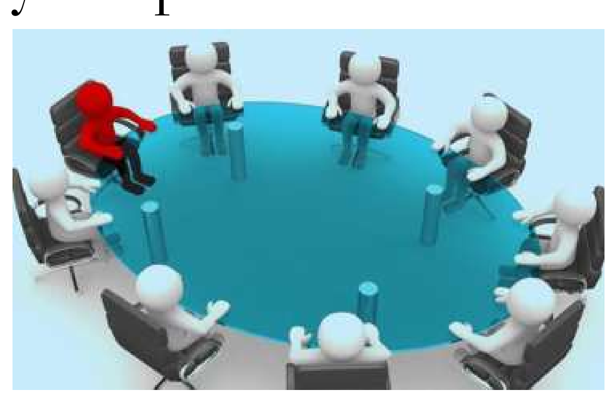
An independent director is expected, among other responsibilities, to uphold high ethical standards of integrity and probity, act objectively and constructively in the discharge of duties, and perform responsibilities in a *bona fide* manner in the best interests of the company.

Additionally, they must remain free from extraneous influences and refrain from abusing their position.

LODR REGULATIONS

Since the introduction of independent directors in 2000, SEBI has continuously reviewed and updated its listing obligation and disclosure requirement (LODR) regulations to reflect evolving corporate governance standards, making them increasingly comprehensive and prescriptive.

In fact, in 2021, after due consultation, SEBI made it mandatory that the entire resignation letter of an independent director should be disclosed to the stock exchanges along with a list of his/her present directorships and membership in board committees.



KEY ROLE. An independent director is expected to uphold high ethical standards and perform responsibilities in a *bona fide* manner in the best interests of the company

PANDEY'S VIEWS

SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey recently said independent directors are required to follow well laid-down processes to flag concerns.

"No one is expected to make insinuations without proper evidence and recordings," he said on the HDFC Bank issue.

"Where independent directors have any concerns about the running of the company... ensure that they are addressed by the board... and if not resolved, insist that their concerns are recorded in the minutes."

Further, concerns relating to "unethical behaviour, actual or suspected fraud, or violation of the company's code of conduct" must be formally recorded, he said.

"We can't keep things vague," he said.

Pandey further said there is a clear framework under the LODR regulations and the Companies Act for independent directors.

Fire-fighting is also happening from HDFC Bank to rebuild its brand image by enhancing corporate governance and transparency as it appointed external law firms to examine the resignation letter.

As the SEBI chief said, independent directors should be more assertive in the board and other meetings, ensuring their views and dissent are clearly expressed and formally recorded.

Following this episode, greater attention will be given to the role of independent directors, which will be beneficial as it helps strengthen corporate governance.

It is hoped that the ongoing probe by regulators and other authorities will bring the full facts to light soon. Until then, HDFC Bank and its shareholders will continue to face damaging speculation, which is hurting both the institution's reputation and its stock price.

A swift resolution will provide significant relief to all stakeholders.

Nifty 50 Movers ▼ 486.85 pts.

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)
ONGC	281.95	10.01	7.89	1.05
Bharti Airtel	1843.90	5.50	28.38	4.94
TCS	2389.80	2.78	18.03	2.35
Wipro	191.60	1.60	15.07	0.53
Coal India	445.05	0.67	9.22	0.97
PowerGrid Corp	295.50	0.50	17.70	1.29
Cipla	1242.30	-0.26	22.14	0.67
Sun Pharma	1793.60	-0.42	39.29	1.83
Hindalco	866.70	-0.62	12.11	1.21
HDFC Life	610.20	-0.64	69.65	0.63
Apollo Hosp	7549.00	-0.71	58.18	0.75
TataConsumerProduct	1048.50	-1.09	70.51	0.66
SBI Life	1837.60	-1.40	74.33	0.79
Grasim Ind	2628.20	-1.64	18.88	0.97
NestleIndia	1193.20	-1.71	70.54	0.82
ITC	294.70	-2.11	17.83	2.73
Max Healthcare	975.10	-2.14	66.84	0.70
Tech Mahindra	1391.60	-2.35	29.70	0.85
Dr Reddys Lab	1281.70	-2.54	19.37	0.75
NTPC	375.65	-2.86	14.67	1.71
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	232.55	-3.45	92.06	0.73
Bajaj Auto	8901.00	-3.59	27.98	0.95
Adani Enter	1823.00	-3.63	14.89	0.46
Trent Ltd.	3399.60	-3.86	74.61	0.73
HCL Tech	1364.40	-3.91	22.48	1.38
UltraTech Cement	11049.00	-4.03	42.49	1.26
Titan	3981.50	-5.23	74.17	1.58
JSW Steel	1130.30	-5.30	35.59	1.02
Eicher Motors	6811.50	-5.47	34.87	0.90
Adani Ports	1337.80	-6.17	24.66	0.95
Tata Steel	193.22	-6.22	26.44	1.54
Asian Paints	2207.40	-6.23	54.15	0.96
Bajaj Finserv	1694.70	-6.46	14.10	0.93
Tata Motors PV	303.20	-6.77	41.23	0.61
Bharat Elec	404.75	-6.84	49.62	1.39
Infosys	1269.70	-7.22	18.38	4.28
Kotak Bank	366.15	-7.99	19.37	2.59
Maruti Suzuki	12389.00	-9.27	26.09	1.56
IntGlobeAvi	4099.50	-9.68	49.36	0.89
Axis Bank	1205.20	-10.63	14.16	3.32
Hind Unilever	2074.40	-11.76	48.47	1.77
Eternal Ltd.	233.17	-14.20	974.10	1.61
Shriram Finance Ltd.	903.80	-16.04	18.59	1.22
M&M	3041.30	-17.00	22.37	2.61
L&T	3564.10	-21.95	25.84	4.02
Bajaj Finance	843.80	-22.69	28.65	2.15
State Bank	1019.50	-37.41	10.87	4.07
ICICI Bank	1233.80	-40.58	15.58	8.47
HDFC Bank	756.20	-87.59	15.02	11.12
Reliance Ind	1348.10	-96.28	18.66	8.75

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers ▲ 1,577.55 pts.

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	Wt(%)
Adani Power .	153.92	3.20	26.27	2.94
Avenuesuper	3903.20	-3.36	88.68	2.78
Zyduslifesciences	896.70	-5.26	17.95	1.09
Divis Lab	5997.50	-6.48	64.23	3.69
Info Edge I	991.40	-7.69	38.15	1.86
Bajaj Housing Finance .	75.85	-9.22	25.51	0.34
Torrent Pharma	4265.60	-10.01	63.54	2.16
Lic	765.65	-10.29	9.13	0.82
Hindus Zinc	509.70	-10.40	18.25	1.07
Bpcl	282.70	-10.76	4.98	2.65
Jindal Steel	1131.40	-13.01	57.25	2.04
Siemens	3048.90	-13.89	68.48	1.30
Indian Railway Finance Corp	92.45	-14.96	17.24	0.80
Jsw Energy .	484.80	-15.29	32.55	1.26
Gail (India)	137.19	-16.27	10.48	1.79
Abb India	6105.00	-16.91	76.71	1.55
Icici Lombard Gic	1747.00	-16.92	31.81	2.04
Adanigreenenergy	832.50	-19.59	73.88	1.23
Bosch	29615.00	-20.17	31.68	1.24
Shree Cement	23705.00	-21.07	47.62	1.53
Mazagoan Dock	2162.90	-21.20	36.25	0.79
Dlf	523.00	-21.84	29.23	1.62
Ambuja Cements	408.85	-23.69	20.54	1.21
Tata Power	385.70	-25.19	24.61	3.13
Ltimindtree	4200.70	-25.65	26.36	1.88
Havells	1231.60	-27.85	52.10	1.50
Macrotech Developers .	700.20	-28.40	20.90	0.95
Hyundai Motor India .	1816.70	-29.43	25.49	1.25
Indian Oilcorp	137.76	-30.94	5.28	2.49
Power Finance	396.00	-32.55	3.91	2.79
Solar Industries	12418.00	-34.50	73.60	1.46
Rural Elec	318.45	-34.66	4.86	1.92
Adani Energy Solutions .	956.00	-35.80	48.18	1.60
Godrej Consumer	1008.70	-37.30	56.66	1.96
Siemens Energy India .	2629.40	-37.68	79.27	1.12
Pidilitind	1314.90	-44.63	57.83	1.97
Hindustanaeronautics	3588.60	-46.00	26.98	3.29
Varun Beverages .	389.30	-49.89	43.00	2.58
Samvardmothersoninternatl	109.38	-49.97	31.72	2.35
Cg Power & Ind Sol	667.95	-50.06	94.81	2.22
Punjab Natl Bank	105.13	-51.10	6.76	1.75
United Spirits .	1253.80	-51.22	53.02	1.79
Britannia Ind	5500.00	-52.02	54.82	3.14
Bajaj Holdings	9150.00	-52.48	11.36	1.92
Canara Bank	130.45	-61.50	6.43	2.13
Bank Of Baroda	260.30	-69.02	6.85	2.34
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3445.20	-69.03	53.60	3.91
Indian Hotels Co. .	590.90	-69.57	38.86	2.51
Cholamandalamin&Fin	1416.30	-72.96	24.66	2.90
Vedanta	649.40	-103.07	15.33	5.33

Pts: Impact on index movement

Sai Parenterals IPO fully subscribed on last day

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The ₹409-crore initial public offering of Sai Parenterals fetched an overall subscription of 1.05 times, led by strong institutional interest.

The qualified institutional buyers (QIBs) portion saw 1.71 times subscription and non-institutional investors (NIIs) 2.36 times. However, retail participation remained muted at just 0.12 times.

Ahead of the public issue, the company raised over ₹122 crore from anchor investors on Monday, indicating early confidence from institutional participants.

RETAIL ON SIDELINE

The IPO comprised a mix of fresh issue (₹285 crore) and offer-for-sale up to 31.57 lakh equity shares being sold by existing shareholders, including Vikasa India EIF I Fund and several individual investors.

The price band for the IPO was fixed at ₹372 to ₹392 per share. Investors could bid for a minimum lot size of 38 shares.

USE OF PROCEEDS

The company plans to utilise the net proceeds from the fresh issue primarily to fund its expansion plans.

This includes strengthening its global formulations business and enhancing its Contract Development and Manufacturing Organisation capabilities.

The focus will be on scaling both injectable products and oral solid dosage manufacturing.

Nasdaq 100 sinks into correction as big tech keeps falling

Bloomberg

The Nasdaq 100 Index fell into correction territory on Friday amid a deepening slump in the shares of technology giants that have powered the bull market for most of the past three years.

The tech-heavy benchmark fell 1.1 per cent to 23,335.13, pushing the index down about 11 per cent from a peak in October. It is the first time since US President Donald Trump's tariffs sent stocks plunging in April 2025 that the Nasdaq 100 has fallen into a technical correction, which is defined as a decline of at least 10% but short of a bear market plunge of 20 per cent.

The index's sell-off comes as the Iran war rattles investor confidence at the same time Big Tech companies are facing mounting scepticism about massive spending on artificial intelligence computing and the outlook for when those investments will start generating bigger returns.

"We're reacting to a lot of headlines, and the geopolitical situation is overshadowing everything else," said Jim Awad, Senior Managing Director, Clearstead Advisors.

Microsoft Corp and Meta Platforms Inc are among the biggest drags on the Nasdaq 100 since it peaked on October 29. Since then, Microsoft is down 34 per cent while Meta Platforms has fallen 29 per cent.

It isn't just the lavish spenders, however, that are getting pummelled. Nvidia Corp, the biggest beneficiary of the largess, has dropped almost 19 per cent since October 29.

AI DISRUPTION

At the same time, anxiety about AI-related disruption has weighed heavily on software makers, as well as other sectors. Workday Inc, which makes human resources software, and Trello-owner Atlassian Corp have seen their shares drop more than 40 per cent since October 29.

Despite leading the sell-off, tech giants are still viewed positively by Wall Street with earnings growth of the S&P 500 this year and stock valuations more attractive than they were several months ago.

QUICKLY.

Ukraine, Saudi Arabia sign defence co-operation pact

Ukraine and Saudi Arabia have signed an agreement on defence co-operation that lays the foundation for future contracts and technological co-operation, President Volodymyr Zelenskiy said on Friday. The war with Iran raises uncertainty for Ukraine over whether the US will restrict its military supplies. REUTERS

Toyota recalls 5,60,000 SUVs over seat safety

Toyota Motor Corp's Chinese joint ventures Guangzhou Automobile Group Co and China FAW Group Co are recalling more than 5,60,000 sport utility vehicles (SUV) from April 1 to fix a defect in the second-row seats that could risk passenger safety, according to a statement from China's State Administration for Market Regulation. BLOOMBERG

Balendra Shah sworn in as Nepal PM

Kathmandu: Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah, popularly known as 'Balen', was on Friday sworn in as Nepal's new Prime Minister.
The 35-year-old Rastriya Swatantra Party leader was sworn in by President Ram Chandra Paudel. Shah is Nepal's youngest leader to be democratically elected to the top office. PTI

Trump extends deadline for striking Iran's energy plants to April 7

NO END IN SIGHT. US President says talks with Tehran 'going very well'; Iran maintains stance of no engagement

Reuters
Dubai/Tel Aviv/Washington

US President Donald Trump said he would again extend a deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face the destruction of its energy plants, after Tehran earlier rejected a 15-point US proposal to end the fighting.

The war has spread across the Middle East, killing thousands of people and hitting the global economy with soaring energy and fertiliser prices that have fuelled inflation fears.

On Thursday, Trump threatened during a cabinet meeting at the White House to increase pressure on Iran if it did not make a deal. He later posted on social media that he would pause threatened attacks on Iranian energy plants for 10 days until April 6 at 8 pm (0000 GMT on April 7).

"Talks are ongoing and, despite erroneous statements to the contrary by the Fake News Media, and others, they are going very well," he added in his Truth Social post.

PAKISTAN MEETING

Iran has said it is not engaged in talks with Washington. Trump has not specified who the US is purportedly negotiating with in Iran, where many high-ranking officials have been killed in the war.

German Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul told Deutschlandfunk radio that he had information that "there have been indirect contacts, and preparations have been made to meet directly".

"That would be very soon in Pakistan, apparently."

Pakistan, which has good relations with Iran, passed on Washington's 15-point proposal, and is willing to host meetings.

On March 23, Trump announced a halt to all threatened strikes against power plants and energy infrastructure for five days. In Thursday's post, he said he had announced the new pause in response to an Iranian request, although there was no immediate reaction from Tehran.

THREAT REMAINS. On March 23, US President Donald Trump announced a halt to all threatened strikes against Iran's power plants and energy infrastructure for five days REUTERS

IRAN'S RESPONSE

Iran has said it will respond with its own strikes on energy facilities in the Gulf region if Trump follows through with his threat.

Iran has effectively blocked the Strait of Hormuz, which carries about 20 per cent of global oil and liquefied natural gas, driving up energy prices and roiling financial markets.

Millions of civilians in the region rely on electricity to power their cities and supply fresh water from desalination plants.

Strikes on three buildings in the Pardisan area of Qom, south of Tehran, killed at least six people, Iranian media reported. In Tehran, rescue workers from the Red Crescent pulled a survivor from rubble.

In Urumia, in the northwest, a direct missile strike on a housing complex killed and injured several civilians, with rescue operations continuing, Iranian media said.

IRANIAN ARRESTS

In the west Iranian province of Kermanshah, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it had arrested a three-member cell linked to Israel's Mossad spy agency that had planned attacks on sensitive sites and military personnel, Iranian media reported. In the central province of Isfahan, authorities arrested more than 15 people alleged to work for the foreign-based Iran International and Manoto TV networks, which state media describe as Israeli-affiliated.

UAE to join battle for Strait of Hormuz

Reuters

The United Arab Emirates has told the US and other Western allies it would participate in a multinational maritime taskforce to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, the *Financial Times* reported on Friday, citing people familiar with the matter.

The UAE is trying to push dozens of countries to create a 'Hormuz Security Force' to defend the strait from Iranian attacks and escort shipping, the report added. The UAE has faced more Iranian attacks than any other country in the region, including Israel.

Several US allies have said they have no immediate plans to send ships to unblock the Strait of Hormuz, rebuffing a Trump request for military support to keep the vital waterway open.

TALKS OPEN

France said on Thursday it had held talks with around 35 countries seeking partners and proposals for a mission to reopen the strait, but only once the US-Israeli war on Iran ends. Iran has effectively blocked the Strait of Hormuz, which carries about 20 per cent of global oil and liquefied natural gas, spiking energy prices.

The UAE is also working on a UN Security Council resolution with Bahrain to provide any future task force with a mandate, but Russia and China could oppose the move.

UN'S EFFORTS

The UN Security Council members have begun negotiating resolutions to protect commercial shipping in and around the Strait of Hormuz, including a Bahraini draft that would authorise the use of "all necessary means", *Reuters* reported earlier this week.

Last week, a senior Emirati official said UAE may join a US-led effort to protect shipping in the Strait of Hormuz after Iran all but shut the waterway to ships. The waterway is vital to the economy of the UAE, a major oil exporter and trade hub. Iran has repeatedly attacked an Emirati port that is used for loading oil exports.

US to start Hormuz ships insurance programme soon

Bloomberg

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said a US insurance programme meant to boost shipping through the Strait of Hormuz will begin soon, a move that may help revive flows of much of the world's oil and gas supplies.

Bessent's predictions, delivered on Thursday during a meeting of President Donald Trump's Cabinet at the White House, come weeks after the President first announced the US International Development Finance Corporation would provide insurance guarantees with naval escorts to help ensure safe passage for oil tankers and other vessels through the strait. The insurance programme was first unveiled on March 3, there's no evidence that any vessels benefiting from the initiative have passed through the strait.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent

"Your bold actions, like the Development Finance Corporation's maritime reinsurance program, in conjunction with Central Command, will soon provide shippers through the Gulf region with a level of security we have never seen before," Bessent said.

SWEEPING FEARS

Bessent's remarks were delivered amid increasing concerns about spiking oil and gas prices during the Iran war. Trump's now-postponed threat to hit power plants in Iran was met by the Islamic Republic's vow that, in response, it would close the Strait of Hormuz "completely".

Insuring vessels is still possible, albeit at a very high cost.

The Lloyd's of London insurance market will continue to provide cover for ships travelling through the waterway, according to Chief Executive Officer Patrick Tiernan. The suggests it is the threat of lethal military strikes from Iran, rather than a lack of insurance.

But Bessent argued that the US economy is better able to withstand short-term energy disruption, thanks to Trump's policies.

Brace for $200 per barrel oil if the war lasts till June, warns Macquarie

Bloomberg

Crude oil may hit a record $200 a barrel if the Iran war drags on till June, with the Strait of Hormuz staying shut, Macquarie Group Ltd has said.

A conflict that stretches through the second quarter would result in historically high real prices, analysts, including Vikas Dwivedi, said in a note, outlining a scenario with odds of 40 per cent. An alternative outlook, with probability of 60 per cent, suggested the war may finish at the end of this month, they said.

RECORD MONTHLY RISE

Brent crude is on pace for a record monthly gain in March, as the war between the US, Israel and Iran has rocked the oil-rich Middle East. The conflict has seen Tehran oversee a near-complete closure of the Strait of Hormuz, severely restricting flows of energy that are vital to the global economy.

"If the Strait were to stay closed for an extended period, prices would need to move high enough to destroy an historically large amount of global oil demand," the analysts said in the March 27 report. "The timing of the reopening of the straits, and physical damage to energy infrastructure, is the main determinant of the longer-term impact on commodities." Brent was last near $107 a barrel on Friday, after touching $119.50 earlier this month. The benchmark set a nominal peak of $147.50 in 2008, according to data compiled by Bloomberg.

China launches tit-for-tat probes against US trade ahead of Xi-Trump summit in May

Bloomberg

China started a pair of investigations into US trade practices, retaliating against similar probes by the Trump administration as the superpowers stake out positions before an expected presidential summit in May.

The move, announced by the Ministry of Commerce on Friday, is a direct mirror of steps US President Donald Trump took to revive his tariff agenda after the Supreme Court last month struck down some of his duties.

"China expresses its strong dissatisfaction and firm opposition to these actions," a Commerce Ministry spokesperson said in a statement, referring to the so-called Section 301 investigations initiated on March 11.

The Chinese measures come days after the White House said Trump will travel to China in mid-May to meet with President Xi Jinping for a summit delayed by the US conflict with Iran.

POWER PLAY

The attacks on Iran, a diplomatic partner of China, brought new strains to US-China ties, although both governments have sought a path of engagement. Relations are also dogged by lingering issues including China's record trade surplus and US arms sales to Taiwan, a self-ruled democracy China claims as its territory. Beijing hasn't yet confirmed Trump's visit to China.

Each of the new investigations carries a six-month deadline, with a possible three-month extension, giving Beijing a legal justification for leverage.

One such probe, brought separately against Mexico in September, concluded Monday. Beijing found the country's tariffs on Chinese goods to be trade barriers and vowed to defend its interests.

QUICKLY.

Gold rises on dip-buying, set for 4th weekly loss

Gold prices rose on Friday on dip-buying but were still headed for a fourth straight weekly loss, with gains capped by rising expectations of US rate hikes. Spot gold rose 0.9 per cent to $4,416.90 per ounce as of 1334 GMT. US gold futures for April delivery gained 0.8 per cent to $4,411.10. REUTERS

Crude oil up nearly 3% but set for 1st weekly decline

London: Crude oil prices rose but were set for their first weekly decline since February 9 as Trump extended a pause in attacks on Iran, though investors remain cagey about prospects for ceasefire. Brent crude futures rose by $3 to $111.01 a barrel by 1118 GMT. US WTI futures were up $2.59 at $97.07. REUTERS

Copper steady, aluminium falls on ceasefire hopes

London: Copper prices were steady, while aluminium fell as US President Donald Trump extended a deadline for striking Iran's energy plants. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME was down 0.1 per cent at $12,132 a tonne by 1049 GMT. Aluminium fell 1 per cent to $3,235.50. Tin gained 2.1 per cent to $44,855 a tonne. REUTERS

50% of key reservoirs half empty, add to farmers' woes

TRIPLE THREAT. Fertilizer supply risks from the Iran war, the looming threat of El Nino and widespread rain deficiency since January are raising concerns

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

At least 50 per cent of India's 166 major reservoirs are half empty, raising concerns with a major part of the country being rain-deficient since the beginning of the year.

The overall storage also declined to below 50 per cent of the total capacity.

It could be a testing period for Indian agriculture, given the problems arising out of the Iran war and a higher probability of El Nino emerging after June this year.

The storage in the major reservoirs is higher than a year ago and normal (past 10 years), but the likely scenario that could unfold over the next 2-3 months will have some impact.

STORAGE POSITION

According to the Central Water Commission (CWC), the storage in the 166 major reservoirs was 46.54 per cent of the 183.565 billion cubic metres (BCM) capacity at 85.432 BCM.

The level was 10.5 percentage points higher than last year and 21 percentage points more than normal.

STRESS SIGNALS

The CWC's weekly bulletin on the reservoirs' storage showed that only 10 per cent of the reservoirs were filled to over 80 per cent of the capacity, while the level in 82 was below 50 per cent of the capacity.

Storage in the southern and central regions was lower than a year ago. However, storage in Assam, West Bengal, Karnataka and Telangana was worrisome.

In the 47 reservoirs of the southern region, the level was 38.2 per cent (39 per cent a year ago) against the 55.288 BCM capacity at 21.119 BCM, with the storage in all the States below 50 per cent.

SOUTH SUFFERING

Barring Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, the level is lower than last year in the rest.

In Andhra Pradesh, the level was 43 per cent, while it was 36.5 per cent in Karnataka, 40.5 per cent in Kerala, 45 per cent in Tamil Nadu and 33 per cent in Telangana.

Reservoir status of key States vs normal (in %)

States	Departure from normal
West Bengal	-29.09
Madhya Pradesh	-4.21
Uttar Pradesh	26.98
Punjab	58.88
Rajasthan	33.68
Andhra Pradesh	53.92
Karnataka	17.78
Tamil Nadu	3.62
Gujarat	55.14
Maharashtra	26.92
Telangana	33.00

Source: Central Water Commission

In the central region's 28 reservoirs, storage was 45.81 per cent (46.83 per cent) or 22.256 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity.

The level in Madhya Pradesh was lower than last year at 42 per cent (50 per cent).

In Chhattisgarh, storage was 70 per cent, while it was 49 per cent and 40 per cent in Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand.

In the western region, the level was the highest at 60 per cent.

Storage in the 53 reservoirs in the region was 22.863 BCM out of the 38.094 BCM capacity.

Gujarat dams were filled to 61 per cent, while those in Goa and Maharashtra were filled to 56 per cent and 59 per cent, respectively.

NORTH, EAST CONCERNS

The level in the 11 reservoirs in the northern region was 45 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 8.845 BCM.

Storage in Himachal was 38 per cent, but it was 58 per cent and 54 per cent respectively in Punjab and Rajasthan.

The 27 reservoirs in the eastern region had storage of 47.5 per cent. The level was 10.349 BCM of the 21.759 BCM capacity.

The level in West Bengal, a key rice-growing State, is 25 per cent, while in Assam it was down to 17 per cent.

The level in Jharkhand was 60.5 per cent, while in Odisha it was 49 per cent.

INPUT COST PRESSURES

Experts said the problem for Indian agriculture is that fertilizer prices have surged in the global market, and this could affect imports.

Farmers may be selective in applying crop inputs, which could affect the yield.

Though the storage is higher than normal and a year ago, the possibility of El Nino could result in the reservoirs not being replenished if the South-West monsoon turns out to be deficient.

Such an eventuality will affect the kharif and rabi crop prospects, they said.

INFLATION RISKS

This is likely to lead to food inflation, which is poised to rise in the coming months due to higher fuel prices.

Storage in the major reservoirs will likely drop further as summer sets in. However, much will depend on the pre-monsoon rain.

Cotton prices gain as domestic demand rises on weakening rupee

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Cotton prices in India have increased further on demand from spinning mills and the trade. Domestic prices are tracking the upward movement in the global price trend, even as the weakening of the rupee against the dollar is making imports expensive.

On Friday, the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI), currently the largest stock holder in the country, increased the natural fibre's prices by ₹300 per candy (of 356 kg). Including today's revision, CCI's price list has improved by ₹1,900 a candy since the beginning of this month.

CCI Chairman-cum-Managing Director Lalit Gupta told *businessline* that the upward revision in prices was following the global price trend. There is a good demand for cotton and yarn.

"We have been able to sell 39 lakh bales (of 170 kg each) in March itself out of the total procurement of 1.05 crore bales, which indicates a good demand," he said.

ROBUST SALES. CCI sold 39 lakh bales in March on higher offtake as imports have turned pricey

ICE FUTURES UP 14%

Cotton futures on the ICE have gained over 14 per cent since early March and are hovering above 69 cents per pound for May 2026 delivery and above 71 cents for July delivery.

"The way rupee is depreciating and ICE Futures are going up, cotton price for good quality is likely to up in the coming days," said Atul Ganatra, former President of the Cotton Association of India (CAI).

Ramanuja Das Boob, a sourcing agent in Raichur, said demand is going up as strong dollar and rising global prices are making the imports expensive.

"There is a good demand for cotton from not only the mills, but also the multinational trading firms as they are finding the Indian prices attractive at current levels as rupee weakens further against the dollar," he said.

In the recent weeks, the demand for the Indian cotton yarn has also gone up from countries such as China, Bangladesh and Vietnam amidst the disruption in the global supply chain due to the ongoing war.

With eateries shut due to LPG shortage, tea loses flavour

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

The ongoing LPG shortage dampened tea demand at the Kochi auction market this week, as reduced operations of hotels and roadside eateries led to a decline in local buying.

Traders said purchases weakened significantly with many restaurants and tea stalls remaining shut, impacting overall consumption in the State.

SHIFT IN MARKET

Anil George, President of the Tea Trade Association of Cochin, said bazaar demand declined amid LPG shortages affecting tea outlets, while export interest was limited to lower-end teas.

There has been a decisive shift in market sentiment, with tightening demand and external disruptions exerting clear downward pressure on prices.

Demand remained fair but distinctly selective, as prices of popular liquoring grades slid by ₹3-₹5, while medium and plainer varieties declined by ₹2-₹3 per kg.

Buyer participation was measured with blenders operating selectively, he said.

CTC DUSTS DOWN

At sale 13, the CTC dust market dropped by around ₹5 per kg, with blenders absorbing only 64 per cent of the 6,57,741 kg on offer, according to Forbes, Ewart & Figgis.

Good liquoring teas saw prices fall by ₹2-₹3, and even more for powdery grades, despite 88 per cent demand.

Plainer tea prices were irregular, often selling at lower rates, with some lots withdrawn due to weak demand.

The orthodox dust segment tea prices declined, with exporters and upcountry buyers purchasing only small quantities of the 10,500 kg offered at the auctions.

In orthodox leaf, the unrest in West Asia led to subdued demand in the Gulf markets, while CIS and neighbouring countries remained active in purchasing.

The offered quantity was 1,62,652 kg, with whole leaf generally sold at firm to dearer levels.

Brokens were firm to dearer, while the rest were irregular and lower, witnessing some withdrawal.

The CTC leaf market was good with medium brokens and fannings irregular and lower.

The offered quantity was 38,500 kg with sales percentage of 72.

West Asia makes up 1/5th of India's agri exports, govt monitoring situation closely: Jitin Prasada

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Countries in the West Asia region, key markets for agricultural products exports from India, contribute nearly one-fifth to the total agricultural exports of India, according to the government.

In a written reply in the Rajya Sabha on Friday, Jitin Prasada, Union Minister of State for Commerce and Industry, said the West Asia region, particularly the Gulf Cooperation Council countries such as the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Kuwait, Qatar, Bahrain and countries such as Iran, Iraq and Yemen, are key markets for Indian agricultural products.

Exports of agricultural products destined to these countries were $10.68 billion in 2024-25. This was nearly 20.5 per cent of India's overall agri exports, he said.

Agricultural exports to the region are broad-based and comprise all major product categories, such as cereals, animal products, basmati rice, buffalo meat, fresh fruits and vegetables, spices and processed food products from India.

The government is closely monitoring the evolving geopolitical situation in West Asia and the Gulf region, including its impact on India's external trade, shipping routes and logistics chains.

Exporters have reported disruptions in terms of increased freight rates, imposition of war-risk surcharges, container shortages, delays in shipment schedules and congestion at ports, he said.

To another query, Prasada said the exports of processed food items to the EU had grown by approximately 49.5 per cent during the period

Jitin Prasada, Union Minister of State for Commerce and Industry

2020-21 to 2024-25, while the exports of processed food products to West Asian countries had risen by approximately 18 per cent during the same period.

SEED PRODUCTIVITY UP

Replying to a question on improvements in productivity of pulses and oilseeds, Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Union Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare Minister, said a total of 917 high-yielding climate resilient varieties had been notified between 2014 and 2025. This includes 444 varieties of oilseeds and 473 varieties of pulses.

"Of these, 317 varieties of oilseeds (71 per cent) and 362 varieties of pulses (77 per cent) are in the seed chain and are being cultivated by farmers across the country," he said.

AGRI INFRA FUND

In a written reply to a question on the implementation of the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF), Ramnath Thakur, Union Minister of State for Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare, said the government had sanctioned ₹84,502.78 crore for 1,70,241 projects across the country till March 11.

Stating that the disbursement of funds in phases is linked to project milestones as per AIF guidelines, he said ₹62,219.10 crore had been disbursed till March 11.

War-driven supply shocks hit coir exporters

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

Ongoing geopolitical tensions and war-related disruptions have triggered a severe raw material crisis for India's coir and rubber doormat exporters, prompting calls for urgent government intervention.

Exporters say they face an unprecedented crunch as shortages and steep price spikes in key inputs threaten their ability to fulfil international orders.

Makers of PVC-backed coir mats and rubber doormats are reporting acute shortages of PVC resin, plasticisers, synthetic rubber chemicals and critical additives — many either imported or linked to global petrochemical supply chains.

Roby Francis, Chairman, and Sajan B Nair, Secretary General of the Federation of Indian Coir Exporters Association (FICEA), said availability had fallen sharply, leading to shipment delays, supply uncertainty and thinning inventories.

COST PRESSURE. Shortages and steep price escalations of key inputs threaten their ability to fulfil existing global orders

SUPPLY WOES

The crisis stems from supply bottlenecks tied to ongoing conflicts, including reduced output in affected regions, logistical hurdles and freight volatility. Exporters with large, pre-committed orders from major US and European retailers are among the worst hit.

With most contracts locked in months earlier at fixed prices, manufacturers cannot pass on higher input costs, squeezing margins.

Erratic raw material supply has also disrupted production schedules. FICEA noted that the US accounts for over 60 per cent of exports in this segment, making it a crucial market. However, a 50 per cent tariff on exports to the US since August 2025 had compounded the strain.

Many buyers have cut orders, while exporters are offering steep discounts on existing contracts, further hurting profitability.

CALL FOR GOVT AID

The association has sought immediate relief, including temporary duty cuts on imported inputs, financial support to offset rising costs, smoother import logistics, and steps to boost domestic production of critical materials.

With no near-term easing of geopolitical tensions, exporters warn of order cancellations, loss of key clients and long-term impact on India's position in the global coir and rubber mats market.

Global steel production goes south by 2.2% in February

Sneha Joseph
Chennai

Global steel output plummeted to 141.8 million tonnes (mt) in February 2026, a decrease of 2.2 per cent when compared with the same period a year earlier.

The top producer China recorded a drop of 3.6 per cent in its production to 76.1 mt while India's output reached 13.6 mt, an increase of 7.7 per cent.

The US' production also went north by 5.8 per cent at 6.5 mt. Meanwhile, Japan's numbers stayed flat at 6.4 mt.

RUSSIA, OTHER CIS

Russia's output decreased by 10.2 per cent at 5 mt. Similarly, the production of Brazil and Iran also showed a drop of 5.7 per cent at 2.5 mt and 1.3 per cent at 1.7 mt, respectively.

South Korea saw a marginal increase of 0.2 per cent in its output at 4.8 mt.

Germany's production went up by 4.8 per cent at 2.8 mt and Türkiye had 3 mt of output, up 3.4 per cent.

Region wise, Africa witnessed an increase of 4.7 per cent in its steel production at 2 mt in February 2026. Asia and Oceania produced 105.3 mt, down 1.9 per cent.

The European Union's numbers went south by 3.6 per cent at 9.8 mt while Europe (Other) had a 3.1 per cent rise in its output at 3.4 mt.

West Asia's steel production surged by 0.1 per cent at 3.7 mt.

North America also recorded an increase of 0.5 per cent in its production at 8.5 mt.

However, the output of Russia and other CIS + Ukraine slipped 10.5 per cent to 6 mt. South America also had a 7.7 per cent dip in its production at 3.1 mt.

GEMA urges govt to raise ethanol blending beyond 20%

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

While welcoming the Centre's decision to rationalise excise duties on petrol and other petroleum products with immediate effect, the Grain Ethanol Manufacturers Association (GEMA) has asked the government to push for ethanol blending beyond 20 per cent.

CK Jain, President of GEMA, said the present moment offers an important opportunity to move decisively towards higher ethanol blending beyond E20.

Expanding blending levels further will strengthen India's long-term fuel security, create additional demand for domestic agricultural feedstocks, such as maize and grain, and provide greater stability to motor spirit pricing in future years, he said.

E20 BLENDING SUCCESS

A media statement said that India's ethanol blending programme has already emerged as one of the strongest policy instruments for reducing import dependence, supporting farmers, saving foreign exchange and creating domestic energy resilience.

The success achieved under E20 blending clearly demonstrates that ethanol is no longer only an environmental choice, but a strategic economic shield for the nation.

Welcoming the government's decision to rationalise excise duties on motor spirit and related petroleum products, GEMA said this will help maintain stability in fuel prices for consumers across the country.

Valley bets big on homegrown tulips

Nabard-backed project aims to curb ₹300-400 cr annual imports

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

At the Mountain Crop Research Station (MCRS) in the Valley, efforts are being stepped up to cultivate tulips and develop seeds locally to cut import dependence. Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences and Technology (SKUAST-K) is setting up a Centre of Excellence for Tulip and Bulb Production at Sagam in Anantnag, about 76 km from Srinagar. Scientists aim to propagate tulips and supply seeds and bulbs to gardens nationwide.

PROJECT DETAILS

Spread over 407 kanals, the ₹8-crore project, backed by the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (Nabard), focuses on land and infrastructure development.

"The idea is to reduce dependence on imported tulip bulbs," said Mohammad Ayoub Mantoo, Head, MCRS, adding that indigenous seeds and bulbs will be supplied across the country. He expects output to begin in about three years.

India spends an estimated ₹300-400 crore annually on tulip bulb imports, underlining heavy reliance on overseas suppliers.

TOURISM BOOST

The garden — now the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden — sprawling across 74 acres at the foothills of the Zabarwan range, draws lakhs of visitors each spring.

Officials say developing indigenous varieties and scaling local bulb production can cut costs and stabilise supply. Research institutions in Kashmir are intensifying work to adapt tulips to local conditions and produce high-quality bulbs capable of replacing imports over time.

QUICKLY.

Centre lets BHEL procure key items from China

New Delhi: The Centre on Friday relaxed norms to allow State-owned Bharat Heavy Electricals to procure 21 types of critical equipment from countries with which it shares a land border, a government order showed, paving the way for procurements from China. New Delhi has also eased restrictions on Chinese investments in select sectors to help ease a capital squeeze, marking a significant reset of economic ties after six years of friction. REUTERS

More time likely for renewing driver licence

New Delhi: The government has proposed to amend the Motor Vehicle Act to allow a 30-day grace period for renewal after the expiry of a driving licence. The licence will continue to remain valid during the grace period. This is part of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada in the Lok Sabha. PTI

RBI mandates identifiers for market transactions

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday mandated the use of Legal Entity Identifier (LEI) and Unique Transaction Identifier (UTI) for transactions in financial markets. These identifiers are key global standards for promoting transparency in the financial markets, the RBI said in a release. LEI code is a 20-character unique identity code assigned to entities that are parties to a financial transaction. For users/clients undertaking non-derivative foreign exchange transactions, this shall be applicable, said the RBI. UTI is assigned to an OTC derivative transaction. PTI

About ₹2.38 lakh crore worth big ticket acquisitions cleared by DAC

MORE MUSCLE. Total purchases cleared under Acceptance of Necessity in FY26 is ₹6.73 lakh crore for 55 deals

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

About ₹2.38 lakh crore worth big ticket acquisitions were cleared by the Defence Acquisition Council (DAC) in its last meeting of 2025-26 on Friday, including orders for 60 medium transport aircraft (MTA), additional S-400 long range surface-to-air missile system, and the Dhanush gun system. With this, the total number of proposals cleared in this financial year went up to 55, totalling ₹6.73 lakh crore.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, who chaired the DAC meeting, said the decisions will help in further strengthening India's defence preparedness. "It's heart warming to note that in the financial year 2025-26, AoN (Acceptance of Necessity) for 55 proposals amounting to ₹6.73 lakh crore has been accorded by the DAC. Moreover, capital procurement contracts have been signed for 503 proposals amounting to ₹2.28 lakh crore. This is the highest number in any given financial year," he posted on X.

For the Army, approvals were accorded for the air defence (AD) tracked system, armoured piercing tank ammunition, high capacity radio relay, Dhanush gun system and runway independent aerial surveillance system, said the Ministry of Defence in a statement.

The AD tracked system will provide real time air defence control and reporting capability, while the high capacity radio relay is meant to offer reliable and fail proof communication in a hostile electronic warfare environment, as per the Ministry.

ARTILLERY POWER

The Army is expected to order 300 Dhanush gun systems to expand its fleet, enhancing the artillery's capabilities to engage targets at longer ranges in all terrains with enhanced lethality and accuracy. The decision comes at a time when the CBI continues to probe alleged use of Chinese components in the gun manufacturing, which were reportedly passed off as German imports.


Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh

The runway independent aerial surveillance system, which is a remotely piloted unmanned system, will boost surveillance capabilities of the Army units, with the armoured piercing tank ammunition offering lethality to the firepower.

Proposals were also cleared for the procurement of 60 medium transport aircrafts more than three months after the Air Force issued a Request For Information seeking replacement of its ageing transport fleet of AN32 and IL76.

Earlier this month, the Defence Acquisition Board, headed by Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, cleared the acquisition of 60 MTAs, expected to cost around ₹1 lakh crore.

The Ministry stated that the induction of MTA will meet the strategic, tactical and operational airlift requirements of the Services.

India is expected to get delivery of the remaining two S-400s, delayed for a long time owing to the war between Russia and Ukraine, by 2026–2027.

According to the MoD, the remotely piloted strike aircraft will enable undertaking offensive counter and coordinated air operations, besides providing stealth intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance activities.

The overhaul of Su-30 aero engine and its aggregates cleared in DAC meeting, will increase the service life of the aircraft and fulfil the operational requirement of the Air Force.

For the Coast Guard, AoN was accorded for purchase of hovercraft or heavy duty air cushion vehicles. These vehicles will be used for multi-purpose maritime coastal operational roles, including high-speed coastal patrolling, reconnaissance, search and rescue operations, stated the Ministry.

Govt to scrap jail term for non-compliance of orders under Jan Vishwas Bill

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government has proposed to scrap jail terms for non-compliance with orders or directions issued under the Electricity Act, but raised the penalty to the extent of ₹10 lakh under the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, tabled in the Lok Sabha on Friday.

The Bill also proposed to omit the clause related to the penalty for extinguishing public lamps, besides streamlining penal provisions under the Electricity Act.

Section 141 of the Electricity Act provides, "Whoever, maliciously extinguishes any public lamp shall be punishable with a fine which may be extended to two thousand rupees."

Section 146 deals with 'Punishment for non-compliance of orders or directions.'

COMPLIANCE RULES

The Bill proposed that instead of "imprisonment for a term which may extend to three months or with fine which may extend to one lakh rupees, or with both," the words "fine which shall not be less than ten thousand rupees but which may extend to ten lakh rupees" shall be substituted.

In the case of a continuing failure to comply with the directions or orders of the power regulators, it proposed that it "may extend to five thousand rupees," the words "which shall not be less than one thousand rupees but which may extend to fifty thousand rupees" shall be substituted.

Thus, the fine will range between ₹1,000 and ₹50,000 for continuing failure to comply with the order or directions. The Bill also proposed to streamline the penalty under Section 139, which deals with negligently wasting electricity or injuring workers.

NEW PROVISION

The Section is replaced by a new provision which says, "Whoever, negligently breaks, injures, throws down or damages any material connected with the supply of electricity, shall be liable to a penalty not less than five thousand rupees but which may extend to one lakh rupees, to be imposed by an officer duly authorised by the appropriate government".

For repeated such offence, it proves that "such person shall, for the second or subsequent offence, be punished with a fine not less than five thousand rupees, but which may extend to one lakh rupees".

Presently, the offence is punishable with a fine which may extend to ₹10,000.

For the penalty for maliciously wasting electricity or injuring work under Section 140, the bill proposed that for the words "which may extend to ten thousand rupees", the words "which shall not be less than five thousand rupees but may extend to one lakh rupees" shall be substituted.

RBI outlines 3-year roadmap for digital payments ecosystem

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday released 'Payments Vision 2028', which envisages a switch on/switch off facility across all digital payment modes, introducing a Payments Switching Service (PaSS), a Shared Responsibility Framework arising from unauthorised digital payment transactions and launching electronic cheques.

The Payments Vision lays out a roadmap for the evolution of India's payments ecosystem over the next three years.

It consists of 15 specific initiatives, which focus on user empowerment, strengthening safeguards against fraud, enhancing efficiency of cross-border payment frameworks and promoting ease of doing business, among others.

The central bank plans to extend the switch on and switch off facility for domestic and international card transactions, currently available to customers and helps them exercise greater control over their cards, to all digital payment modes.

SMOOTH TRANSITION

To address the challenges faced by customers in managing their payment instructions in case their account number changes due to shifting to another bank, merger of banks, the RBI will examine the feasibility of implementing a 'Payments Switching Service'.

This centralised service would facilitate migration of payment instructions, both incoming and outgoing, from one account to another.

To ensure balanced accountability, the RBI will explore introducing a shared responsibility framework under which both the customer's bank (issuer) and the beneficiary's bank jointly bear the liability arising from unauthorised digital payment transactions.

ELECTRONIC CHEQUES

To create a more integrated, efficient and accessible receivables discounting ecosystem for the MSMEs, the RBI is likely to introduce full interoperability across Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) platforms to harness efficiencies, competitive spirits, and avoid duplication of efforts; factoring with recourse; and trade receivables discounting of export MSMEs.

A comprehensive review of the design and security features of cheques to enable the speed and reliability of electronic payments, and the introduction of electronic cheques will be explored.

India to buy Russia-made Tunguska Air Defence Missiles for ₹445 crore

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) on Friday signed contracts, totalling ₹858 crore, to procure Tunguska Air Defence Missile System from JSC Rosoboronexport of Russia, and depot level inspection of P8I long-range maritime reconnaissance aircraft used by the Navy.

The contract for the procurement of Tunguska Air Defence Missile Systems, valued at ₹445 crore, for the Army, was signed in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh.

With this, the government has added another Russian military hardware after the S-400 to its arsenal bolstering its air defence system as part of its 'Mission Sudarshan Chakra' to shield strategically important assets and regions.

"These cutting-edge missiles will enhance India's multilayered air defence capabilities against aerial threats including aircraft drones and cruise missiles," the Ministry of Defence said.

The Ministry has also signed a deal with Boeing Defence for depo level inspection of the P8I Long -Range Maritime Reconnaissance Aircraft

CREW OF FOUR

The 2S6 Tunguska Air Defence System, which operates through a crew of four — commander, gunner, loader, and driver — is self-propelled and uses a tracked chassis that is mounted with both guns and missiles. The 2S6 Tunguska is designed to protect tank and motorised units from low-flying targets and personnel of the enemy.

The 30mm guns can fire at a rate of 5,000 rounds per minute and missiles have a 8-km range to strike at the target. The deal for depot-level inspection and maintenance of the Navy's P-8I long-range maritime reconnaissance aircraft fleet is worth ₹413 crore. The contract with Boeing Defence India is meant to enhance operation preparedness given that it will reduce maintenance downtime of the P-8Is.

RBI penalises three banks, Pine Labs for flouting norms

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) imposed penalties on Union Bank of India, Bank of India, Central Bank of India, and Pine Labs for non-compliance with certain directions. It imposed ₹95.4 lakh penalty on Union Bank of India, ₹63.6 lakh on Central Bank of India, ₹58.5 lakh on Bank of India, and ₹3.1 lakh on Pine Labs, the RBI said in a release.

SERVICE FAILURE

Monetary penalty on the Union Bank of India was imposed as the lender did not credit the amount involved in unauthorised electronic transactions to certain customers' accounts within 10 working days from the date of such notification by the customer, did not provide customers with 24x7 access to report unauthorised banking transactions, and resorted to manual intervention in the System-based asset classification process in certain KCC accounts.

In the case of the Central Bank of India, the penalty was imposed as the bank failed to upload the KYC (Know Your Customer) records of certain customers onto the Central KYC Records Registry within the prescribed timeline

Bank of India was penalised for collecting ad-hoc service charges/inspection charges/processing charges in certain priority sector loan accounts, and not paying interest on certain Term Deposit Receipts from the date of maturity till the date of their repayment

Pine Labs issued several Full-KYC Prepaid Payment Instruments without completing the KYC of the PPI holders, due to which the penalty was imposed.

ED files one more chargesheet against RCom ex-Director

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed a prosecution complaint in a Rouse Avenue court against Punit Garg, the former Director of Reliance Communications (RCom) Ltd, in an alleged money laundering case linked to the overall ₹40,000 crore-worth bank fraud.

The ED's prosecution complaint or chargesheet has been marked to Special Judge Ajay Gupta and will come up for hearing on Saturday, said sources. The interim bail of Garg, arrested on January 29, will also be heard by the Special Judge on the same day.

Garg, arrested by the ED in January this year, during his stint at senior managerial and directorial positions in RCom from 2001 to 2025, was allegedly actively involved in the acquisition, possession, concealment, layering and dissipation of proceeds of crime generated from the said bank fraud, the ED said earlier.

LAUNDERED FUNDS

The agency alleged that the laundered funds were "diverted" through multiple foreign subsidiaries and offshore entities of RCom.

The ED, in its probe, allegedly found out that the proceeds of financial crime were diverted to purchase a luxury condominium apartment in Manhattan, New York, US. Interestingly, as per the agency, the property was offloaded during RCom's Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) fraudulently by Garg.

The money trail revealed that the sale proceeds of $8.3 million were remitted from the US under the guise of a sham investment arrangement with a Dubai-based entity controlled by a Pakistan-linked individual, without the knowledge or consent of the Resolution Professional.

Not just that, the investigators charged that a part of the public money taken as bank loans by RCom was routed for Garg's personal expenses, including overseas education-related payments of his children.

This a fresh chargesheet filed by the ED.

Japan commits ₹16,420 crore ODA loan for metro, healthcare and agri projects

Asian News International
New Delhi

The Government of Japan has committed Official Development Assistance (ODA) loan of ¥275.858 billion (₹16,420 crore) to India for four projects in urban transport, health and agriculture to be implemented in Punjab, Karnataka and Maharashtra, according to an official release by the Ministry of Finance.

The notes were exchanged on March 24 between the Joint Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs, Ministry of Finance, Government of India, Alok Tiwari, and the Ambassador of Japan to India, Keiichi Ono.

The projects include the Bengaluru Metro Rail Project (Phase 3) (I) ¥102.480 billion, Mumbai Metro Line 11 Project ¥92.400 billion, Project for Strengthening Tertiary Medical Healthcare Delivery, Medical Education System & Nursing Education System in Maharashtra (I) ¥62.294 billion, and the Project for Promoting Sustainable Horticulture in Punjab (¥18.684 billion).

TRAFFIC DEMAND

According to the release, the Bengaluru and Mumbai Metro Rail projects aim to cope with the increase of traffic demand in the cities by expanding the mass rapid transportation system, promoting regional economic development, improving the urban environment and eventually mitigating climate change, through relief of traffic congestion and decrease of pollution caused by increasing motor vehicles.

The healthcare project in Maharashtra aims to improve access and quality of medical care in the State by construction of tertiary care facilities, colleges, hospitals, medical colleges and nursing schools.

SUSTAINABLE VENTURE

This shall further contribute towards the promotion of universal health coverage in India.

The project for sustainable horticulture in Punjab aims to improve farmers' income by diversifying into high-value horticulture crops, and infrastructure development for a stronger value chain and capacity development.

This shall leverage environmental conservation and sustainable socio-economic development in Punjab.

Krafton holds first BGMI e-sports event in Chennai

Rohan Das
Chennai

Krafton India, the game publisher behind Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI), hosted the finals of its BGIS 2026, an open for all e-sports event here on Wednesday.

Held in Chennai for the first time, BGIS 2026 will see 16 of the top teams at the tournament fight it out over a three-day final for a prize pool of ₹4 crore. The top teams were selected after multiple qualification rounds which saw over 2 lakh participants, competing in teams of four.

Speaking to *businessline* on the sidelines of the event, Karan Mahesh Pathak, Associate Director of Esports at Krafton India, said that the publisher now hosts four flagships e-sports events every year. He mentioned that the company will add more events to the calendar next year, without disclosing the exact details.

In terms of how e-sports contributes to the Krafton's overall revenue, he said that the goal is not to monetise these events but build the larger gaming ecosystem. "Right now there is no revenue and we are putting money into the ecosystem," he added. Over the long-term, the events will give more of a visibility to Krafton's games and grow the brand especially among the younger gaming communities, he added.

Speaking about global gaming industry, Pathak said that the industry dynamics in India is different and while the wider tech space might be feeling the stress, the talent situation within India remains stable.

In a first, APSEZ has set up Ports of Refuge at Dighi and Gopalpur

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) has operationalised India's first Ports of Refuge (PoR), on the West and East Coasts. This initiative plugs a long-standing gap in the country's maritime emergency infrastructure, creating a formal mechanism to handle vessels in distress.

APSEZ, which handles nearly 27 per cent of India's port cargo volumes, will designate two locations as PoR — Dighi port on the West Coast and Gopalpur port on the East Coast.

These sites will cater to traffic across the Arabian Sea and routes to the Persian Gulf, as well as vessels operating in the Bay of Bengal and along the Malacca Strait.

A PoR, as defined by the International Maritime Organization, is a designated location where ships can seek shelter to stabilise conditions, protect life and limit environmental damage. While such frameworks are standard across major maritime economies, India had not formalised one until now, the company said in an official release on Friday.

SERVICES OFFERED

The facilities will offer a suite of emergency services, including salvage and wreck removal, firefighting, pollution containment and coordinated response through specialised equipment and trained teams.

The initiative is backed by a tripartite memorandum of understanding with SMIT Salvage, the salvage and emergency response division of Royal Boskalis Westminster NV, and the Maritime Emergency Response Centre.

The partnership is expected to bring global expertise and enable coordinated response capability for maritime emergencies.

The PoR will also support vessels insured under the International Group of Protection and Indemnity Clubs.

QUICKLY.

Novartis to buy Excellergy in deal worth up to $2 b

Novartis AG agreed to buy biotech firm Excellergy Inc for as much as $2 billion, as it tries to strengthen its portfolio of treatments for food allergies and other immunology conditions. The transaction includes upfront and milestone payments, the Swiss drugmaker said on Friday, without giving a breakdown. Novartis has been on a deal streak as its ageing best-sellers face generic competition, prompting the company to project its first profit decline in at least six years. The deal comes after it agreed to buy breast cancer drug firm from Synnovation Therapeutics for as much as $3 billion. BLOOMBERG

US is seeking feedback on bringing call centres back

The Federal Communications Commission (FCC) has mooted proposals to encourage businesses to bring back to the US call centre jobs that are usually outsourced to companies in countries such as India, the Philippines or South Africa. The FCC said that over the past few decades, many corporations had shifted their customer service operations from America to a range of foreign countries, with nearly 70 per cent of US companies outsourcing at least one department. PTI

India faces WTO investment pact heat as Turkey backs off

SOLE RESISTANCE. Delhi is the only major holdout against China-backed plurilateral deal

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India's fight to keep the China-backed Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) pact out of the WTO legal framework has got stiffer with Turkey, one of the three major countries initially objecting to it, formally withdrawing its opposition at the ongoing WTO MC14 in Yaounde, Cameroon.

Now, the responsibility to safeguard the WTO's "consensus-based architecture" falls mostly on India as South Africa had already signalled its intent to step aside during General Council sessions prior to the meeting, say experts. India under pressure on WTO investment pact after Türkiye steps aside

STANDALONE ISSUE

"India's opposition to investment facilitation (IFD) was on its own and not dependent on Turkey's support. While India is the only influential country continuing to oppose investment facilitation, many countries share similar concerns on the larger systemic implications of allowing plurilaterals to become the norm at the WTO. So, the picture on investment facilitation is getting complicated, as countries may no longer see it as a standalone issue," said international trade expert Abhijit Das.

ONUS ON NEW DELHI. The responsibility to safeguard the WTO's 'consensus-based architecture' falls on India

The IFD, supported by 128 WTO members, aims to facilitate FDI flows by enhancing the transparency of investment frameworks, as well as the predictability and efficiency of investment procedures.

Earlier this week, India said that it supported facilitation of FDI flows to developing countries and least developed countries (LDCs), but a government spokesperson added that the country did not believe that the WTO was the right forum to do so.

India has been opposing integration of the IFD in the WTO framework as it is a "non-mandated" initiative pushed as a plurilateral agreement (not involving all members) without full consensus. It would set a precedent for other non-mandated issues gaining legitimacy at the cost of long-pending mandated ones such as food security, it believes.

Some WTO members, mostly led by developed countries, are trying to push for rules on new issues like e-commerce, investment facilitation, services domestic regulation, and micro, small and medium enterprises, bypassing the traditional consensus rule through a plurilateral initiative termed the joint statement initiatives (JSIs).

LEGAL BASIS

India, together with South Africa and Turkey, had been arguing that JSIs have no legal basis under the Marrakesh Agreement (the WTO's founding charter). Specifically, regarding investment, the countries referred to the 2004 General Council decision that explicitly dropped "investment" from the WTO agenda. At the WTO, a subset of members cannot unilaterally revive an issue that was removed by consensus, India had said.

DIVERTED ATTENTION

Moreover, cluttering the negotiating table with new issues without the mandate of the entire membership diverted attention from the long-pending issues of interest to developing countries and LDCs on the table, such as food security and public stockholding programmes and special safeguard measures to protect agriculture against a spike in imports and other problems.

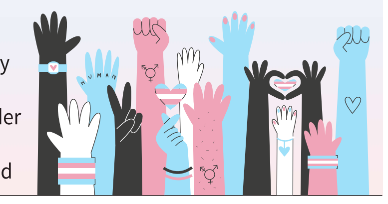
However, with South Africa declaring in December 2025 that it would not resist incorporation of the IFD pact into the WTO legal framework (Annex 4 of the Marrakesh Agreement), and now Turkey following suit, the going will not be easy for India at a decisive meeting on the issue in Yaounde on March 28. "The pressure is definitely higher. Seems like India is the only one holding out. But I am not sure. Let us see how this plays out," a participant at the WTO MC14 told *businessline*.

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic **KS Gunasekar**

Redefining identity and access

The proposed amendments to India's transgender law mark a significant shift from self-identification towards state verification. The changes affect how gender identity is recognised, the process of certification and access to welfare benefits. Speaking to Adv. Kanmani R, transgender woman and advocate, Chennai, this explainer breaks down what is changing and the key concerns being raised



Transgender Bill Amendment — What's changing?

Before	Now (What the amendment proposes)
Definition based on the case, National Legal Services Authority versus Union of India	Redefines "**transgender person**"
Recognised self-perceived gender identity	Removes "**self-perceived identity**"
No mandatory medical proof	Identification subject to **official verification**
Focus on dignity, autonomy and fundamental rights	Government says earlier definition was "**vague**"

New five-stage process

- Application to District Magistrate (DM)
- Appearance before medical board
- Medical board assessment and recommendation
- DM satisfaction review
- DM can overrule and seek other medical opinions

Structural and practical challenges

Medical infrastructure gaps
Many district hospitals lack the required specialists, which could lead to delays and repeated hospital visits

Bureaucratic burden
The new process may increase documentation, discretion and waiting time in an already backlogged system

Economic impact
Repeated visits and medical requirements may impose income loss and additional costs, especially on daily-wage workers

Welfare access paradox

Under the 2019 Act	Under the proposed amendment
A Trans ID card enabled access to welfare schemes like Ayushman Bharat, which could support surgeries and hormone therapy	Medical procedures may be required before obtaining an ID card, making welfare access conditional on prior treatment

Government's stand

- Says earlier law made it difficult to identify "genuine oppressed persons"
- Aims to streamline identification

Experts and activist view

- Call it a rollback of rights
- Argue that it contradicts the spirit of the 2014 Supreme Court ruling
- Warn of marginalisation

What lies ahead?

- Legal challenges possible
- Debate over constitutional validity
- Impact on access to welfare, healthcare and documentation

Hetero launches generic semaglutide overseas

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Hetero has launched its generic semaglutide portfolio in the overseas markets even as it is awaiting regulatory approvals in India. The launch represents the beginning of a strategic, multi-year global rollout across more than 75 countries, as part of Hetero's focus on improving access to advanced cardio-metabolic therapies.

Initial launches are underway in Africa, Asia and West Asia, with further rollouts planned, subject to regulatory approvals.

The injectable semaglutide therapies will be marketed under the brand names Truglyx, Rolmodl and Moto G across markets.

CLINICAL TRIALS

Hetero is currently awaiting approval from India's national regulator, Central

Drug Standard Control Organisation, following the completion of clinical trials in type 2 diabetes and obesity. Launch in India is anticipated post regulatory approvals.

PEN DEVICES

The portfolio will be available in multi-dose disposable pen devices designed in line with innovator formats, and across multiple dose strengths including 0.25 mg, 0.5 mg, 1 mg, 2 mg, 1.7 mg and 2.4 mg, supporting both type 2 diabetes and weight management, and enabling flexible, patient-centric dosing, it added.

Biocon names Tambe as CEO & MD amid full integration of biologics and generics

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Biocon Ltd has appointed Shreehas Tambe as its Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director, effective April 1, 2026, as the company moves to integrate its biosimilars and generics businesses under a unified structure.

Tambe will be the first CEO of the combined entity, following the integration of Biocon Biologics Ltd as a wholly owned subsidiary of Biocon.

The restructuring is aimed at creating a scaled global biopharma platform spanning biosimilars, insulins, complex generics and peptides, including GLP-1 therapies targeting diabetes and obesity.

The company also named Kedar Upadhye as Chief Financial Officer.

Executive Chairperson Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw said the integration marks a strategic shift toward building a globally competitive, innovation-led enterprise. She highlighted Tambe's role in key milestones, including the acquisition and integration of Viatris' biosimilars business, which helped position Biocon Biologics among the world's top five biosimilar companies with a valuation of $5.5 billion.

"It is an honour to lead Biocon at such a pivotal moment as we bring together our biologics and generics businesses to build a leading global medicines company," Tambe said, adding that his focus will be on strengthening the company's foundation, consolidating operations, and accelerating sustainable growth.

LEADERSHIP ROLES

Tambe, who joined Biocon nearly three decades ago as a management trainee, has held multiple leadership roles across the organisation. As CEO of Biocon Biologics, he led its global expansion and oversaw the integration of the Viatris biosimilars business, building a fully integrated, end-to-end biologics platform.

Shreehas Tambe, CEO and MD, Biocon Ltd

Earlier in his career, he played a key role in scaling Biocon's insulins business globally, including establishing a large integrated manufacturing facility in Malaysia. With a background in research and development, Tambe is also an inventor on 61 patents.

SHARPENING FOCUS

The integration comes as Biocon looks to sharpen its focus on high-growth therapy areas such as oncology and immunology, while expanding its global footprint. By bringing its generics and biosimilars businesses under one umbrella, the company aims to improve operational efficiency and strengthen its competitive positioning in regulated markets.

The leadership transition signals Biocon's intent to leverage scale and scientific capabilities to drive long-term growth as it positions itself among a select group of global biopharma companies addressing complex and chronic disease segments.

DGCA introduces new norms for VVIP flights

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Pilots operating VVIP flights shall not be subjected to undue pressure, Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has said in its new regulations that aim to enhance safety.

Any last minute changes to the planned flight due to VIP requirements should be coordinated through the company management only and not directly with the crew, the DGCA order said.

UNDUE PRESSURE

The order, which was issued on Friday, also asks charter operators and State governments to keep a pamphlet in the aircraft, indicating capability and limitations of that aircraft. It must also mention planning and conduct of the flight are professional responsibilities that must remain under the sound judgement of flight crew and engineers.

The pamphlet should also state that VIP passengers respect decisions taken by the crew regarding diversions and that they be free from any external pressure or undue influence.

The directions come two months after the fatal air crash in Baramati, which resulted in the death of Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar. The order covers various aspects, including aircraft airworthiness requirements, crew qualifications, airfield conditions and other operational and safety issues.

According to the order, the flight duty and time limitation in respect of crew members engaged in the operations shall be in accordance with existing regulations. The flight crew will have to ensure strict compliance with visibility and weather requirements.

India's luxury boom stalls amid shortage of malls

Reuters
Mumbai/Paris

In India's rapidly growing economy, millions of newly affluent consumers are fuelling demand for bags and accessories from the likes of Louis Vuitton, Chanel and Dior. But getting to a store can be a problem — there aren't that many of them.

With nearly 1.5 billion people and an economy growing more than 6 per cent, India is expanding faster than China, the luxury industry's growth engine for over a decade.

That said, top brands are struggling to expand amid a severe shortage of high-quality retail space. India only has three true luxury malls: two in New Delhi, the Emporio and the Chanakya, owned by real estate developer DLF, and the Jio World Plaza in Mumbai, owned by the Reliance conglomerate.

MORE SPACE

"We have regular requests from the parent companies — from LVMH Group, from Kering, from Richemont — to give them more space for the brands they want to get into India," said Saurabh Bharara, Head of Luxury

LACKING INFRA. While India holds the potential for greater luxury sales that could offset slowing momentum in other key regions, that promise may go unrealised until more malls are built

Malls at DLF. "We have top 15 brands that are ready to enter India, if we give them space tomorrow," he said, but added that there was "zero availability" right now.

DLF is planning an expansion of the Emporio, which will double its leasable space of 1,60,000 sq ft but will likely only be operational by the end of 2028.

India now ranks fourth globally in the number of individuals with wealth above $100 million, behind the US, China and Japan, according to Knight Frank's Wealth Report 2025.

It also has a rapidly growing middle class. Yet, India's luxury goods market was estimated at just $12.1 billion last year, less than 3 per cent of China's, according to Euromonitor data.

LUXURY SALES

So, while India holds the potential for greater luxury sales that could offset slowing momentum in other key regions, that promise may go unrealised until more malls are built.

"Quality real estate is the single largest stumbling block," said R Satyajit, CEO of International Brands at Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail. The firm opened a franchise of France's famed department store Galeries Lafayette in Mumbai in November, affording some 200 foreign brands an entry into India. Four luxury-focused malls, including the expansion of the Emporio, are being planned, although all are expected to take some years before opening. Of the other three, one will be in Mumbai, another in Hyderabad and one in Gurugram, part of the National Capital Region near New Delhi.

That's given hope to the likes of Chanel's Managing Director Amit Goyal, who said although "there are currently only a few luxury malls in the country, several promising projects are in development," adding that a store in Mumbai is a near-term priority for the brand.

Some high-end labels have set up shop in less exclusive but still premium malls. Encouraged by what it calls a young confident Indian Gen-Z population, luxury sneaker brand Golden Goose has opened three stores in two years — in New Delhi, Bengaluru and Mumbai.

NOTABLE GAPS

The shortage of high-end mall space has resulted in some notable gaps in India's luxury market. Several leading brands like Patek Philippe and Loro Piana, for example, have no physical stores in India.

Prada has no fashion stores and only one beauty store, while Chanel has just one fashion store and seven fragrance and beauty boutiques.

In China, by contrast, Prada has 14 fashion stores while Chanel has 18. It's not uncommon for some brands to have 40-50 stores in China, Louis Vuitton and Gucci among them.

HIGH CEILINGS

Even if a label is willing to forgo ultra-high-end spaces characterised by large column-free stores, high ceilings and ample parking, options remain limited.

India has only about 110 million sq ft of grade-A mall stock, compared with over 400 million in China and around 700 million in the US, said property consultancy Anarock.

Opening branded stores on high streets is not seen as an attractive business proposition, given Indian cities' problems with cleanliness and pollution. Because of the hurdles, some brands prefer to enter India through franchise agreements with the retail arms of conglomerates Reliance, Aditya Birla Group and Tata Group, which act as gateways to the market, providing store networks and capital.

Cleantech hiring up 57% in 2 years as capacity addition, AI drive demand

Rohan Das
Chennai

As India posts another record year of renewable capacity addition, the sector is seeing a significant uptick in job opportunities.

According to a report from CIEL HR Services, India's cleantech sector has seen a 57 per cent surge in hiring between November 2023 and November 2025.

Cleantech, as defined by the report, includes firms operating in industries like renewable energy, energy storage and efficiency, green transportation and carbon capture, among others.

Speaking to *businessline*, renewable energy firms say that the surge in hiring is being driven by scaling of capacity, alongside the integration of new-generation digital technologies across operations.

NEW CAPABILITIES

B Preetha, Vice-President, HR & Automation at Swelect Energy Systems, said she believes that beyond just the growth in the industry the hiring is driven by the need for a new set of capabilities that are indispensable.

She added that digital and AI capabilities are required both on the product side and other functions like marketing, energy forecasting, supply chain and improving operational efficiency. "Our hiring plans are considering the impact of these emerging technologies, ensuring it is integrated into our current operations and long-term strategy," she said.

Swelect has recorded a 30-35 per cent rise in high demand roles like design engineers, project managers, cell & module specialists, energy analysts, procurement specialists, she added.

HIGH DEMAND ROLES

Priyansh Mohan, Co-founder and CEO of Meine Electric, a start-up that manufactures iron-air based energy storage solutions, said that some high demand roles in the sector include product designers who work on the physical architecture of batteries and power electronic engineers who build the power conversion systems required for these systems.

Mohan added that the start-up had ramped up hiring significantly and the headcount had grown 75 per cent year-on-year as the company scales its operations.

Despite the scale up in hiring, executives noted that the sector faces a talent gap.

EARLY EXPOSURE

Mohan suggested that the ecosystem needs initiatives that lead to engineers gaining early exposure to battery chemistries, applied engineering techniques and advanced manufacturing.

Preetha also believed that upskilling is critical as the industry is moving towards newer innovations.

Meanwhile, the report mentions that since many firms in this sector are in a growth or scale-up phase, the median tenure of employees within the sector is about 2.7 years. "Employees are often hired for specific phases such as product development, or pilot execution and move on once these goals are met while the strong demand also encourages them to switch roles," it said. On compensation, it said that over 48 per cent of cleantech jobs fall in the salary bracket of above ₹10 lakh, suggesting a greater concentration of specialised, technically intensive and leadership roles.

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52 WH	52 WL	PE	BSE Cl
20 Microns [5]	151.67	140.72	150.01	150.92	137.61	257.21	284.10	139.00	8	141.20
360 One WAM	1002.10	977.40	998.00	998.90	969.80	602.54	1273.80	790.50	-	-
3i Infotech	13.61	13.50	13.61	13.80	13.35	1901.01	27.45	12.68	-	-
3M India	31790.00	30865.00	31785.00	31785.00	30710.00	3.53	38300.00	26800.05	106	30893.05
5PAISA	274.90	261.75	273.00	274.90	258.00	89.97	435.95	260.05	28	261.70
63 MoonsTe [2]	505.15	487.85	504.00	506.55	479.00	483.77	1130.00	479.00	53	487.90
A										
Aadhar Hsg	471.30	456.35	470.10	472.00	453.20	296.85	547.80	399.35	-	-
Aarey Drugs	61.96	55.90	61.19	62.42	55.77	144.24	100.00	32.85	-	-
Aaron Ind	130.26	119.69	130.26	130.26	116.85	55.25	478.00	116.85	-	-
Aarti Drugs	341.10	330.70	345.00	345.85	328.85	206.14	574.95	312.50	16	330.60
Aarti Ind [5]	431.25	417.40	426.25	428.75	412.35	1270.36	494.00	338.20	41	417.90
Aarti Pharm	639.00	608.85	636.00	636.00	602.50	397.02	971.00	574.45	-	-
Aavas	1135.50	1110.40	1121.00	1130.90	1096.60	297.83	2238.35	1060.80	14	1109.00
AB Capital	314.70	305.75	311.40	311.50	301.45	4796.03	369.25	169.55	27	305.75
AB InfraBuil	16.84	16.43	17.00	17.00	15.77	3582.56	224.98	15.77	-	-
AB Real Est	1167.80	1130.70	1167.80	1168.80	1104.00	565.08	2537.90	1080.10	-	-
AB Sun Life	939.80	902.95	928.00	928.00	888.45	312.48	1046.55	556.45	-	-
ABB [2]	6212.50	6105.00	6190.00	6190.00	5987.00	425.65	6555.00	4590.05	78	6106.70
ABB Powerpro	25670.00	24685.00	25500.00	25545.00	24500.00	187.46	26325.00	10400.00	-	-
Abbott (I)	26405.00	26135.00	26455.00	26555.00	25865.00	9.73	35921.55	25350.00	36	26155.40
ABFRL	58.85	57.05	58.65	58.90	56.25	9602.18	107.71	55.20	-	57.07
ABML [1]	108.62	102.45	108.69	108.69	101.00	89.39	207.35	101.60	11	103.10
ACC	1367.90	1314.40	1367.90	1367.90	1305.00	480.45	2123.30	1306.00	10	1314.30
ACCELYA	1142.30	1102.90	1137.00	1142.20	1097.00	24.88	1524.55	1100.00	14	1103.50
ACME Solar	254.12	269.41	254.12	274.00	251.16	12295.43	324.30	172.63	-	-
Action Cons [2]	818.70	780.70	812.00	812.00	777.15	414.92	1390.00	775.00	21	781.30
Acutaas Chem	2527.30	2545.00	2515.20	2561.40	2473.40	750.07	2580.00	1040.50	-	-
Adani Ent [1]	1886.60	1823.00	1880.00	1883.20	1816.50	2585.26	2612.75	1814.05	101	1822.85
Adani Green	853.80	832.50	850.45	850.45	825.90	2328.45	1179.20	767.00	186	832.45
Adani Ports [2]	1375.90	1337.80	1375.00	1375.00	1330.10	2667.31	1584.00	1041.05	155	1337.60
Adani Pwr [2]	153.65	153.92	153.50	155.28	151.56	23958.05	182.75	94.41	29	153.85
Adani T Gas	520.80	529.10	521.95	553.50	511.50	11384.74	798.00	462.80	-	-
Adani Wilm	182.85	185.40	184.00	187.95	180.53	5301.80	291.20	171.19	-	-
Adani.E.Sol	990.40	956.00	985.00	986.00	953.50	1357.13	1067.70	744.90	-	-
ADF Foods [2]	167.85	157.89	165.70	166.27	153.10	199.13	301.00	154.95	19	158.55
AdityaBirlaL	93.08	91.98	93.08	94.39	90.11	2192.57	175.00	90.00	-	-
AdityaInfote	1809.40	1826.00	1824.90	1889.90	1790.00	1116.74	1889.90	1015.00	-	-
AdityaVisi	480.35	489.20	480.00	493.00	470.00	454.02	598.70	327.60	-	-
AdorWelding	937.40	909.70	937.40	941.90	905.20	11.65	1260.00	788.00	-	-
Advait Ener	1762.40	1761.70	1750.10	1835.40	1715.50	83.56	1885.00	1351.00	-	-
Advance Agro	96.20	92.55	96.20	97.68	92.01	1403.25	154.00	87.76	-	-
Advent Hotel	145.27	135.46	143.00	144.87	131.20	540.49	345.05	131.20	-	-
Advenzymes [2]	274.50	265.90	268.10	273.00	260.90	200.93	366.55	259.70	24	265.35
Aegis Log [1]	611.75	612.00	609.70	616.50	603.60	496.32	946.50	576.00	33	611.65
Aegis VopakT	175.31	171.89	173.91	175.31	166.20	1359.25	302.00	166.20	-	-
Aequs	121.15	123.06	121.11	125.51	119.13	4068.15	165.40	113.30	-	-
Aeroflex Ind	251.38	240.57	247.00	253.97	239.34	1219.54	264.00	148.01	-	-
AeroflexEnt	68.51	66.49	68.21	68.48	66.05	376.57	113.90	62.20	-	-
Aether Ind	1158.55	1170.35	1151.80	1195.00	1126.50	595.04	1250.00	725.00	-	-
Afcons Infra	282.65	282.10	281.10	285.00	275.50	491.39	498.70	265.80	-	-
Affle [2]	1393.70	1446.10	1381.00	1460.00	1374.70	1158.96	2186.80	1221.05	160	1446.40
Afford Robo	141.82	131.51	140.00	141.26	130.00	149.84	534.40	130.00	-	-
Agarwal ind	372.55	377.70	370.65	384.00	366.00	148.33	1083.10	367.30	14	377.65
AGI Greenpac	510.05	492.05	509.05	512.00	486.65	710.80	1009.00	465.00	-	-
AGI Infra	302.85	294.55	302.00	303.20	291.00	1034.64	1408.00	224.70	-	-
Ahluwalia [2]	689.85	682.15	684.95	701.20	666.10	206.07	1129.20	666.05	17	683.50
AIA Engg [2]	3486.40	3458.40	3486.40	3525.00	3411.30	104.43	4200.00	3000.60	25	3446.50
Ajanta Pha [2]	2879.90	2807.90	2879.90	2919.90	2780.30	90.25	3158.20	2022.05	37	2821.45
Ajax Engg	461.45	426.05	469.25	469.45	421.15	306.68	756.20	421.15	-	-
Ajmera [2]	109.39	104.04	109.39	110.00	103.28	715.04	221.23	99.80	19	103.95
Akums Drugs	493.65	474.35	492.10	492.95	470.10	367.63	622.95	405.00	-	-
Akzo Ind	2925.10	2947.50	2929.90	2950.00	2858.60	50.66	3909.25	2649.05	36	2943.70
Albert david	648.75	609.20	648.20	653.15	600.60	44.33	959.35	601.00	36	607.75
ALEM PHAR [2]	694.15	673.55	694.00	694.15	666.00	710.45	1107.80	635.30	26	673.60
Alembic Ltd [2]	79.27	75.39	78.46	78.60	74.90	687.70	125.70	75.00	14	75.53
Algoquant Fi	53.32	50.86	53.32	53.32	49.11	1192.58	71.01	47.80	-	-
Alicon [5]	627.30	622.10	618.00	637.70	613.05	22.63	1024.95	541.00	26	624.30
AlivusLife	984.75	980.80	984.75	1025.00	973.10	148.00	1225.10	819.00	-	-
Alkem labs [2]	5435.50	5344.50	5401.00	5419.50	5259.00	145.05	5933.00	4627.90	29	5343.50
ALKYL AMIN [2]	1378.30	1292.50	1364.10	1364.10	1275.00	284.32	2448.80	1212.35	37	1291.35
Allcargo Ter	21.47	20.07	21.90	21.90	20.00	754.85	40.51	20.00	-	-
Alldigi Tech	761.75	718.45	766.00	766.00	715.60	36.36	1084.00	715.60	-	-
ALLIED DIGIT [5]	99.21	91.75	98.20	99.60	91.00	485.42	226.50	91.25	38	91.75
AlliedBlend	408.50	397.05	408.50	410.00	386.25	1388.01	696.80	279.00	-	-
AllTimePlas	204.84	196.69	201.77	204.01	195.01	168.38	334.90	195.00	-	-
Alm.Global [1]	13.45	12.43	13.80	13.80	12.35	338.33	27.76	12.40	-	12.46
Alok Ind	12.69	11.91	12.70	12.70	11.76	19919.65	23.50	11.76	-	-
Alphageo	188.88	176.53	183.40	192.89	175.10	49.73	296.95	175.00	-	177.50
Amagi Media	327.25	323.95	325.75	325.75	312.05	208.27	438.40	312.05	-	-
Amar.Raj.Enr	725.05	701.70	725.05	729.35	698.25	894.71	1109.00	698.25	-	-
Amber	6746.50	6602.00	6720.50	6720.50	6541.00	311.17	8625.00	5404.00	160	6598.05
AMBIKA COTTO	1229.40	1175.60	1220.00	1225.00	1170.00	14.94	1700.00	1100.60	11	1175.75
Ambuja Cem [2]	421.80	408.85	418.00	418.60	407.60	6114.06	625.00	394.00	28	408.95
Amrutanjan [1]	519.20	509.40	519.20	524.00	505.95	51.58	789.95	496.90	26	510.80
Anand RathiW	2992.70	3032.60	2975.00	3078.90	2962.50	195.67	3321.40	1600.00	-	-
AnandRathiS	458.15	438.75	460.00	460.00	434.90	551.09	794.85	431.00	-	-
Anant Raj [2]	455.75	437.30	453.50	453.50	434.40	3151.48	744.10	366.15	55	437.25
Anant Raj Gl	122.74	119.01	122.50	123.40	115.47	1356.02	206.10	112.25	-	-
Andhra Paper	61.57	59.01	60.95	62.09	58.07	545.41	90.00	58.07	-	-
Andhra Sug [2]	74.32	71.75	73.95	74.18	70.81	327.67	87.99	63.27	9	71.82
AngelOne	241.67	235.27	238.00	243.00	233.72	7528.58	3285.00	208.63	-	-
Anlon Health	116.17	115.91	116.63	117.70	114.48	197.07	172.75	90.78	-	-
AntelopusSel	518.30	530.10	522.85	552.50	508.50	365.18	767.95	357.00	-	-
AnthemBiosci	645.85	681.45	640.00	690.45	633.00	996.57	873.50	579.15	-	-
Antony W Hdg	420.60	400.60	420.00	420.80	398.15	178.08	693.00	398.15	-	-
Anup Engg	1714.80	1672.80	1679.30	1704.40	1635.10	78.95	3633.05	1422.30	-	-
Anupam Ras.	1267.00	1233.80	1255.50	1266.90	1220.20	284.93	1407.00	686.10	-	-
Apar Ind	10014.00	10608.00	9980.00	10798.00	9789.00	312.78	11641.75	4270.00	43	10589.10
Apcotex Ind [2]	350.50	331.20	345.90	350.35	325.30	40.43	443.35	290.05	21	332.15
Apex	396.25	377.55	390.00	393.70	375.30	367.97	486.10	190.50	38	377.40
APL Apollo [2]	1998.60	1986.20	1970.10	2012.00	1965.70	788.89	2300.90	1367.10	112	1985.70
APOLLO [1]	197.67	189.49	197.07	197.07	187.53	10347.07	354.65	101.05	69	189.40
Apollo Hosp. [5]	7580.50	7549.00	7510.00	7621.00	7510.00	533.51	8099.00	6432.10	75	7548.40
Apollo Pipes	414.50	428.20	415.40	432.00	406.40	1836.70	494.95	252.10	-	-
Apollo Tyres [1]	419.65	412.45	418.95	419.15	408.00	657.59	540.30	368.00	24	411.65
Aptech Ltd	76.09	73.29	76.00	77.66	71.20	911.29	182.40	71.20	20	73.84
Aptus V Hsg	207.25	197.78	206.51	206.51	196.74	5613.57	364.00	196.74	-	-
Archean Chem	602.00	608.40	590.50	617.45	576.15	307.40	727.60	480.00	-	-
Archidply	69.69	68.01	70.23	71.92	67.75	41.73	121.20	66.65	13	68.68
Arfin IndiaL	77.98	75.47	76.50	78.98	74.40	1350.01	84.90	31.43	-	-
ARIES AGRO	349.85	339.35	352.60	357.40	337.00	89.95	459.00	237.00	12	339.00
Arih Super	220.20	204.50	216.90	217.00	200.90	150.82	468.15	194.60	-	203.00
Arih.Capital	66.94	62.11	66.28	66.63	61.20	638.74	120.00	61.00	-	-
Arisinfra So	103.70	100.75	102.20	103.19	99.50	818.50	208.50	82.18	-	-
Arkade Dev	104.05	99.92	103.89	104.10	98.00	954.37	213.69	97.66	-	-
Arman Fin	1454.30	1406.80	1442.00	1465.10	1401.00	63.17	1849.95	1111.00	34	1405.65
Arrow green	414.40	386.85	414.05	414.05	383.10	65.28	816.15	342.00	13	385.90
Artemis Med	225.69	215.92	225.00	225.49	214.00	221.99	306.15	210.06	-	-
Arvind Fash [4]	399.95	382.45	394.15	398.00	378.00	261.94	579.05	338.00	-	382.65
Arvind Ltd	363.15	350.65	360.90	362.75	343.70	542.82	404.95	271.55	33	352.45
ArvindSmart	521.30	516.65	515.05	519.95	502.00	95.63	756.00	490.35	102	515.15
Asahi Ind. [1]	836.75	817.10	835.00	836.45	805.55	114.75	1072.95	579.25	69	813.75
Ashapura [2]	489.55	487.10	488.00	502.80	479.00	921.45	924.70	317.00	34	486.85
Ashiana ho [2]	299.40	289.30	297.00	298.00	286.60	58.74	374.00	248.75	24	289.50
Ashima	12.99	12.75	12.99	13.04	11.50	724.90	36.32	11.90	-	12.74
Ashok Leyl [1]	170.95	163.09	170.00	170.00	162.85	21631.70	215.35	95.20	26	163.00
Ashoka [5]	114.90	109.26	114.32	114.32	108.90	2196.28	230.70	105.55	15	109.25
Asian Energy	263.45	252.35	264.00	265.85	248.00	248.94	391.65	230.00	-	-
Asian granit	59.43	58.72	58.90	59.69	58.60	1534.05	78.78	39.58	-	58.81
Asian Paints [1]	2270.20	2207.40	2246.30	2269.00	2201.10	1089.01	2985.50	2116.00	53	2207.25
ASK Auto.	444.15	438.75	439.65	446.40	423.70	269.25	578.50	372.55	-	-
Asso Alcohol	726.00	686.95	726.00	726.95	683.00	97.01	1477.95	683.00	-	-
ASTECFE	623.50	579.80	618.00	625.80	561.15	680.78	990.87	512.35	-	583.85
ASTERDM	652.00	668.00	653.00	671.80	645.40	913.29	732.00	431.30	105	666.35
Astra Micro [2]	917.70	879.20	917.70	917.70	875.00	522.11	1195.65	629.45	56	879.65
Astral Poly [1]	1646.60	1619.10	1635.00	1653.90	1610.10	790.71	1767.95	1235.00	76	1620.55
Astrazeneca [2]	8415.00	7931.00	8400.50	8442.00	7806.50	62.98	10653.05	6501.60	95	7946.10
Atal RealTe	22.47	21.55	22.81	22.90	21.02	5335.90	29.20	12.71	-	-
AtherEnergy	776.65	796.35	772.80	802.90	759.05	4166.17	802.90	288.15	-	-
Atlanta Elec	1195.95	1238.65	1180.00	1263.00	1163.65	598.40	1277.00	707.60	-	-
ATUL AUTO [5]	415.35	400.75	412.20	414.05	395.30	151.70	554.20	381.70	24	401.35
ATUL.	6221.50	6240.00	6200.00	6261.00	6149.00	33.68	7793.00	4882.00	36	6236.40
AU SFB	910.40	882.75	900.00	907.90	877.25	3432.52	1038.75	498.05	29	883.10
Auri GrowInd	0.27	0.26	0.26	0.26	0.26	4663.86	1.00	0.20	-	-
Aurionpro So	795.25	764.30	795.25	795.25	755.10	228.80	1663.15	756.50	38	763.25
Aurob Pha [1]	1307.80	1314.20	1307.80	1327.00	1296.00	1923.75	1330.90	994.35	36	1313.75
Authum Inv	526.70	485.90	517.20	522.90	462.15	3386.64	3318.70	400.00	-	-
Auto Axles	1650.40	1585.40	1630.00	1642.10	1580.00	9.89	2125.95	1533.15	14	1580.15
AUTOIND	59.19	52.35	59.19	59.19	51.76	503.58	96.00	52.00	15	52.65
AUTOMOTIVE S	411.55	397.80	415.00	415.00	391.65	40.08	656.50	380.20	31	397.10
Avadh Sugar	453.80	453.10	456.10	487.10	449.10	455.80	586.35	307.75	12	453.15
Avalon Tech	970.00	963.10	958.00	973.90	940.00	173.51	1318.00	689.90	-	-
Avantel	130.09	124.12	129.76	129.76	123.35	2639.18	215.00	102.20	-	-
Avanti Feeds [1]	1263.40	1208.60	1263.10	1263.10	1200.00	338.51	1489.45	582.00	29	1210.50
AVG Logistic	158.36	148.75	159.80	159.80	145.35	105.61	339.90	130.00	-	-
Avonmore Cap	11.69	11.00	11.92	11.99	10.91	430.06	24.19	10.91	-	-
Awfis Space	252.40	254.25	249.00	258.85	237.65	876.93	718.95	237.65	-	-
Axis Bank [2]	1222.10	1205.20	1209.50	1213.50	1202.00	9479.30	1418.30	1032.45	15	1205.20
AXISCADES [5]	1397.30	1459.70	1393.00	1467.10	1381.00	488.60	1778.55	725.00	194	1465.15
Aye Finance	111.90	99.33	110.00	110.00	97.30	1016.10	149.50	98.00	-	100.05
Azad Engg	1473.20	1484.30	1527.30	1601.90	1476.00	1402.26	1899.00	1159.45	-	-
B										
Baazar Style	282.25	287.30	280.50	299.00	280.50	700.26	392.00	220.50	-	-
BAJAJ AUTO	9048.50	8901.00	8971.50	9004.00	8840.00	326.68	10186.60	7088.25	27	8902.70
Bajaj Cons [1]	360.00	350.10	360.00	364.55	347.35	355.63	408.65	153.00	28	350.00
Bajaj Elect [2]	361.45	351.20	359.50	366.20	348.00	172.36	710.00	335.50	87	351.95
Bajaj Fin [1]	882.75	843.80	875.00	875.15	841.25	11282.82	1102.45	788.40	33	844.35
Bajaj Finser [1]	1746.20	1694.70	1738.60	1738.60	1680.10	2522.24	2194.65	1660.05	191	1694.50
Bajaj HCare	313.90	300.70	312.30	312.30	298.00	226.10	744.00	273.25	-	-
Bajaj Hindus [1]	16.15	16.46	16.15	17.15	15.52	33711.11	29.62	14.89	-	16.50
Bajaj Holdng	9554.00	9150.00	9464.00	9531.00	9120.00	131.11	14873.20	9100.00	38	9149.15
Bajaj HouFin	79.13	75.85	79.00	79.00	75.00	37587.29	136.96	75.00	-	-
Bajel Proj.	152.59	144.42	152.00	152.47	143.00	780.96	263.90	137.25	-	-
Balaji Amine [2]	1059.50	1033.90	1040.00	1048.20	1016.00	121.50	1946.00	905.15	23	1032.25
Balaji Tele. [2]	79.89	76.01	79.05	79.90	73.80	1279.76	139.99	56.01	15	75.60
Balkrish Ind [2]	2207.80	2150.50	2174.80	2180.00	2117.00	132.80	2815.40	2016.00	32	2150.40
BalmerLawrie	162.16	157.41	161.89	161.89	156.92	292.17	238.00	156.05	11	157.60
BalramChini [1]	508.50	497.20	505.00	513.65	486.95	1349.06	627.00	393.40	24	496.60
Balu Forge	431.90	408.65	425.50	429.65	403.05	864.60	784.00	341.05	-	-
Ban.Amn.S [5]	19.50	18.20	19.60	19.60	18.02	485.45	38.00	17.55	8	18.15
Banco Prod [2]	560.75	531.65	555.00	556.55	525.00	208.28	879.60	305.00	22	528.95
Bandhan Bk	153.42	148.91	152.76	152.76	148.31	6274.12	192.45	134.30	24	148.70
[illegible]										

For BSE/NSE live quotes, scan the QR code or click the link https://bit.ly/2FpossK

CHENNAI
businessline.
SATURDAY - MARCH 28 - 2026

Company	Prev	Close	Open	High	Low	Qty	52 WH	52 WL	PE	BSE Cl
ZEN Tech [1]	1394.80	1356.20	1387.90	1387.90	1341.60	630.62	2268.15	1224.00	57	1353.60
Zensar Tech [2]	535.15	525.55	535.00	535.00	517.50	810.27	894.75	517.80	18	526.05
ZF Com VE	13592.00	13678.00	13451.00	14287.00	13326.00	28.86	16665.00	11900.10	-	-
Zinka Log	591.15	587.50	586.00	596.40	572.80	305.76	748.00	373.20	-	-
Zodia Enr	241.42	226.08	234.20	240.00	223.00	25.64	560.00	214.75	-	-
Zota Health	1130.80	1060.50	1130.00	1147.80	1052.00	114.02	1740.00	752.00	-	-
ZUARI	199.00	191.98	197.00	200.74	189.21	245.28	394.65	166.40	-	192.50
Zuari Ind	228.80	217.85	226.50	228.00	215.10	168.13	416.00	212.20	20	217.65
Zydus Life [1]	903.70	896.70	901.95	910.40	894.00	940.09	1059.00	797.05	19	896.60
Zydus Well [2]	457.95	446.10	451.00	462.00	433.85	1227.69	530.55	316.80	402	446.05

Exchange Traded Funds

Company	Pre Cl	NSE Cl	Vol	52 WH	52 WL	BSE Cl
360One AMCSi	225.97	215.23	222.07	358.00	78.40	-
360OneAMC Go	139.50	138.35	67.94	178.00	78.20	-
AONEAMC - AONETOTAL	10.83	10.62	462.19	12.51	9.63	-
AoneAMC-Liq	1052.31	1052.78	60.13	1060.00	908.58	-
AONEAMC-Nif	9.56	9.37	396.25	12.00	9.13	-
Axis Gold [1]	120.16	118.15	2504.61	149.95	68.00	118.14
AXISAMC - AXISVALUE	31.33	30.93	141.33	34.97	22.84	-
AXISAMC-AXISBNKETF	551.56	535.99	13.15	647.82	485.00	-
AXISAMC-AXISTECETF	325.14	323.24	8.10	439.67	310.10	-
AXISAMC-AXSENSEX	77.59	76.03	19.58	91.35	74.00	-
AXISAMC-Nift	255.64	251.48	51.46	296.38	236.80	-
BandhanGoldB	144.39	142.56	242.24	180.16	127.96	-
BARODABNP-BBNPPGOLD	138.65	137.60	12.21	184.05	82.00	-
BarodBNP-PNB	54.15	52.75	6.52	62.77	48.63	-
BFAM-BANKBETF	54.50	53.02	90.18	65.00	49.64	-
BFAM-NIFTYBETF	240.23	233.96	7.38	279.99	220.50	-
Birla Gold	126.01	125.28	896.75	155.86	75.01	125.35
Birla Nifty [1]	27.13	26.62	630.85	161.71	79.04	127.65
BIRLASLAMC-ABSLLIQUID	1000.00	1000.00	5.89	1044.99	999.99	-
BIRLASLAMC-ABSLPSE	10.10	10.01	225.84	11.60	8.00	-
Birlaslamc-B	54.80	53.45	3474.64	64.94	50.00	-
BIRLASLAMC-BSLSENETFG	75.53	74.51	6.68	87.82	64.38	-
BIRLASLAMC-HEALTHY	14.89	14.84	252.88	16.98	12.20	-
BIRLASLAMC-MOMENT	28.99	28.26	51.73	33.15	25.75	-
BIRLASLAMC-NIFTYQLITY	19.64	19.95	180.08	23.03	18.30	-
BIRLASLAMC-SILVER	228.46	220.56	3628.97	371.89	89.00	-
DSPAMC - BANK10ADD	16.08	15.69	6.44	16.94	15.38	-
DSPAMC - DSPBANK	54.82	53.29	3604.28	62.90	49.86	-
DSPAMC - TOP10ADD	86.46	84.98	7451.35	103.43	83.53	-
DSPAMC-HEALTHADD	146.87	145.60	24.15	155.90	129.94	-
DSPBRAMLiqu	1000.00	1000.00	94.59	1002.00	980.55	-
EDELAMC - EBANKNIFTY	54.07	52.77	2.68	69.39	47.00	-
EDELAMC - ECAPINSURE	22.24	21.89	189.69	26.77	17.13	-
EDELAMC-EBBETF0431	1387.92	1382.00	15.27	1410.12	1309.97	-
EDELAMC-EBBETF0433	1263.10	1266.89	11.50	1315.12	1199.25	-
EDELAMC-EGOLD	143.95	142.35	150.98	184.95	85.00	-
Gold BeEs [1]	119.29	117.53	58866.05	148.42	66.40	117.53
Goldmanamc - CPSEETF	100.51	100.38	1444.52	105.37	79.20	100.41
GrowwAMC Rea	7.74	7.63	263.49	11.30	7.31	-
GrowwAMC-Gol	14.08	13.83	4440.41	179.96	12.71	-
GrowwAMCMOM5	9.74	9.51	635.06	12.00	9.11	-
GrowwAMCNXT5	63.88	62.45	10.37	72.25	61.30	-
GrowwAMCVol	9.88	9.84	12.82	11.50	9.00	-
GrowwAmc-WEV	27.90	27.55	251.42	32.38	23.00	-
GrowwAMSC250	8.63	8.60	123.53	10.47	8.07	-
GrwowA-WCAPM	9.52	9.39	356.52	11.78	8.02	-
HangSengBees [1]	481.60	468.31	206.09	577.98	319.47	467.14
HDFC GOLD ETF	122.95	121.44	9319.41	152.30	70.10	-
HDFCAMC HDFCPSUBK	86.59	83.12	64.63	101.25	60.00	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCBSE500	34.45	33.81	48.68	39.55	31.14	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCGROWTH	111.90	110.79	11.99	133.30	103.11	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCLIQUID	1053.48	1053.94	10.27	1053.95	990.00	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCLOWVOL	19.40	19.16	7.95	23.00	17.92	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCSILVER	221.63	211.24	10103.81	359.00	85.67	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCSML250	150.63	148.32	4170.58	183.18	136.27	-
HDFCAMC-HDFCVALUE	126.47	124.89	47.32	147.05	117.50	-
HSBCAMC - HSBCGOLD	119.17	123.84	32.08	126.99	122.41	-
ICICI PR NIF LW VL 30 ETF	20.91	20.57	1136.82	26.81	19.03	-
ICICIPRA010G	258.70	258.50	0.00	265.36	244.59	-
ICICIPRAMBha	116.53	115.38	842.09	131.00	95.41	-
ICICIPRAMC - CASHIETF	1055.01	1055.44	449.15	1064.57	1001.71	-
ICICIPRAMC - EVIETF	27.95	27.91	329.34	33.75	23.56	-
ICICIPRAMC - METALIETF	11.38	11.22	7974.61	12.74	7.35	-
ICICIPRAMC - OILIETF	11.10	10.94	2992.74	14.00	9.46	-
ICICIPRAMC - TOP15IETF	9.63	9.42	96.00	11.33	9.22	-
ICICIPRUDNV20 ETF	13.69	13.54	478.86	16.00	11.20	-
ICICIPRUMIDCAPSE ETF	16.43	16.05	396.10	20.00	13.86	-
ICICIPRUNIFTY ETF	262.64	257.51	1651.90	328.24	234.97	-
ICICIPRUNIFTY100 ETF	26.54	26.13	525.32	30.88	23.85	-
IDFCAMC-NifE	253.49	251.13	1.30	340.80	235.01	-
Infra BeEs [1]	918.25	910.97	24.09	289.40	236.60	250.11
InvesIndGold [100]	12582.55	12345.40	0.48	15704.78	7670.00	12418.72
InvesInNifty	2660.00	2612.16	0.16	3150.00	2511.00	-
Kotak Nifty	256.35	251.94	613.01	320.00	238.25	-
Kotak PSU Bk	857.07	826.84	136.51	1010.00	585.31	-
KtakMAMC-Sil	22.42	21.47	9656.06	388.00	17.77	-
KtakMAMC-Vol	19.69	19.63	313.76	22.90	18.29	-
KtkMAMC-BKET	55.45	54.20	505.86	652.87	53.15	-
KtkMAMCMid50	16.40	15.48	1995.72	183.48	15.18	-
LIC MF-LIC GOLD ETF	129.15	127.65	139.07	16200.00	117.85	-
LICna-LICnfe	259.67	254.89	1.46	293.04	251.39	255.10
LICNAMC -CNFESGP	850.10	827.91	0.21	989.00	808.11	-
LICNAMC-LICNMFET	28.63	28.52	72.48	30.05	27.27	-
LICNAMC-LICNMID100	55.57	54.52	7.62	67.50	48.50	-
LICNAMCNFNHGP	260.04	255.58	0.73	296.41	242.47	-
Liquid BeEs [1000]	999.99	1000.00	4565.20	1004.99	994.00	1000.00
MIRAEAMC - BANKPSU	86.22	82.83	139.86	99.52	59.80	-
MIRAEAMC - CONSUMER	10.25	9.97	440.70	12.87	9.00	-
MIRAEAMC - DEFENCE	62.79	61.09	217.65	72.00	60.33	-
MIRAEAMC - DIVIDEND	34.14	33.90	14.89	38.03	33.15	-
MIRAEAMC-MAMFGETF	148.47	144.97	29.18	164.84	119.50	-
MIRAEAMC-MAN50ETF	251.89	246.72	1468.73	289.05	226.00	-
MIRAEAMC-MANV30F	194.74	191.63	4.42	219.10	180.04	-
MIRAEAMC-MANXT50	653.22	637.97	78.92	738.15	580.00	-
MIRAEAMC-MASPTOP50	69.45	68.96	191.08	73.13	40.86	-
MIRAEAMC-SENSEXETF	77.16	75.49	190.82	88.70	72.01	-
MotiAMCMOCap	45.31	44.13	508.30	51.13	30.98	-
MOTIAMC-MOHEALTH	43.32	42.49	38.88	47.57	37.96	-
MOTIAMC-MOLOWVOL	35.22	34.84	0.43	43.07	33.05	-
MOTIAMC-MOMOMEN	58.20	56.27	321.28	66.37	51.21	-
MOTIAMC-MONQ50	99.90	100.99	259.49	104.31	61.31	-
MotilAMCMODe	83.62	80.27	4776.85	102.00	61.70	-
MOTIOSMIDCAP100ETF	59.61	58.38	837.59	69.20	50.50	-
MOTIOSNASDAQ100ETF	236.18	231.73	1744.55	258.80	159.30	-
MOTIOSWALM50ETF	242.43	237.78	7.96	279.33	218.00	-
NiftyBeEs [1]	264.06	258.89	18765.90	298.77	243.89	258.95
NiftyJrBeEs [1]	686.24	671.06	862.63	763.62	620.83	671.83
NIPINDETFCONS	119.50	117.20	207.60	144.38	110.86	-
NIPINDETFDIVOPP	76.61	74.93	1553.63	87.09	68.30	-
NIPINDETFETFNV20	140.36	138.85	30.61	159.67	122.02	-
NIPINDETFIT	32.78	32.53	22548.55	44.27	31.25	-
NIPINDETFLONGTEGILT	29.11	29.09	3490.39	30.13	27.60	-
NIPINDETFMIDCAP150	211.18	205.50	14675.20	239.29	180.39	-
NIPINDETFNIFTY100	252.85	249.90	65.79	290.00	230.35	-
NippAMC-NePh	23.28	23.18	6184.80	26.52	19.47	-
NIPPONAMC -QGRWBEES	1032.85	1033.28	65.04	1056.29	995.55	-
NIPPONAM - MANUFGBEES	146.08	143.19	4.76	163.64	140.80	-
NIPPONAMC - SNXT30BEES	38.50	37.68	26.68	42.50	37.03	-
NIPPONAMC-NETFAUTO	257.97	250.45	362.96	299.92	197.07	-
NIPPONAMC-NETFSIL	221.42	212.50	62965.14	360.00	77.55	-
PSU Bk BeEs [1]	95.68	91.77	4384.46	110.34	65.28	91.88
Qgold [2]	119.34	117.65	94.10	147.09	69.80	117.75
Qnifty [1]	255.37	250.35	24.76	289.40	236.60	250.11
RELCAPAMC-NETFGILT5Y	64.08	63.88	798.10	66.31	60.01	-
RELCAPAMC-NETFSDL26	137.10	137.08	15.49	143.99	124.95	-
SBIAMC -QUIDSBI	1000.01	1000.00	14.59	1029.99	970.23	-
SBIAMC - SBIBPB	49.60	47.50	309.22	58.27	34.37	-
SBIAMC - SBILIQETF	1032.03	1032.46	285.14	1050.00	984.99	-
SBIAMC - SBIMIDMOM	57.41	56.24	40.64	60.97	54.09	-
SBIAMC - SBINEQWETF	31.04	30.49	433.66	35.00	27.30	-
SBIAMC - SBISILVER	226.83	218.01	3351.77	362.00	86.00	-
SBIAMC - SETF10GILT	257.46	257.40	36.58	266.10	248.01	-
SBIAMC-EQY	205.42	202.33	2.47	240.00	191.50	-
SBIAMC-SBIETFCON	110.93	108.42	7.49	133.97	100.00	-
SBIAMC-SBIETFIT	326.95	325.36	14.15	439.27	311.30	-
SBIAMC-SBIETFPB	257.60	254.92	7.37	304.58	245.48	-
SBI-ETF Gold	122.94	121.42	10065.49	153.95	64.96	-
SBI-ETF NIFTY 50	249.69	244.63	2853.45	287.33	227.33	-
SBI-ETF NIFTY BANK	549.20	537.24	524.89	646.11	465.64	-
SBI-ETFNN50	679.25	665.34	104.50	840.00	585.51	-
Sharia BeEs	452.21	447.88	5.93	529.39	437.32	448.70
Shriram LiqS	1097.37	1097.79	10.48	1097.81	1044.58	-
TataAML Gold	13.97	13.79	91559.84	17.70	7.14	-
TATAAML-NETF	251.80	248.58	6.74	292.90	227.05	-
TATAAML-NPBET	267.99	258.38	2.12	307.00	250.43	-
TataAMLSilv	22.40	21.50	102647.77	35.10	8.56	-
TATAAML-TNIDETF	78.70	77.56	116.24	103.26	75.04	-
UnionAMCGold	141.05	139.20	16.08	177.00	85.00	-
UTIAMC-BANKBETA	55.35	53.78	3688.17	73.70	48.74	-
UTIAMC-GILT10BETA	25.98	25.74	0.73	26.99	25.05	-
UTIAMC-GILT5BETA	64.28	64.70	2.03	66.43	60.40	-
UTIAMC-ITBETA	309.34	307.38	1.42	410.00	296.83	-
UTIAMC-MIDCAPBETA	206.38	202.01	46.73	235.48	178.10	-
UTIAMC-NEXT50BETA	68.65	66.89	305.64	79.10	60.20	-
UTIAMC-NIFTYBETA	256.89	251.70	320.47	297.48	235.00	-
UTIAMC-SENSEXBETA	829.80	812.24	11.18	952.91	779.95	-
UTIAMC-SILVERBETA	222.32	211.78	1492.61	379.66	85.08	-
UTIAMC-SNXT50BETA	84.21	83.08	6.35	102.25	75.74	-
UTIAMC-UTIGOLDBETA	121.00	119.70	1279.88	149.35	71.10	-
WEALTH - TWCGOLDETF	142.82	141.74	1.46	187.98	123.31	-
Zerod Mid150	10.19	9.99	15533.20	12.00	7.66	-
ZerodAMC-Liq	113.31	113.36	34451.88	113.37	102.00	-
ZerodAMSML10	8.98	8.88	3240.55	11.08	8.50	-
ZerodhaA-Gol	22.64	22.37	16189.15	27.94	12.83	-
ZerodhAMCGil	29.71	29.61	148.91	30.94	28.71	-
ZerodhAMCSil	23.33	22.36	17651.57	38.01	9.00	-
ZerodhAM-Nif	9.28	9.09	2434.90	10.97	8.94	-

*: Closing price is the average of trade price(s) for the last half an hour;52-Week High/Low figures pertain to BSE.

Shares of face value other than ₹10 is indicated in brackets immediately following the name of the company.

Qty (No of shares traded) is denoted in thousands.

The PE(price-earnings multiple) of each stock is based on the latest declared earnings.

The PE computation takes into account the per share earnings of each company for the latest 12 months.

BSE Stocks

NSE Trade for Trade

Company	Pr Cl	Cl	Company	Pr Cl	Cl	Company	Pr Cl	Cl
Best Agrolif	13.59	12.94	GEM Aromat	151.78	145.32	Take Sol [1]	38.09	38.85
BirdGroup	272.10	258.50	Izmo Ltd	679.30	648.30	Tirupati For	42.92	40.80
E2E Netwrk	2247.80	2135.50	REL INFRA	74.19	70.49	TVS SupplyCh	98.49	95.04
Embassy Dev	43.71	41.74	RIL COM V [5]	0.83	0.77	Zee Media [1]	7.36	7.00
GE Power Ind	411.25	404.35	SwanDef&Heav	1763.80	1676.60			